What The Storm Blew In

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35498947.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Dark and Stormy Night, Leather Jackets, Alternate Universe - Fantasy, Genderfluid Catra, Homosexuals, Nonbinary Catra (She-Ra), gay shit, Orcs, Alcohol, because it's at a bar, Leather Kink, sorta - Freeform, Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Idiots in Love, bros, It's Brightmoon but it's not, Fluff, Eventual Smut, Fluff and Smut, Butch Adora (She-Ra), Fluff and Humor, Punching, Drunkenness, Drunken fight, Sexual Tension, Mutual Pining, Cute, Queer Character, queer sex, Dirty Talk, Shit Talking During Sex, Consent, Impact Play, Masc4Masc, Butch4butch, Domestic Fluff, Nonbinary Adora (She-Ra)

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by Bluefromthemoon

Summary

Before she could open her mouth, she caught sight - no, connected with the most threatening pair of eyes she had ever seen in her life. Firey and glinting dangerously in the darkness of the noisy crowd were two eyes staring her down. One was a chilling, fierce blue like the icy slopes of the high north region; the other a wicked, fearsome amber, just like the coat of the wild beasts that lived in the deep woods. Adora didn't spook easily, but these eyes were downright terrifying.

———————

Adora leads a hard, bitter life, working the illegal nightshift at Brightmoon's harbor. On a particularly wretched night, Adora finds herself in the seediest of pubs to wallow in her pain. She is bitter as hell and aching for a fight when the perfect opportunity presents it's self....or does it?

Leathery homosexualty in a fantastical Brightmoon. Really, we just wanted a fic like this with a dark n' stormy night and GAY SHIT.
Catra is a masculine genderfluid queer magicat - I use they/them pronouns for them.
Adora is a butch genderfluid lesbian-type who might be described as a butch dyke, but but like…the lines are blurry. "Disaster lesbian" seemed like the best tag to use.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Champion of Humankind

Gods, did Adora hate the rain.

It was a cold, freezing night, full of thunderstorms and slashing rain that turned to sleet the second the sun set below the foggy horizon. That had been hours ago, and Adora had spent a tragically long evening working in the frigid, hopeless dark at the harbor, unloading the contraband products in the thick sea air and bitter wind. Enormous rusty chains screeched around her, barely doing their job to keep the old docks tethered to land. The waves slammed against the hull of the batterered, creaking ship she was stationed on, while the roaring wind violently rocked them to and fro. For hours, she tossed heavy pallets and barrels alongside the other poor souls whose lives had landed them in the vile circumstance of being tiny, nameless cogs in the wide reaching trafficking ring of Bright Moon's underground. They were stuck lugging whatever the hell was crammed in these barrels and boxes from massive ship to ricketty carts over and over, night after night. Many of her fellow lost soul co-workers were orcs. And oh, how Adora *despised* orcs.

They were the *worst.*

They had been toiling away in the wet gloom and salt spray when the lightning began, and from there on out, Adora wished and *prayed* that it would strike her dead on the spot; anything, *anything* to free her from one more moment of this wretched work with these wretched, smelly beings that rolled their eyes at her and called her a shrimp.

A shrimp.

A shrimp?!

Could believe it?

Gods, she was the biggest human she knew - she *towered* over her entire hometown, not to mention all the human patrons of the gritty pub she was currently sitting in, grumbling away, angrily slamming back the cheapest drinks her meager wages could buy. She raked a large, dirty hand through her closely cropped blonde hair, wincing when she touched the fresh scar on her chin. The wind had been ravaging her skin too, and it was dry and irritated, stinging withevery touch. She hit her knee on the bar - her stool was just too short for her, and now *everything* hurt.

Ah bugger.

So what if all the orcs were bigger than her - *the strongest person around* - and so what if they could each lift four barrels while she could only lift one. They were heavy enough, for crying out loud! What difference did it make!?

She could still beat anyone (a human, that is) in an arm-wrestling match, no doubt. She slammed her glass down on the ancient bar top, covered in gouges and deep scars of its own.

Fuck!

The journey to the pub had been treacherous as well. Adora had discovered yet *another* hole in her old boots when she stumbled on the wet cobblestones and slipped into a stinky puddle the size of a fish pond. The mist was too thick, the air too smokey, and she couldn't see a cursed thing so she kept bumping into everyone and everything at every fucking turn of the winding road. Too many cloaked figures floating around in the fog for her to keep track of. There was no street lighting in this grimy part of town, just sooty windows that lined the cramped, narrow alleyways to guide lost souls towards the tavern.

Stupid, cheap shoes. Built to last *my ass.*

Well, at least her jacket wasn’t the worthless shit that was sold these days. No, it was genuine dragon’s hide, sturdy and worn, darkened with dye and age. It was her armor - had been for all

these years- thick, protective, full of secret pockets, and an unbreakable zip that had protected her without fail. Grease, paint, knives - all had come up against this jacket, and it had stood strong. Soft and warm on the inside, strong and durable on the outside.

A large commotion erupted in the far corner of the tavern and Adora jerked to attention. It was a small place, packed to the brim with unsavory characters. There was a long, heavy bar top made from a solid cut of a huge tree, covered in years worth of knife points and spilt liquid. The dark boards of the walls made the room feel and dank cave, lit by mismatched glass oil lanterns that swung dangerously with each thunderclap. The pub was stocked with mysterious liqueurs and strange alcohols, lined up in homemade bottles on the wall behind the bar, lit by an eerie green lantern that cast an unnatural glow over the drinks. Potions, that's what they reminded her of.

Best not lose one's self in a place like this. Bodies had been uncovered in the back ally here; this was a real tough spot. Adora subtly checked behind her. She was tough as shit! Still, better to keep your wits about you *before* being attacked from behind. She had learned *that* the hard way, but was thankfully quick on her feet and handy with sharp objects.

She peered about. This had to be one of the more depressing, violent watering holes she had been to. Something about the heavy storm, and the unforgiving rain - not to mention her soaking feet - had put her in such an ominous mood that she was craving a place that could match it. She was wanting for a disgusting, vile establishment, and had found it in full.
At least it was warm. The air was humid and heavy from the shared body heat and the small crooked windows dripped with condensation.

She and the other patrons were practically bathing in a low cloud of etherial stinky mist that wound its way through the air, coming from the steady stream of pipe smoke produced by the group of hybrids gambling in the corner. The smell of the pub was an

absolutely rank mixture of spilled drinks from the hardest home-brewed liquor one could buy, the heavy scent of sweat from many humans and hybrids combined *(and orcs, can't forget those fuckers)* , and some unnamable odor that permeated this area of town. The space was lit by an assortment of oil lamps that were likely fueled by the cheapest tallow one could buy, a guarantee for a very peculiar fragrance . It would have been nauseating if it weren't for the dense, spicy aroma that wafted through the tiny vent from the kitchen of a neighboring restaurant, and the large bundle of herbs that the pub keeper burned throughout the night, likely to offset the acrid fumes of the bar's patrons in the first place.

Fucking orcs.

She gruffly gestured for the bar boy to refill her glass. He poured a long stream of green-tinted liquid into the chipped cup she was using before stomping off and cursing under his breath. She sipped, then winced at the acidic burn of her drink, nearly choking on the harsh sensation.

God, what had become of her life.

Adora shifted on her stool, feeling her leg muscles straining against the thick rough trousers she was wearing. Those too felt like armor - they could withstand most edges and surfaces that would slice most anyone's wardrobe to shreds and had protected her from all sorts of injuries, tonight included. She was so grateful, but all she really wanted was to take them off. The damn things were giving her a fierce rash at this point and she longed for the soft silky fabric she saw in rich shop windows. She would never come close to touching something that delectable, but she could dream, couldn't she?

Ah, but she shouldn't! That's what got her into this mess in the first place.

An icy blast of wind shook her out of her thoughts yet again, as the door of the pub slammed open and a fresh round of filth -

ahem - *patrons* staggered in from the cold.

More orcs, for god's sake?!

Couldn't the stars give her rest from the madness of her life for one, *single* night?!

A crowd around the door erupted in boisterous yells, screaming about nothing, shoving, and pushing for no apparent reason. *I swear, if someone doesn't close that damn door soon -*

Adora whipped around on her stool, about to yell at someone, *anyone* truly, to close the door. She half hoped that they would come at her for a fight - she was itching to beat someone to a pulp. Ideally an orc, but that may be wishful thinking based on her state of mind and physical capabilities.

Before she could open her mouth, she caught sight - no, *connected* with the most intense, threatening pair of eyes she had ever seen in her life. Firey and glinting dangerously in the darkness of the noisy crowd shown two eyes boring into hers. One was a chilling, fierce blue like the icy slopes of the high north region and looked just as deadly; the other a wicked, fearsome amber like the coat of the wild beasts that lived in the thickets of deep woods. Adora didn't spook easily, but these eyes were downright terrifying.

The owner of the eyes was looking right back at her, dead on, menacing as could be. Adora nearly toppled off her stool when she realize exactly *who* owned those eyes, because of course, it would have to be a *magicat.* Her *second* least favorite species.

Damn this night!

The magicat was short, sturdy and broad, with fur the color of rosewood, cheeks darkened with freckles. Their short, tightly cropped hair was a frothing sea, dark and brown as the fertile soil of Adora's home village, the kind that anything could grow in; that's why the harvest season was always so plentiful up in the mountains - it was the liveliest soil that ever was. Adora

swallowed a lump that had formed in her throat as she stared this nasty stranger down. It was a shame that Adora loved rosewood and the look of the plowed fields so much. The whole thing made her feel so unsteady, a confusing blend of threatening hate and deep, tender nostalgia.

The stranger rolled their stupid eyes. *Welp, no more time for nostalgia.* Adora set her jaw and rolled her eyes right back, cracking her neck and squaring her massive shoulders in a show of dominance. The stranger opened their mouth and *spat* on the floor, rolled their eyes *again* , and then—

— they were gone.

Adora blinked stupidly. *Where on earth?* They just clean disappeared into thin air. She scratched her head with a dirty nail. *Magicats!* The wiliest, sneakiest, meanest of them all.

Except for orcs , she mentally corrected. *They were the real worst ones.*

She turned back to the bar and huffed loudly while looking into her glass, reflecting on the misery that was her life; it was all horrid smells, uncomfortable stools, splinters from barrels, holes in her boots, slipping on mysterious piles of shit in the dark while she wound her way to the lowliest pubs in the city to drink her sorrows away. She let her head fall and took a deep breath, allowing herself a moment to acknowledge the bitter truth.

Poor, poor Adora.

Poor little old me.

Strayed so far from home, and now look where you are. Tsk, tsk.

Not a wee coin to my name, not a friend in sight

Poor – "Hey!!! You gonna sit there and cry all night, or are you gonna make some room for the rest of us?" A sharp voice drawled

in her ear. It was positively dripping with disgust and was far, far too close.

Un-believable.

Adora's head snapped up faster than a whip crack to face whoever the hell thought they could speak to her like that. *Sure,* she may have shed a tear or two into her cup of undrinkable alcohol, and *sure* she hadn't gotten a fresh drink in a bit longer than was acceptable, even for a place such as this. But none of this gave this little shit the right to speak to her like that!

And of course, *of course,* it was that offensive magicat with the devilish eyes and stupid fur the color of her favorite tree!

The little shit stared at Adora with the most unwholesome and scathing sneer that ever was, then spat on her shoe. Adora stood bolt upright, preparing the knock this sucker clean across the floor.

However.

Up close the magicat was a whole different package, which gave Adora pause before she unleashed a torrent of brilliant profanity to put this kitten in their place. The magicat was - *unfortunately* - fearfully muscular and clearly quite strong. Broad shoulders indeed, fists balled at their sides, hands encased in tight, fingerless gloves that revealed black nails. They were retracted of course, but Adora had witnessed first hand the fatality that razor-sharp claws of a magicat could inflict. She shuddered at the memory of having the misfortune of being a front-row audience member to a drunken brawl between an angry magicat and entitled, pompus human.

Hmmm.

Best not replicate the scenario.

This magicat was in an aggressive fighting stance, feet apart, tail lashing ominously, and strong sinewy leg muscles bulging against

the thick, black fabric of their pants. Their hands were actually quite large, which was also…unnerving in a peculiar way.

Adora swallowed yet another, suspicious lump in her throat.

“Psst. My eyes are up here.” Whispered a voice.

Adora’s gaze snapped up in embarrassment. The magicat was watching her smuggly, sneering happily, ears flicking inadvertently with each loud sound from the pub.

“Yeah.” Adora said gruffly, feeling quite stumped as to what the next appropriate move was. She had been aching for a fight but was feeling increasing like she wanted to keep her face intact this evening, no matter how self-destructive she had been earlier.

“Uhhh…” She started, then lost the trail of her thoughts - *which was actually not that unusual for her-* because the deeper she looked into the eyes of the magicat, the stranger she felt. So… odd. Unsteady. Memories were surfacing in her mind - *happy* ones, *fun* ones. Was she being enchanted? Oh dear. That would be very inconvenient for the amount of debt she was currently trying to work off. Or was she truly *this* drunk? Was she –

“Oh for fuck' s sake you giant oaf! Can you *please* move your drunk ass out of here?!” The magicat erupted, “ I didn’t hike my exhausted ass through the storm, all the way from the eastern warehouses just to wait on *you* to order a damn drink!” The magicat spat out. "Now move it!!"

A vicious little fucker.

Adora sputtered at this incredible rudeness and *complete* lack of social decorum. She was - yet again - opening her mouth to unleash a perfectly articulated retort - *yes, she could do it…on occasion* - when she froze.

Her eyes widened, looking at the being before her.

“You’re - you’re -”

“Yeah! I’m late for my date with a glass of the hardest drink in this joint because of *you!* I won’t say it again you big old –”

“No,” Adora said softly, in wonder. So gently that the magicat froze in alarm, bewildered as to why anyone in their right mind would start to whipser gently in a bar like *this* , “You’re wearing a jacket.”

The magicat looked down as if to check, then looked up at Adora, clearly preparing to congratulate her on being such an observant fuck, when their eyes widened too. A soft *oh* formed on their delicate lips. Adora did not like the fact that she noticed how delicate this magicat’s lips were, but that was beside the point.

“Your jacket is just like mine," Adora whispered in reverence, as if it were a secret too pure for this dirty pub, for this unbending, cruel world.

The magicat nodded quietly, a serene expression on their face, features suddenly gentle and peaceful. Handsome.

Adora silently chastised herself for calling this *rude, snarky, stupid* stranger handsome.

“It’s lovely,” the magicat whispered, eying Adora’s jacket.

“Yeah,” Adora muttered, “s-so is yours.”

It really was. Smaller than Adora’s, but just as mighty and thick, greasy and heavy, bearing the marks of a rough life and adventure. Stars, it was a beautiful sight to behold.

Adora swallowed another lump.

The magicat looked up at her again, eyes soft and luminous, and - *oh no* - gorgeous. *No, this could not be happening.*

“Catra.” The magicat said gently.

“B-beg your pardon.” Adora said dumbly.

“My name.” They said again.

“My name is Catra.”

Alley Cat

Chapter Summary

A few tags have been updated.
The chapter count is now 4 or 5 chapters.
Last chapter got a glow-up with more descriptive language.
Please do a reading if you want a better picture of this world of Brightmoon and the pub.

Drunken brawl ahead!
It might read as graphic for some people (not so much for me, but maybe I'm desensitized), so take care of yourself.

but don't despair...
The gays are moving forward with their idiot selves.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra.

Cat - ra.

Ca - tra.

Hmmm. Lovely name. Lovely jacket. Lovely eyes.

Adora begged her brain to stop saying these nice things about her jacket-mate.

"Oh..my name is Adora." She fumbled out, pulling her eyes from the jacket and up to Catra's face.

Catra immediately barked out sharp, unkind laughter.

"Adora?!" They said in disbelief " *That's* you're name!" It was a bit rude. Adora had feelings too! Despite what this unloving world seemed to think, she was quite sensitive!

“How on earth do you go about looking all tall and tough with a name like *that* ?!”

Alas, Adora was far too drunk to stop herself .

“Says the magicat with the word ‘cat’ in their name.” She huffed, towering above the little thing - *Catra* apparently.

Catra snapped and narrowed their eyes.

Uh oh.

“What did you just say?”

“Um…”

Quick as a flash, Adora found Catra’s strong, firm grip clamped down like a metal trap against the firm leather of Adora’s collar, yanking her to eye level.

“What did you just say?” Catra breathed in her face, “You think that just because you're a human,” they spat the word with contempt, “all high and mighty with pretty eyes and big shoulders you can just stomp all over the rest of us?!”

Adora looked on stupidly. Tragically, she had reached her limit a few drinks ago, she now realized, and was far too wobbly to keep this picture steady.

“J-just because you're a magicat with even prettier eyes doesn't mean you can…um. You can…um..”

Damit!

Think!

Catra's freckles looked darker, flushed, even though they hadn't had a drink, and Adora noticed their tail lashing a bit faster. Adora sighed internally. It was looking like her face might come out of this night with a few more scars after all.

"Pretty eyes have nothing to do with it!" Catra spat in Adora's face, eyes glowing brightly.

Did they? Adora wasn't sure. She sort of wanted to sit and think about it but her mind was just too fuzzy. Catra probably had thought about this particular issue, so maybe they could talk about their jackets and each other's pretty eyes for the evening instead of doing this. *Yeah.*

"Hey…" Adora tried, "how about I just buy you a drink and we forget about -"

Catra threw their head back and laughed. "Oh, that's rich! Just like a human would." They spat again, then whispered harshly, "Just like a human to throw an age-old insult in my face, then try to cover it up. Do you know how many times I've had that line of joke? TOO MANY!" Catra bellowed ferociously, then added darkly, " and I'll have you know, Catra is a very common name where I am from."

"Oh, sorry," Adora fumbled. The bar top was really digging into her ribs from the way Catra was pulling her down. They were incredibly strong, Adora would give them that.

"Well," she tried again,"could you maybe let go of me and -"

"Oh, we are far from done here, you idiotic, hairless ape." Catra took a heaving breath, " you're probably from the high hills - that's where the dumbest humans are from —"

Which was unfortunately the wrong thing to say to Adora on a night like this.

A night where she hated her life with every fiber of her being and regretted the day she turned her back on her home in search of glory, only to land herself here, years later, a failure. And now this little shit of a magicat had to stomp in here looking like her native woodlands and farms, wearing a rare jacket just like her own, only to hit her where it hurt the most.

Right in the tender wound of her battered heart.

Adora reacted reflexively and slammed her fist into the magicat's gut. It caught them both by surprise, and knocked the breath out of Catra who sprawled backwards onto the floor. Unfortunately, the vice-like grip on Adora's collar remained unbreakable and tight, so down Adora went, collapsing in a heap on her brand new enemy.

She gulped down another lump in her throat, preparing for the very real possibility of being dismembered on this stormy evening by a very insulted magicat. No matter what happened, there was really no going back.

"Ugghhh" Catra wheezed. They had drawn quite a crowd.

Adora immediately kicked into action- *as much as she drunkenly could* - and began task of trying to dislodge the death grip Catra had on her collar. Her efforts would best be described as flailing about on the floor, pawing at Catra's fist. Catra recovered instantly and yanked her back.

"You are so done for you piece of blonde shit, I've been hoping to get my claws a little dirty and you're perfect." They hissed

"YOU TWO! OUT!!" The pub keeper boomed from above them, leaping over the bar top with surprising agility for a lesser giant. "Break it up and leave, or take it somewhere else!" She stormed over, towering about them unsheathing a large, bronze dagger from a pouch on her belt, "if you don't, I'm shutting the bar down

for the night!" She yelled to the other customers, who immediately rushed Adora and Catra, shoving them out. "Make sure you just keep the alley clean!" The bar keeper screamed over the crowd. "Although the storm will probably work just fine." Adora heard her mumble as she slipped away.

Ah shit, so this was how her life was going to end.

Poor little me.

Adora was jostled along, Catra firmly attached to her collar and whispering the most terrifying threats in her ear as a mob of rowdy patrons moved them like a lost ship in the boiling sea. She could hear snippets of conversations around her, people placing bets on who would walk away from this fight alive. Another group was placing bets on how long Adora would last before her inevitable death. The crowd was joyous and boisterous, Catra was spitting in her face, and Adora just tried to stay upright and walk with her head held high (in a metaphorical sense, that is. A burly magicat hanging from her neck was something that not even she, champion of all humans, could withstand).

Finally, they were ejected into the cold outdoors and Adora felt her back slam against the freezing gray stone of the alley wall. Immediately they were drenched in a heavy downpour as a small crowd of onlookers cheered, egging the two of them on. Adora caught sight of Catra looking down at her gleefully, drawing a fist back in perfect form, and shooting their arm forward. Before she could even think to raise her hands, a large, thick fist connected with the side of Adora's head. She heard a crack. *Shit* . It stung and throbbed instantly.

Crack! The fist hit her again, and Adora could feel blood trickling down her cheek. Try as she might, she just could not get her hands to work!

A massive thunderclap made her yelp and jump, and she felt Catra flinch to; when Adora opened her eyes, she felt something firm and warm in her hand. Looking down, she found to her

complete surprise that her hands had moved on their own accord to grasp Catra's hips for steadying, one holding securely to Catra' belt. They had very strong hips, she noticed. An extremely tight ass too from what Adora could see from this angle; heat was pulsing through the think fabric, and a tiny fringe of soft fur was visible in the gap between their shirt and pants.

It was very soft to the touch.

Oops. She touched it before she knew it. She realized this a bit too late, brain struggling to catch up with the current events.

A growl brought her attention up to a very irritated, perplexed magicat.

"What the fuck do you think you're doing?!" Catra hissed, voice laced with venom. They had yanked Adora's face close again, their other hand gripping the side of Adora's head, thumb claw pressing into the soft flesh beneath Adora's throat, nearly breaking skin. *Greats moons,* Catra's hands were terrifyingly strong.

I really might die tonight.

Adora stared stupidly, the freezing rain pelting them from above, droplets spattering on the grey stone below them, beads of water rolling off their jackets as the crowd screamed, haggled, and bet. Catra's once-curly hair was plastered to their forehead and their brow creased in anger.

"You seem to be very," Adora struggled to find the words - her head was swimming from the impact of Catra's punch, not to mention the fact that her exhausting day and many drinks made speaking so difficult. Catra arched their eyebrows impatiently. By some miracle, this magicat was allowing her to speak, which was a welcomed alternative to getting her face slashed to bits and dying in a frigid alleyway behind a repulsive bar.

“You’re very… soft.” Adora whispered so the crowd couldn’t hear. Catra’s eyebrows went flat in irritation. “No, no, don’t worry. It’s a nice thing, very good.” Adora slurred, feeling compelled to reassure the magicat, who looked very conflicted. Adora didn't know why - *anyone should be proud to be that soft!*

Catra sighed in annoyance.

“Look” The enunciated carefully. Something had changed about them, the fight dwindling and draining from their stance. They still had Adora’s collar balled into their fist, and Adora still had her hands pressed into their hips. It felt like they had been there for an eternity, but how long was it? Ah, a mere few seconds.

“Focus on me, idiot,” Catra snapped. Adora locked her eyes on Catra’s lips so she wouldn’t miss a word.

“I don’t know what your problem is, or why you’ve been such a shit to me, but I’m really, *really* tired, and I just want a drink to forget the shit storm of my life. So can we cut this out?”

The lips stopped talking and Adora waited for more, taking note of how nice the lips looked.

“Hey!”

Adora’s eyes jerked up to Catra’s, then back down to their lips, then their eyes, lips, eyes, lips....

Catra’s eyes widened in surprise and narrowed.

“I see.” They said stoically.

“What do you see?” Adora asked in wonder. She only saw lips and eyes. *What on earth was Catra looking at, if it wasn’t lips and eyes?*

“I see that,” Catra leaned in closer. The crowed cheered, preparing for the final blow, “I see that you want to fuck me.”

Adora drew back in shock. “I said nothing of the sort.” *She hadn’t, had she?*

“Didn't have to, I can just tell.” Catra said snobility.

“I…uh….” Adora sputtered.

“I know you want to fuck me,” Catra said cruely, mouth twisting into a devilish grin “ and listen…if you do? You'll *never* forget it.”

Adora stared with wide eyes, heart pounding. Her thumb accidentally started moving and stroking the fur of Catra’s hip bone. Catra gave a low growl, pupils dilated and sneering down at Adora.

But they weren’t moving either.

“So what if I do?” Adora rasped out. It was *really* hard to talk and she felt that Catra owed her just a smidgen of breathing room here, but she decided to keep that to herself.

“Well,” Catra’s tone was frustratingly cruel, but Adora could feel Catra’s thumb on her throat begin to relent, instead changing to a gentle pressure and then a slow rub, as if trying to soothe an injury. Ironic, considering Catra had just almost punched Adora’s face in and was nearly strangling her.

“I guess,” their eyes glazed over, voice turning from growl to whisper and laced with curiosity, “ I guess this night might look a bit different.”
Silence hung between them.

“Kill her!!” Someone screamed.

“No! Not yet! Just a few minutes more!” Yelled another voice.

“No, do it now! I’m about to win!” Hollered another

Adora ignored them. She began to recognize a low grumble of disappointment starting in the crowd, and finally someone yelled

in exasperation, “Ah shits! All bets are off. Look at them! Wrong kind of party everyone! ” Angry cries erupted in protest as the back row got a clear look at the scene in the back ally, and accepted that this would not be ending in bloodshed.

She heard feet stomping back inside, griping about how much they needed the winnings to get out of debt, to finance a loan, to blah blah blah.

Catra held fast, eyes burning into Adora’s.

“Look,” they said nervously, “do you? Because if I let you go and you attack, I will make some of those betters happy by shredding you to the bone.”

Adora just oggled and shook her head, entranced by the feeling of Catra’s gentle thumb strokes. Such a sweet and soft touch - no one had touched her like that in a long time.

“And” Catra rushed out, Adora saw a flash of longing in their eyes, “ if - if you run away it’ll be even worse. I know where you work too.”

“How?” Asked a bewildered Adora, because truly, *how* ?

Catra shrugged. “ Just a hunch. And I happen to have extremely good sense of smell and know the scent of the western harbor. You know, underground magicat stuff.” They said proudly

Of course! Catra said they came from the eastern warehouses! The harbor was part of the same underground circuit.

“ I won’t run.” Adora said quickly. “I’m far too drunk,” she watched Catra’s ears droop subtly , “ and I really…like the looks of you.” Adora finished because, well, she did.

Catra’s ears perked up, and they slowly relaxed the grip on ador collar but didn’t fully release.

The rain spattered down on them, dripping down the wall Adora was pressed, but she didn't dare move. For one she was a bit scared, and two, she was completely mesmerized by Catra. They really were handsome - square jaw, thick fur across their cheeks and curling at the sides of their jaw into tufts and sideburns. Their eyes were truly brilliant and they looked stunning in that jacket. Adora was lost for words, but she found them.

"Does that mean…" she dared move her neck a bit forward, looking at Catra's lips. Catra smiled crookedly, and cocked her chin.

Adora surged forward and pounced.

The kiss was wet, hot, and delicious. Catra kissed back with just as much force, pulling Adora forward hungrily. Sparks flew. Catra's lips were so *soft;* their tongue swiped into Adora's mouth and swirled and sucked. Adoras hands flew from Catra's hips to their torso, yanking them forward, running up and down their sides and fisting handfuls of leather to use as handles. Catra groaned and relaxed, kissing her so hard it hurt. Adora's face was still bloody and throbbing but she didn't care any more. Catra was warm and fierce and Adora's felt higher than she had in ages.

A thunderclap made them both jump and pull apart.

"We should, ah, maybe go somewhere else?" Catra said gruffly but couldn't hide the hopefulness in their voice.

Adora was panting, nodding vigorously, which made Catra smile. "Yes, uh - my tab - my drinks - should close it."

She was trying to regain her footing on this moment, but everything felt so tippy.

Catra smiled brightly, so enthusiastic that it was downright cute, and rushed them inside with surprising speed. Catra was more excited than Adora thought, she realized, as they shoved people

aside, called to the bar keeper, then impatiently tapped their foot while frowning at how long the bill was taking, occasionally looking up and smiling at Adora and trying to remain nonchalant.

“Looks like you worked it out.” Spat the pub keeper, handing over a slip of paper with Adora’s total. Adora was fishing around in her pockets - *how on earth did they get so confusing* - but Catra was slamming their hand on the counter, paying in coins and sputtering, “well -hah! You know, misunderstandings happen. Here, this one’s on me.” And then to Adora’s greater astonishment, added a polite, “ sorry for the trouble we caused you this evening.”

The pub keeper grunted and rolled her eyes, but Adora saw the glimmer of amusement- “eh, not like I care, but it’s nice not to have blood on the stones once and while. Terribly hard to keep regulars when they keep taking each other out.” She stomped away, and Catra leapt into action. They grabbed Adora by the arm and dragged her towards the door. Hybrids, humans, and phantoms alike gave them dirty looks as they pased by, less so for the unmissable sexual tension between the, and more for creating a false betting stage and false hopes.

Ah, it was their own faults, blood thirsty lot that they were.

Catra thrust Adora out the front door under the decaying awning and hopped nimbly out behind her, bumping up against her side. “Where too?” they asked cheerily.

Chapter End Notes

Thoughts? Favorites?

What's up next for these two homos?

The Ethical Theif

Chapter Summary

> Enter: Smut!
> And consent. 😊
> Some shit-talking during sex because they are bad, bad queers. ;)
>
> Read accordingly.

"I um, I stay at a boarding house downtown," Adora muttered, embarrassed to be lodging in a trashy home at her age. Catra nodded sharply and rushed on without pause "Sounds good. I don't stay in one place at all, don't usually sleep in beds. Your's sounds like a dream."

Doesn't sleep in beds?

Where…where did they sleep if not in a bed!? Adora slept on the cold streets during her down and out times in the city, but Catra didn't seem like that! Catra was able to pay for Adora's drinks *and* leave a tip…it just didn't make sense. Adora had never met someone who was so eager to spend time with her since she'd been in Brightmoon unless they wanted something from her, and that was usually a bad sign.

She felt an uneasy suspicion that Catra had planned something that was more then just a roll in the hay - images of Adora waking up with all her possessions gone flashed in her mind, but before she could truly develop them into a full-fledged horror story, Catra was pushing her out into the stormy weather and tugging them along the tiny street towards Downtown Horde.

The sprawling metropolis of Brightmoon had naturally divided itself into small townships - or large neighborhoods really - and each had it's own central square, connected to the next by wandering streets and thoroughfares. The closer to the water the

less desirable property became, and trust, Adora's boarding house was in one of the sections of the city, closest to the harbor's edge. The houses were tall and leaned at dangerous angles, while other buildings were decrepit and abandoned, providing free housing for urban beasts and those in need of shelter - it all came at a cost of course, but anything beat sleeping outside during the storms of the season. The streets were in a constant state of disrepair, long forgotten on the city's endless to-do list, houses and warehouses simply left when their owners grew tired.

They wove through streets at a dizzying pace, Catra's tail flicking away - *so* alert, eyes wide, sniffing the air and looking everywhere. Adora didn't run into a single person or fall in a single puddle with Catra at her side - *ah* , to be a magicat with superior senses!

Adora thought wistfully of all the accidents she would've dodged had she had hearing, sight and smell like that.

"Where next?" Catra was asking. They were almost to the town's square.

"Oh, down harbor way then Moon Avenue, then —"

"Say no more, I can smell us the rest of the way there." Catra said as they hauled Adora forward with alarming strength.

The world flew by and before she knew it, they were standing outside the old boarding house. It was too tall for it's own good, stilted to one side, hodgepodge attachment built on at treacherous angles that threatened to collapse. Adora smiled nervously down at Catra, suddenly self conscious, but Catra showed no sign of judgment, just impatience to get out of the pouring rain. Adora pushed through the doors and hustled over the threshold, making a beeline for the stairs.

"Not so fast you!" Came the angry cry from the dark, and out stepped the ancient little man who ran the place

Ah shits.

"No guests! You know the rules!"

"What! It's just my pal! Just here to wait out the rain!" Adora cried.

Please, just this once.

"Heard that one before! Next thing you know everyone's purse is gone and I'm all out of oil!"

Adora was gearing up to argue, when Catra hurriedly stepped in. "No worries at all, I'll be fine out there," they said quickly to the housekeeper, then faced Adora, "don't worry about me mate, I'm good. Nice walking with you. I'll see you 'round." They gave Adora a soft punch on the shoulder, a quick nod and wink, and were gone in a flash, out the door into the torrential downpour.

What?

Adora stood frozen. Damn. She still was confused about what in the moon's name was happening but *stars* , if she hadn't gotten excited about taking Catra home. It was so new. It had been so long that she'd been with someone, and even longer since she'd felt a spark and *wanted* to be with anybody. And with a magicat! With the same jacket! She didn't usually go with the handsome, rugged types; mostly the ladies with longer hair, but this was… new.

Different.

And gone. It wasn't going to happen.

Adora trudged up the creaking stairs after giving the housekeeper a seething glare, wondering why on earth Catra walked off so quickly and easily after all the rush and excitement.

After dragging herself to the eighth story of the house, she wearily stepped into her small room, greeted by the old barren

walls and that leered at her. She lit the candle in a battered lamp she kept on the tiny desk by the window. Bah! She had seen closets that were bigger than this room.

The flame flickered as she shook off her jacket and hung it on a hook, where a small puddle of water began to drip onto the floor, then removed a little key to open the heavy padlock she had purchased after all her possessions had been stollen last season. It was inlaid with a decorative, spiraling design had cost her 3 weeks worth of wages, but was well worth the price. She stripped her sweaters off to her undershirt, kicked off her stupid stinking boots, and struggled out of her wet trousers, releasing a contented sigh with the new freedom. No matter how cold her room was, she was grateful for it.

She sank heavily on the bed, staring forlornly out the window. She was lonely. She was sad. Her face hurt. She thought she was about to have a good night, but then Catra left her at the last second. Stupid CAtra. She looked out the window. Two lights shone in the distance - a blue and a yellow - that brought the image of Catra's face flooding back. Adora shook her head, but no matter how hard she tried, she couldn't get rid of the vision. Fuck, she was pathetic.

"Hey," said the vision.

Adora jumped and screamed. Oh gods, she really was drunk. And the head injury probably didn't help at all.

"You gonna let me in?" The vision said while smirking. Slowly Adora realized that it wasn't a vision, and was in fact CAtra perched on the outside windowsill in the rain.

"Get in here" Adora leapt up and wrenched the window open, yanking Catra inside. "We're eight stories off the ground - what's wrong with you? You could fall and die out there!" Adora hissed while slamming the window shut against the wind.

Catra smiled loudly and flexed their claws, retracting them. "What can I say, I take risks. And magicats can climb most walls as well. You're smart to leave your windows locked." They winked.

Adora crossed her arms. Catra looked her up and down, appraisingly. Adora remembered that she was in nothing but her briefs and thin undershirt, and even those were wet and see-though.

"Care to sit?" Her voice was a few octaves too high and Catra grinned and nodded, lazily reclining on the chair in the corner and crossed their legs. Adora stepped towards them, tripped and staggered right onto their lap.

"Oh!" Catra yelped in surprise, looking closely at her, bringing their hand up to support her back. Adora could practically hear the gears turning in Catra's head as they furrowed their brow.

"You are…much more drunk then I thought." They said softly. "I'm sorry."

"S'fine!" Adora said merrily. She really liked sitting on Catra's lap, (so warm!) and placed a hand on their shoulder to push them against the chair. She leaned in and shoved her nose into the jacket, inhaling the familiar scent of dragons hide, woody oils and waterproofing waxes, and the spicy new scent of this mysterious creature that had appeared in her life. She shuddered in pleasure, then dove in for a kiss, but Catra quickly turned their head to dodge it.

"I - can't - we shouldn't."

"What?!" Adora was aghast - first running off, then rejection?

"You're too drunk - it's not right. I know, call me crazy - a thief with a moral code, but it's true. You are *really* drunk and I wouldn't want you to wake up with regrets. Lords, I already socked you hard enough. This would be the cake, wouldn't it?" Catra scoffed in self disgust, pinching the bridge of their nose. "I can't do that to you."

“I’m fine.” Adora chirped, then tipped backwards precariously . Catra caught her before she fell flat on her back. Catra cursed under their breath, saying something that sounded like *done it again* and *no good magicat,* which made Adora wonder why they would ever say a thing like that.

“I say we should put you in bed.” Catra was already lifting her and hauling her over to the small mattress. Ignoring Adora’s protests, they shoved her in, all but restraining her as they tucked the rough blanket’s up to her chin, and forced a canteen of water into Adora’s mouth.

“Drink. Now shush. Just go to sleep.” Catra said seriously, concern edging into their tone.

“But what about…. you know?” Adora whined. She really wanted to go now. But gods…she was so tired. Ah shit.

“Fucking me and never forgetting it?” Catra said with a smirk, “yeah, well,” they looked around in resignation , “I guess we won’t get to do that. Didn’t realize how far gone you were. ‘S’not fair at all. I’ve done enough damage as is. I’ll see you around then, Adora?” They said sadly.

Adora whimpered like a big baby. Catra was *really* soft and she wasn’t ready to let them go!

Ah! An idea!

She scooted over and patted the new space on her mattress. Catra’s eyes widened and they shook their head.

“Oh come on,” Adora chided, “no fucking, just sleeping. Besides, it’s cold out there and I’m cold and you’re very warm.”

Catra considered for a moment then, with surprising speed, stripped down to their briefs and leapt into the bed, burrowing down into the blankets and letting out a sigh. Adora was stunned.

“That was…uh, fast.”

Catra huffed and aggressively shoved their head into the crook of her neck, inhaling deeply.

“You’re warm," Adora said in surprise. Burning would have been an apt description. The image of Catra’s bare torso, thick with muscles and sinews, covered in light fur and scars was emblazoned on the backs of Adora’s eyelids - she was certain *she* would never forget *that.* And, Adora had been right- Catra’s ass was *fantastic*.

“Magicat thing. Now, go to sleep. You need some rest.” They commanded, then yawned widely, displaying their sharp incisors.

Adora didn’t need to be told twice. She closed her eyes and knocked out with a large arm thrown around her new bed fellow.

Hours later she awoke in the dark of the early morning. The moon shone through the window in a break from the storm.

Why was she so warm?

She looked down to see a fluff of fur. Ah, Catra. The starlight illuminated their face, which was pressed against Adora’s chest, peaceful and sweet. A low rumbling purr thrummed in the air while Catra gently kneaded the bedding. Their tail flicked lazily in their sleep.

Cute. Gorgeous.

Adora readjusted herself and dropped back into her dream.

Hours later, Adora woke up to a rough, methodical touch on her face. It stung a bit, but was oddly soothing to the swollen, angry tissue on her cheek. She cracked an eye to find Catra wide awake and licking the side of her head. They stopped in embarrassment.

“What…are you doing?”

Catra looked at her sheepishly. “Well, some asshole punched you in the face last night, so I thought I’d help you out. Magicat saliva is good for healing, you know?” They looked at the ceiling, then back at her, full of regret. “I’m sorry about those punches. I shouldn’t have done any of it. This should help.”

Adora smiled. “I shouldn’t have insulted you. Or punched you. It was impulse.” Catra shrugged.

“Stop. The faults’ on me Adora. But…why did you?”

“Something about home cuts real deep these days.”

“Oh.”

They let the silence hang.

Catra cautiously leaned up, opened their mouth, pausing to give Adora time to respond. She nodded and Catra resumed licking. The gentle pressure of the sandpapery tongue and careful motions truly did feel nice, so Adora lay back and closed her eyes, relaxing into yet another round of sleep.

She woke up the third and final time to Catra rustling around beside her.

“Hey.” They smiled up.

“Hey.” Adora smiled. Her face felt a lot better, but she had a dull throbbing headache.

Catra’s face was so close, their hand resting below Adora’s collar bone, flat against her chest as if to track a heartbeat.

“ Do you remember last night?” Catra said in a low, anxious voice.

Adora thought back. *Hmmmm* …terrible day, horrible bar, magicat with the same jacket, near-death fight, kissing in the rain, came home…Catra said no to sex…

"Yup!" Adora said cheerily.

"Is it, okay that I'm still here then?" Catra asked nervously

Adora frowned, wondering why it wouldn't be, and nodded.

"Do you want to….well?" Adora looked at Catra suggestively.

"I don't think…that's a good I idea." Catra muttered, looking at the wall pointedly and pulling their hand off Adora's chest quickly.

"What? Why?" Adora wasn't ashamed of the pleading tone in her voice because quite honestly, her mind had been changed about magicats in a big way. Catra's rippling muscles and tight, sturdy form - and the fur, my god! So soft and warm and just…of the earth, unlike the cold stones and stench of the city. It didn't hurt that their body reminded her of home, and they had a certain smell that she always found comforting. Their hands were big, which Adora liked too, and she was fairly certain that underneath the hard exterior, Catra was just as much of a cuddle monster as she was.

"Why?" She repeated. Because she *wanted* something real for the first time in ages.

"Look," Catra said hesitantly, and Adora realized that they didn't want her back, it was all a strange ruse, a slip of the moment, tempers too high and violent desire.

Catra continued, "Adora…I did something to you last night that was wrong. I said some horrible things- not sure if you remember really - and hurt you , plain and simple. I don't think you should want anything from someone who did that to you. And I manipulated you to let me stay here." They looked ashamed.

"No you didn't!" Adora said. *Had they manipulated her?*

Eh, who gives a shit? After everything that happened, was she really about to turn down a good time?

This was the first nice thing that had occurred in ages - someone in her bed, warm and close, someone who cared enough to pause and reflect on morals. She felt nurtured for the first time since she moved to the city, not to mention experiencing a deep attraction to a stranger. When had *that* happened to her last? Who cared if the circumstances that brought her here were pitiful? *She didn't* - she was done caring about the reasons. When a gift presented itself to her she took it now, even if the delivery was dubious.

Yeah, didn't matter.

Catra looked away anxiously, biting their lower lip in thought, which was unfortunately quite sexy.

"I just think you should think on it." Catra said finally.

"You know, if second thoughts or doubts come up. Just…give yourself that, okay?"

Adora groaned in exasperation. *Really?* How was this happening. This cat almost beats the shit out of her, seduces her, kisses her passionately, *then* has a crisis of ethics, crawls into her bed and purrs adorably, licks her wounds and then…just fucks out of here?

Catra was still watching her, a blush creeping across their face.

" *Fine,"* Adora groaned.

Catra just watched her silently, wide-eyed. Adora could feel Catra's heart rate picking up.

"What. Why are you acting so strangely. And why are your eyes so big?"

"I uh..." Catra's voice cracked, "I have a very sensitive sense of smell."

“I know this.” Adora was pissed.

They’d talked about Catra superior senses already.

“I can, um, smell…” Catra looked off, “you.”

We're in a bed together, stupid. Of course you can smell me.

But something about Catra’s blush, the way they held eye contact, kept looking at Adora’s mouth hungrily…Adora felt wet and warm.

“Ah.” She said in realization, “you can smell…my, um.”

“Yeah.” Catra’s voice was raspy, raw... sexy. *Shit*.

“Just…maybe…I could.” Adora was looking at Catra pleadingly.

Catra swallowed nervously. “Do what you’re comfortable with - *no* - we shouldn't’ you could still be drunk.”

“I’m fine.” Adora she didn’t care if this was wrong or regrettable, she had enough things to regret in her life so why not make one more on the list? Catra was already here, Adora was already rearing to go, Catra’s desire and hesitation was enough - what could the harm be? She was already so fucked in her life that a sliver of pleasure would be amazing.

Adora broke the silence

“Fucking kiss me,” She whispered harshly, and Catra’s mouth snapped shut. They scooted up, “you’re sure?” They whispered nervously as if it were a precious secret that might be overheard.

“Yes. It’s not a soul bond Catra, gods. This is the least you could do. ” Adora rolled her eyes and watched as Catra delicately leaned in and slowly pressed their lips to Adora’s. The first touch was warm, soft and wet. Catra pushed against Adora’s mouth gently and sweetly, savoring each touch. Adora felt a tingling shoot through her spine. This was so different than the kiss they shared last night, this was real and slow; Catra was taking their time.

Catra's tongue swiped against hers - the same tongue that had soothed her wounds a hours ago. They sighed, leaned forward, and Adora pulled them in, angling her head to allow for a new position, sliding her tongue around Catra's, exploring and tasting, warmth and heat flickering between them as heat pooled in Adora's abdomen and moisture flooded between her legs. She was hungrily stroking Catra's back, exploring the fur and muscles there, egging them on. *Gods, they were just so soft.* She felt up the muscle in between Catra's shoulder blades and she sucked hard on their lower lip, proud of the loud, uncouth moans that erupted. Whimpers and soft cries - and this was just *kissing.* A new wave of desire flooded her as she thought about all the sounds Catra would make if Adora fucked them - *really* fucked them hard. Did Catra like it hard? Or soft?

Adora grew dizzy just thinking about it, running her hands along Catra's muscular sides, up and down their scarred, bulging arms, gently fisting handfuls of dark fur. Such delicate moans for such a tough guy.

Catra was purring consistently now, tail lashing, panting a bit. Adora couldn't stop herself and ran a hand down her own belly and into her briefs, slid between her legs, fingers rubbing the moisture and slick. Catra panted "What are you - are you sure -"

Adora growled - *if this magicat asked her one more damn time if she was sure* - "Yeah, I'm sure."

"Okay, I'll just watch."

"Watch?"

"I'm serious Adora, I don't want this to be something to regret."

Really, she did not need a babysitter, but whatever.

"Is it okay if I...?"

Catra nodded tentatively, eyes locked on the spot where Adora's wrist was disappearing into her briefs, hand moving beneath the

fabric. She groaned, losing her fingers in the slick, the soft flesh, the thought of Catra *watching* and smelling her hungrily.

And Catra was. They were panting now, their hand was absentmindedly kneading Adora's belly, ears flicking, a low purr vibrating between their chests.

"Kiss me." Adora commanded and Catra's gaze snapped to hers and wordlessly crashed into her. It was a hard, ferocious kiss, and suddenly Catra's hands were roaming her body, groping and scratching. They grasped Adora shoulders and squeezed, broke apart and looked into Adora's eyes, asking for an order-

"Touch me, touch my chest," Adora panted and Catra dove in, kissing down Adoras neck, hands slipping under her shirt. Adora felt firm calloused fingers and soft fur sliding up her rib cage, leaving trails of heat and static. Strong fingers circled then pinched her nipples, twisting and fondling roughly. The air had grown hot, both of them were damp with sweat as rain poured outside and ran down the side of the house. Adora rubbed harder, slipping a finger inside and fucking herself.

"*Gahhh*." She groaned through clenched teeth. The heat and pressure built as Catra thrashed around her, tail whipping out of control. It was intoxicating and overwhelming and *obscenely* hot.

"Fuck you, you fucking sexy bastard," they growled, panting heavily, "you're so - *shit*, so hot!" They sounded aggressive, and Adora laughed, "Are you - *ahh* - are you mad about it?" Adora circled her clit furiously, muscles straining. Thunder and electricity was all she could think of. White hot, red hot - Catra's hands were everywhere, gliding over her abs, her chest, squeezing the thick muscles of her arms and kneading her all throughout. Adora would've felt embarrassed at how utterly desperate she was if it wasn't for the way Catra was clearly at the end of their own rope of self restraint, twisting and turning, and pressing down on Adora's body in the heat, feeling up her arms and chest and biting her neck. A pressure was building in her lower body, tension waiting to be released. *"Ahhh,* fuck!"

“Yes.” She heard Catra hissing in her ear, “fuck yeah you handsome piece of shit, fucking sexy fucker, do it.” Catra was nipping at her neck, then her chest, then panted the words “come, you gorgeous thing, *come.”* Their eyes were fiery, pupils blow to the maximum with hardly any visible color, and although Catra wasn’t actually doing the hard work, they were drenched with sweat and panting as heavily as Adora.

Adora felt a powerful shock, a rush and tingle, and a *flood* of energy and pleasure. She was flying

“Ahhhhh fuck…” she bit into the pillow, “ *fuckfuckfuckfuck* .” She bucked her hips, feeling Catra’s weight bearing down on her, Catra’s hips involuntarily grinding her side, breath hot in her ear, “yes, you dirty bastard, come.” Catra said in a frenzy, chest heaving, entire body shaking. Adora was fairly certain Catra was drooling at this point.

Adora panted, slowing her pace, letting the flood wash over her. Catra was watching her intensely, breathing heavily, stroking the side of Adora's face, massaging her softly. Adora let her eyes close as she gasped for air, and tipped her head back on the pillow in extant. “Ahhhhhhh, wow. Amazing.” She cracked and eye in Catra’s direction, “and no regrets.”

Catra flushed and looked away, hiding a smile. “Yet,” they said softly, thumbs moving down to massage Adora’s shoulders.

“You-you're really nice to watch,” they said, barely audible.

Adora chuckled, pushing the sweaty hair off her forehead. “Glad I could convince you to stay for this." She looked at Catra earnestly.

There wasn’t a trace of sarcasm and bravado in Catra’s tone.“Yeah. Me too. Thank you. Handsome.”

Adora blushed and readjusted her hand by her head.

Catra carefully lay down on top of Adora again, nesting into the crook of her arm, looking suddenly small and anxious. "Well, uh, I guess that was sort of a…"

"A fuck?" Adora asked "because if that's what you're going to say, than I need to tell you that it doesn't actually count in terms of what we're talking about."

"But that was a fuck," Catra began,

"Not the kind I was promised", Adora joked.

Catra grinned, "I can always go back on a promise, you know, especially when it comes to fucking. Anyone is allowed to change their mind,"

Adora looked down, "I - I know, I didn't mean to pressure you - "

Catra was smiling and shook their head, "I know what you were saying.I shouldn't have threatened you about hunting you down if you ran away last night. But it's true, that wasn't what I promised. And that is a promise I'll keep. If you'll let me. Maybe that's for…a different time."

Catra slowly brought their thumb up to rest on Adora's chin, then edged up to push into the plush of her lower lip. They watched, mesmerized, as Adora kissed the pad of their thumb and breathed onto it, letting it rest on the tips of her lips.

Adora loved moments like this. It had been so, *SO* long.

Catra was trying valiantly to appear smooth and suave, full of confidence and silk, and it was so *obvious,* even to Adora, the reigning prince of obliviousness, that Catra was giddy and hopeful as hell. Ears perking and eyes widening like a child, a now-consistent purr rumbling, and a pure and unguarded expression

while furiously kneading Adora's side. Their fur was still damp and curling from the sweaty heat.

Gods, so cute.

"Sure, I'd love that." Adora whispered, and she swore Catra glowed.

Catra got up, finally, having to go to work.

"Come back around, will you?" Adora said hopefully, propping herself up on the mattress as Catra dressed hastily.

"Maybe." Catra said coyly "Or this : same place same time?"

Adora grinned. For the first time since arriving to Brightmoon, she was looking forward to the rest of her day.

Moments later Catra slipped out the window and Adora watched them scale down the building at pace that put her heartbeat in her throat. They turned and waved as they hit the cobblestone street, smile glowing from eight stories down.

Ready

Chapter Summary

We're back.

Q: Did the author watch extremely queer porn before writing this chapter?
A: Yes, yes indeed. Crashpad, featuring some extremely butch genderfluid queer people in fact. (Read notes for more)

Some impact play, degrading name calling (requested by the character!), consent, and fluff. A bit excessive maybe…but enjoy 🤷 !

Proof read?
Hmmmmm...yes. But. Typos. Tell me if they are really bad.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's day crawled on after Catra left. Adora lay in bed in a blissful post-orgasm nap until her growling stomach forced her out of bed and down to the cheap foodstall across the street. She ate a monstrous portion of something that was fried - it made her stomach hurt but filled her up, good preparation for what was promising to be another icy evening.

The warmth and intimacy from the morning with Catra seemed to leave Adora mid-day as she trudged to the docks, an hour from sunset.

Of course, another storm rolled through. Adora hated every second of it, grumbling and cursing when she pinched her fingers between the cold metal of the boat's chains, stupid orcs taking up breathing room around her. Gods, they were just so *rude!* And…

orc- y! She couldn't wait for tonight. A flicker of blue or yellow would remind her of Catra – soon, *so soon,* she would get to see them, touch them, maybe even *taste* them! It made her shudder with excitement, a slight balm to the wind and rain that seemed intent on draining the life from her.

But.

At the bar, Catra never showed.

Bastard.

Adora waited one hour, then two, and by hour three she was cursing Catra's name, kicking out of the dirty pub and traipsing through the rain on the cold cobblestones, stepping in almost every puddle along the way.

She stomped up the stairs, body aching with every step, and threw herself into her room.

"Where were you?!?!" Catra flew at her from the dark, leaping from the bed, clearly furious. They were like a tree demon, the way they descended on her, scaring Adora halfway to the underworld.

"Oh, went to the pub without me?" Catra spat.

"Without *you* ?! I waited for *you* at the pub for three hours!" Adora roared back.

"Yeah, well I waited for *you* for *five* hours!" Catra spat

"Yeah, well that makes two of us!" Adora yelled, "Same place - same time! That's what I was going off of!"

“Yeah, I meant your room, *obviously* !” Catra screeched.

“Obvious? *How* !? We met each other at the pub!” Adora threw her hands out in exasperation,

“Why would we go to the shittiest pub when all we were going to do was come back here! For three hours at that?! Unless you didn’t want to see and had second thoughts?! Getting cold feet? Waiting at the pub until you knew I’d be gone?” Catra whirled around angrily, clearly hurt.

Idiot.

“No! That’s not why! Why are you so upset?” Adora spat.

“I’m mad at you! I wanted to spend time with you tonight!” They huffed.

“Me too!” Hollered Adora, growing hot under the layers of sweaters and leather with her dumb, soggy boots.

Silence.

“This is stupid.” Adora groaned, beyond agitated.

Catra looked at her, crestfallen. “What do you mean?” Their voice cracked, eyes suddenly panicked.

“This! This argument! It’s stupid. We’re mad about the same thing.” Adora huffed, “it was a misunderstanding.” Adora finished in irritation, shaking her head.

Catra looked relieved.

“What did you think I meant?”

“Oh, uh, nothing. That you didn’t want me here.” Catra scratched behind their ear, notably relieved.

“No- what? I - of course I want you here.” Adora grumbled.

Catra scoffed angrily and turned away. “Well you’re not acting like it.”

Adora rolled her eyes.

What a brat.

“Here.” Catra growled, angrily shoving a bag towards Adora while still somehow managing to have their back turned.

Adora rolled her eyes and grabbed the bag, opened it…

And…. *gods.*

What was inside was shocking.

Brand new boots. They were clearly well made, thick leather that extended high up the calf with tight double stitching and metal toe pieces. A beautiful rusty brown. They smelled of wax, and had a thick coat of sealant on for heavy rains. She turned the boots over in her hands, then peered inside to find two pairs of enormously thick socks stuffed down. Adora was stunned.

“Catra…I…that’s so thoughtful. Thank you.”

“Whatever.” Catra sneered. Adora noticed their tail flicking quickly, happily.

“Really, nice. I - no one’s ever done this for me.”

“S’nothing.” Catra huffed. Their tail was flicking faster now.

“Truly. “ Adora grinned.

“You’re an idiot.” Catra said flatly, although their tail was swishing furiously through the air.

Adora put the boots down on the table and admired them, then opened her arms as an invitation for a hug. Catra rolled their eyes but loosened their stance. After a long pause that involved a lot of exasperated sighs – *from Catra* – and tentative, encouraging smiles – *from Adora* – the two of them finally embraced. Adora felt Catra relax, although an edge of tension remained in their shoulders.

“Come to my bed.” Adora smiled hopefully.

“You’re too tired. Just go to sleep.” Catra sounded defeated and disappointed, which Adora could relate to. She still had no regrets from this morning, but had found a small shred of resentment towards Catra for leaving her at the bar for so long.

Catra was waiting for you here, she reminded herself. But it was hard to let it sink in, especially as she was still recovering from the well-aimed blows to her face.

She was exhausted and there was no way there would be any fucking tonight.

With that, it dawned on her that this very possibly could be the last time she saw the magicat.

“Come in here.” Adora invited as she slid under the covers.

Catra sighed and shoved their fists in their pockets, tail flicking in thought, then tore off their clothes with surprising speed and huffed under the blankets next to Adora.

Perfect.

Adora tried to put an arm around them desperately trying to replicate the cuddles from the morning, hoping for a tiny sliver of

the warmth and safety that had filled her with comfort, but Catra tossed and turned on the rough sheets, growing more agitated by the second.

Catra wasn't quite as comforting now - all claws and growls, which made Adora feel suddenly very alone. She had experienced a closeness for the first time in years, and now it seemed to have withered up and dried.

"I'm leaving, your bed is too uncomfortable." Catra was troubled and angry, suddenly up and walking towards their pile of clothes.

"You didn't have a problem last night." Adora hissed in a desperate attempt to make them stay.

"Well, I slept on you last night. Your mattress is shit, I hate it!"

"Well," Adora snapped, " sleep on *me* then!"

Adora hadn't even finished her sentence when Catra had wholly and completely scrambled on top of her as if the mattress was made of fire. They sighed happily and within a few minutes, had curled up and purred, then passed out.

Adora looked down at the small, burly figure in shock and pleasure.

What in the name of the moon was the deal with this magicat?

Why were they so prickly and cute?

So…strange.

Adora lay down flat on her back, feeling both touched and awkward and relaxed into sleep.

Adora woke up to Catra creeping out of bed, brown fur whispering against her skin.

"I need to go handsome," Catra winked, "work calls."

Adora rubbed her eyes sleepily, willing Catra to stay. They seemed much happier now, more like the version of them that wanted to care for Adora, not fight or argue.

"Come back tonight?"

Catra smiled happily and nodded, now bundled up in blue pants and heavy jacket, then leaned down and kissed Adora's forehead roughly. They gave her cheek and affectionate pinch before slipping quietly out the window.

Adora's day passed like many others - another long nap to prepare for the cold, then a meal at the food stall.

She wore her new boots that night and stayed shockingly dry, even as she stumbled into the many puddles to and from the docks. Stars, she was almost ready to go puddle-jumping with these things on! Walking was no longer a horrible activity!

Work was hard, but nowhere near as dreadful as it had been. She used the time to review the recent events in her life.

Where and how did Catra get these?

And *why!?* Did they actually like Adora?

They had spent the night twice, and both evenings had started off prickly, then ended so sweetly! She was more than ready to see them tonight - a warm bed was something she missed.

She walked home carefully in the dark, feeling tired but nowhere near as grumply. In her room, Adora cleaned the boots off meticulously, then oiled them with a small bottle that Catra had left her. She tidied her room and put out a few sprigs of Sweetherb on the table, a soft, wispy plant that was known to be soothing to magicats. She picked it out especially from an old magicat herbalist in a nicer part of town earlier today before work.

Catra never showed.

Adora grew worried and fought off the doubts of Catra's interest by looking at the boots, clearly an expensive, affectionate gift, and waited up as long as she could before she passed out.

She awoke to an empty bed and a soft drizzle outside. Her room was washed in gloomy, gray light that always reminded her of how dreary the city was, especially during this time of year.

There was a note smashed in the window. Adora shot out of bed.

Adora,

You locked your window last night. I got delayed at work. Being the ethical criminal I am, I chose not to pick the lock. Didn't want to cause a stir or terrify you. It looked like you needed to sleep. You were drooling.

Catra

Adora grinned as she penned a note back, sticking it on the inside of her window with the writing facing outwards, right where Catra would come up to read it.

Catra,

You have my full permission to pick the lock - even if I'm out. Just don't steal my stuff and sell it in the underground circuit. And wait for me to get home if you can, but you can always sleep here for a rest. That is as long as you don't steal my stuff. See above for details.

Adora.

Adora went to work feeling hopeful about Catra, wondering if they would be there, if a note would be stuffed in the window, if tonight was *the* night, if they would be late, if, if, if.... Her mind was buzzing with possibilities.

The warm socks and boots did incredible changes for her energy. She wouldn't say she was in a *great* mood at work, but she wasn't miserable. Which was a miracle of sorts, considering she was, quite literally, working on a rocking boat in a horrible thunderstorm.

She hunched her shoulders as she walked through the sleet after her shift was over, cold and excited when she made her way up the stairs to her room.

Not five minutes after she stepped over the threshold she heard a tapping at the window. She bounded over to where Catra was

crouched on the outdoor sill, winking at her.

Catra arrived that night with another gift.

They looked calm and collected when they entered through the window, save for the frantic movement of their tail and the glimmer in their eyes.

"I can't bare to sleep on that uncomfortable bed again." They scoffed.

Adora grinned, looking at the soft, plush, silky animal hide Catra was holding in their hands.

"It's incredible." Adora said in wonder, reaching out and petting it "but You don't sleep on the mattress - you sleep on *me* ." Adora smiled. Catra looked away, blushing heavily, tail flicking at the praise.

"Yeah, well, maybe I wanted you to be comfortable too." They muttered.

Adora grinned and stroked the fur on their hands. Catra's tail swished in wide, happy strokes.

They laid the hide on the mattress.

The day had been cold and they were both exhausted and there seemed to be a mutual agreement that tonight was not a night for fucking or sex. The two changed on opposite sides of the room in an odd spell of self-consciousness, sneaking peeks at eachother from behind.

Adora slid into bed, sighing in amazement - her bed was like a soft cloud! *Bless!*

She watched Catra lean over and sniff the Sweetherb that was still on the table. They whipped their tail happily.

Catra chuckled, then blew out the candle and slipped under the covers, twisting about, then settling on top of Adora and beginning to purr.

Adora nestled into the new, silky texture of her bed, comfortable for the first time in ages and at last warm from the constant chill.

“You still want to….?” Adora mumbled sleepily.

“Keep my promise?” Catra whispered back while nuzzling her under the chin, “yeah, don’t worry. All in good time.”

Adora smiled then slipped off into a heavy sleep.

Catra left in the morning, whispering to Adora that they would be back much earlier than usual, and that they would be… *ready.*

Adora’s day passed in a lusty haze - she slept as much as she could in effort to make it through work easily, then ate extra food.

The night at the harbor was - *blessedly* - cut short with a major shipping mishap. The orcs around her were furious , and really she should have been too as she would be missing a night's worth of wages, but she didn’t care at all this time. It was her lucky night!

She practically skipped home in the dark streets.

She found Catra already in her room, curled in a ball and sleeping on the end of the bed. They popped up in excitement when Adora walked in and leapt on her in an uncharacteristically openly sweet greeting. Adora laughed as Catra kissed her cheek. “Missed you.” Catra cleared their throat and climbed off her, looking away. “Yeah. me too.”

Adora shook off her work clothes and ran to the shared washroom to relieve herself and scrubbed her hands very, *very* clean with a

special antibacterial soap that the magicat herbalist also recommended. She was *ready.*

"You ready?" She faced Catra after slamming the door behind her.

Catra nodded, licking their lips. Adora watched as the fur on their cheeks rose, knowing that beneath their clothes, all of Catra's fur was on end. The air between them was humming. Catra swallowed audibly.

Adora walked over slowly, entire body expanding with excitement while watching Catra's tail lash in increasingly enthusiastic sweeps. They licked their lips again and balled their fists, pupils blown.

"How do you like it?" Adora asked once she stood in front of them.

"Messy. Hard. Mean" their stance was firm and challenging, then broke a bit, " B-but not too mean." They waved their hands awkwardly.

"What else?"

"I don't want to have to think any more. Maybe…call me things, tell me what to do."

"You trust me enough to do that?" Adora drew back, suddenly nervous.

Catra shrugged. "I trust you enough. I've been with some rogue people and have plenty of bad experiences under my belt. You're a bit different." They looked away, blushing, "I think you'll either be boring or… perfect. I don't care if it's another bad one - what's another at this point?" They scratched their neck.

They sighed in what looked like resignation, then turned, ”but I have a feeling I’m gonna get lucky with you.”

Adora’s chest puffed in pride.

Damn right Catra was about to get lucky - Adora was gonna give it to them like they’d never had it; she’d give them the fucking ride of their life – they’d wonder what the hell they’d been doing with all those losers before! Catra would never forget this!

“What about after?” Adora pressed

Catra cocked their head, thrown off guard. “A-after?”

“Yeah *after* , you know? How do you like it?”

“Oh – uh. Dunno. Usually I just leave.” Catra blushed and shrugged.

Adora was affronted. “Why?!”

“Well…that’s what they tell me to do. And well, we’re usually in like, an alleyway or something.” Catra hopped nervously.

“What do you *want* afterwards?”

Catra paused, then quietly muttered: “Soft stuff.”

Adora nodded. “Good.” She could definitely work with that.

Catra perked up at the affirmation.

“Oh! You’ll do that? I mean - you better do that!” They tried to cover the slip with nonchalance.

Adora smiled. “Yeah, I’ll do that.”

Catra blushed again, looking completely sexy, handsome, and adorable.

Adora sighed and smiled. “Okay then…ready?

“Ready.” Catra nodded, licking their lips.

The air seemed to spark between them, tension building and heat settling around their little corner of the world while a storm raged beyond the walls.

Adora slowly approached and stood in front of Catra, sizing them up, letting her eyes wander over the proud, sturdy magicat that boldly watched her right back. They were zipped up in that jacket, hair slicked back in perfect strokes and the tufts of their side burns curling with sweat, leading down to their sharp jawline. The fur on their face was clean and bristled like rich brown flames; the thick fur on their chest poked out of the top of their jacket along with the collar of a clean white shirt. They had their dark blue trousers on and tall, study black boots. Every time Adora had seen them, Catra always looked like they were ready to pounce with such an alert stance, dashing and agile, brave and fast - just thinking about it sent a thrill through Adora's core. She was going to get to touch that creature from head to toe to tail all night long. She shuddered with anticipation.

“You look…” Adora paused while she locked eyes with Catra, then glanced down at their lips, making a show of dragging her gaze up and down their body. “...delicious.” Catra released a heavy breath with the softest of whimpers and Adora smiled and looked down at them.

She settled her hands on Catra's shoulders, felt muscles tense and ripple beneath the leather, and she felt a vibrant heat flood through her veins like never before, awash in excitement and dark desire. Adora began to rub Catra’s broad shoulders softly, loosening and playing with them as a warm up, allowing them to acclimate to her touch, a greeting before they moved into a deeper sexual space. She took her time, savoring each flex of muscle that she felt, every soft breath and whimper that reached

her ears, the twitches and flicks of Catra's delicate ears. Adora bore down on them, locked in a smoldering gaze and admired the flash of blue and yellow eyes. She increased the motion to a rougher touch, moving Catra's shoulders from side to side and watched Catra's eyes roll back slightly. Catra went limp and a low purr began to rumble.

Adora firmed up her movements, applying heavy pressure, grabbing Catra's muscular shoulders through their jacket and rocking them back and forth in smooth motions. Catra's mouth had fallen open and they were breathing through their nose heavily, body supple and loose in Adora's grip.

"Punch?" They rasped out.

"Pardon?"

"Punch it."

"I'm sorry… what ?" Adora was baffled - was Catra speaking in code?

Catra grabbed Adora's hand, gently curled it into a fist, and brought it softly to their pectoral muscles, the flesh on their chest next to their shoulders.

"Like that."

"O-okay." Adora felt very young and incredibly inexperienced suddenly, which…was accurate. "Um, I've never done that before…"

Catra's eyes fluttered open as they emerged from a trance. "I'll show you how I like it." They finally croaked out. " Can I show it on you? I'll just be soft." Adora thought for a moment, then nodded.

Catra swayed then steadied themself and brought their hands up and gently rubbed Adora's upper chest on either side. "Right here, where it's fleshy." they whispered softly, "Always on the flesh, never over bone, and not where there are organs. Then I want you to make fists," Catra balled their hands into fists and held them up for Adora to see, "then bring them down with the flat part against me," Catra held their fists and softly hit them against Adora's chest in slow motion. Adora watched how the flat area of their fingers between the first and second knuckles came down against her jacket. "I like the impact." Catra said shyly, blushing. They flicked their tail curiously, brown fur shimmering in the candle light.

"Will you try it on me?" They asked quietly, hopeful.

Adora nodded and smiled tentatively but her stomach was in knots. She was admittedly terrified she would injure Catra, which would just be…the polar opposite of all her current goals.

"You're sure?" Adora mumbled nervously, looking at her shoes, "I don't want to hurt you. How strong do you like it?"

Catra nodded. "We start slow and lighter, then we get harder until the pressure is right." *Thank gods, Catra was in charge.* Adora nodded in relief.

She rubbed Catra's chest in the spot that they told her to, admiring the leather and heat she felt through the layers. She begane giving gentle slaps at Catra's guidance, then balled her fists and punched lightly with a satisfying *thump* .

"Harder."

thump .

"Harder."

thump .

"Harder."

thump .

“Harder,”

“Ahhhhh,” Catra gave the most sensual moan Adora had ever heard, eyes fluttering closed.

A fire roared to life in Adora’s chest with that raw, gravily sound.

If she was already ‘interested’ in Catra, well now she was *obsessed.* They were standing with their eyes closed, brow furrowed with a longing expression on their delicate features, completely uninhibited and submissive - fucking *gorgeous* and sexy and addicting. Smelling like spices and leather, body tight with muscles and covered in that deliciously soft fur - Catra was goddam a vision to behold and Adora was going to devour them tonight. *Fuck* , Adora was practically frothing at the mouth now, she needed to hear that raw, raspy voice dripping with sex and longing. *That moan,* gods, it was intoxicating, she was going to do everything in her power Catra make those sounds all night long.

“Good?” She asked, keeping her fists against Catra’s chest while they kept their eyes closed for a moment longer.

“Harder. Just a bit.” They panted out.

Adora punched a few more times at Catra’s request while they figured out the pressure, each *thump* resulted in a new sound, a whimper, sharp breath; Catra was moaning more now, tail flicking, eyes half-mast in a lusty daze.

Thump.

Thump.

Thump.

“Yessss,” they hissed as Adora brought her fists down repeatedly and moaned deeply, swaying with the impact, bracing their back against the wall for a moment.

Adora watched closely for any signs of discomfort or pain. “Good? Less? More?” She whispered softly.

Catra shook their head, looking almost drunk. “It’s gooood,” they moaned. Adora found a rhythm, alternating from side to side, finally moving together, flowing naturally.

Adora grabbed Catra’s jacket and fisted the leather in her hands, “Handsome,” She whispered harshly, then pushed Catra and brought her fists down heavily against their chest. Catra groaned louder, their cries sounded higher and a bit more desperate. *Thump. Thump. Thump.*

Adora began to sweat with the effort and watched Catra relax and breathe heavily, admiring their broad face frames with thick curls, the cute freckles that scattered across their cheeks and the way their nose would scrunch in excitement.

Adora hit them hard, and listened eagerly as a growl and purr erupted and rolled from their chest, louder than Adora had ever heard it. Catra began to pant.

“You like that?” Adora whispered in awe. Catra nodded and Adora slowly reached out to grab Catra by the collar, then pushed them up against the wall where they were panting and huffing, whimpering even. Adora leaned in for a quick kiss, pressing her lips against Catra’s and noticing their dryness from all the panting and licked them wet. They shared the same, hot breath as the rain thundered against the window, the sound of water rushing down the gutters and pipes a few strides away. A waterfall or desire, inside and out. The torrential downpour, the dripping, the heat, the *wet* - great sea gods, Adora felt feral and ravenous, mounsture flush between her own legs too.

Catra looked no better. They were hissing, purring, twitching, trying to readjust their pants, groping randomly at Adora’s belt.

“You're a mess,” Adora growled in a low voice, then shoved her nose into the space between Catra’s neck and jacket, smelling

their scent, the sweat, and their old worn jacket before she bit down on the sensitive flesh at the slope of their neck. Catra mewled, let out a startling whine then a gargle and Adora tightened her grip while Catra shuddered. Adora felt two strong legs wrap around her waist and pull her in.

She pulled her head up to whisper in Catra's ear, "desperate, are you?" Catra moaned loudly, too proud to say the words but fully aware of how needy they were. No shame - they knew Adora was on the verge of giving them the fuck of their life.

Adora yanked Catra's head into her chest, lacing the fingers of her other hand in Catra's hair and twisting just enough to get a whine. "You like that?" She whispered as she inhaled sharply. Catra simply moaned, nodding. Adora began to press their head into her upper chest, shoving their face into the leather, listening to Catra's moans, their hips trying to grind against her, their hands flying up and tugging at the waist of Adora's jacket.

"Yeah, you like that don't you," Adora murmured, shoving Catra harder into her leather, "you fucking like that you little shit, you want your face right there," Catra was heaving and moaning, little cries muffled by the heavy layers of fabric and hide. Adora lessened her pressure to give Catra the option to come up for air, but they growled and shoved themself forward, butting into Adora's chest. Adora resumed, and began whispering the filthiest things she could think of until Catra was nearly screaming into the jacket.

She pulled Catra's head back suddenly and looked straight down into their wide, hungry eyes. Catra was an absolute mess - pupils blown, eyes glazed, mouth open and panting desperately, a strand of saliva ran from their lips to the wet spot on the jacket they had made.

"Fuck," Adora hissed at them, "look at you, you fucking mess," Catra let out a gargle and mewl, clawing at Adora's waist, looking

for *something* . Adora held them tight, looking down seriously as Catra panted and shifted their hips for some simulation. Adora bent down close to their ear, and growled, then twisted Catra's hair until they cried out, high and pure. Adora guided Catra's head back to the front of her chest, maintaining complete control of Catra's movement, much like their first tousle in the rain.

"Lick it," she commanded, and Catra's breath hitched and stuttered. Adora slowly pulled Catra in by the collar of their jacket, supporting and controlling the movement with her other hand that was twisted in their hair, until Catra was just close enough to her front.

"Now." She whispered.

She watched Catra's eyes flutter shut and delicately open their mouth, stick out their tongue, then slowly lick a stripe across Adora's front pocket. Adora let out a low moan; it was Catra's soft expression, their beautiful tongue and the deliberateness of those small movements that were so sensual, and the rush of water outside the window. Adora felt big and powerful and completely enamored by this scruffy, tough, stubborn proud person who was so eagerly diving into submission. Adora wanted to fuck, care for, dominate, and please them beyond words - rub them up and down and luxuratie in the richness of this experience, in their soft, firm body. And fuck them senseless.

"Again," Adora panted, and Catra reached out and kissed her jacket, giving it another long, slow lick, leaving a trail of saliva and grinding their hips against Adora's hip bone. They licked slow tenderly, like they had Adora's wounds, occasionally resting their forehead against Adora's shoulder, panting, rubbing their face against her chest pocket. Adora mind flashed to a vision of those slow licks between her legs, Catra's handsome face pushed against her crotch, eyes lidded with desire and lathing their tongue through the slick.

"ahhhh," Catra gave a low, guttural groan, and Adora guided their head to the other side of her chest, where she pushed Catra's face

in and they resumed the soft, slow licks, opening their eyes and meeting Adora's gaze while they worked away. Their fidgeting had calmed as they entered a different rhythm now, a sensual, patient, absolutely dirty pattern, swirling their tongue around the snaps and eventually trying to reach Adora's collar. Adora was panting, a bead of sweat trailing down the side of her face, looking down in Catra's eyes, feeling their now-damp hair between her fingers, watching the small, pink tongue, the way their head bobbed up and down. The air was hot and heavy, charged and vibrating between them.

"Fuck," Adora muttered, "gorgeous motherfucker, I'm putting you down."

Adora gently lowered Catra to their feet while Catra kept their mouth against her jacket, moaning and groaning. Catra was limp and gave no resistance when Adora pulled them gently back by the hair and slowly turned them around to face the wall, pressing them firmly.

"Palms on the wall handsome," she commanded, Catra moaned and complied. Adora stood by their side, one arm wrapped around their torso beneath the arms to pull Catra close against her body. Adora laced her other hand in their hair, pushing their head forward.

"Breathe with me." She muttered into their ear, and the two of them stood still, taking heaving breaths in unison, feeling the stabilizing comforting presence of the other. Adora twisted Catra's hair once more, then trailed her hand down their leather-clad back, admiring the texture, yanking occasionally, stroking heavily and firmly, then finally creeping down to the small of their back above their tail and scratched. Catra gave an enormous moan, a cry almost, and Adora watched in awe and their tail fluffed instantly. She reached down and firmly grasped Catra's muscular ass cheek in her hand, admiring it's shape, squeezing, groping, them moving the the other one, growling into Catra's ears, whispering *your ass feels so good,* and listening to Catra's whimpers grow to a higher pitch, their purr rumbling away. Adora

squeezed Catra's ass once more and gave it a gentle slap, then wound her hand down between Catra's thighs, feeling them up from behind, caressing along the inseam of their trousers, then groping at their crotch. A moan ripped from Catra's throat and they shifted their legs further apart, panting, tail fluffed and lashing, claws extending and lightly beginning to scratch at the walls.

"Breeeathe," Adora whispered in their ear as she slowly unzipped Catra's jacket halfway and slid a hand inside, beginning to circle a hard nipple. Catra turned their head to the side to make eye contact glaring at her, eyes shifting to her lips, then back up. Adora leaned down and touched their lips together.

Adora's arm was snaked through Catra's legs behind their ass, and she gently began to apply upwards pressure on Catra's groin through the thick fabric. Adora gently lifted them off the ground from their crotch, arm wrapped around their torso for support, pulling them tight against her front, burying her face in their disheveled curls, kissing their temple, nipping at their sideburns while Catra took heaving breaths, their tail wrapping around Adora's wrist. Adora just held them there, securely, possessively, following some instinctual desire to hold tight, to claim and comfort all at once. Catra shuddered. Adora sniffed at their head, inhaling the scent, trying to mimic the way Catra treated her, then slowly maneuvered Catra to the side so their back was pressed against her front, her mouth giving above the scruff of their neck.

"Hmmm" she gave a low, satisfied hum, "you're such a good boy," Catra whimpered, hanging limp in Adora's arms.

"Can I bite you back here? On your scruff?" Catra let out a groan and nodded vigorously, pressing their head backwards.

"Eager little guy, aren't you?" Adora whispered. Catra whimpered. Adora gently lowered her head with Catra relaxed in her arms and opened her mouth, just breathing on the scruff of Catra's neck, then pressed her face into the soft warmth. Catra let out a moan laced with a heavy purr. Adora opened her mouth and gently bit,

and that's when she felt Catra shudder and stiffen, shake, grinding down on her hand and let out a soft deep groan, claws digging into the stucco walls.

They're coming. Adora thought in disbelief. Holy shit. She kept the pressure of her bite even, gently moving her hand across Catra's crotch through the thick pants and listened to the way Catra's breath caught in their throat and the soft swearing that tumbled out of their mouth. Catra relaxed slowly and Adora lowered them down lightly on the floor.

Catra exhaled softly as they melted against her.

Adora grabbed a canteen of water and tipped their head back, dribbling water in to their mouth - *fucking was always better when hydrated* - and Catra lapped it up.

Adora took a swig. Wordlessly Adora bent down and slowly released the liquid into Catra's open mouth, watching their throat bob as they swallowed. "Good boy," she muttered. Catra blinked slowly and smiled dumbly. Adora took another long drink, then let the water pass from her mouth into Catra's, letting her tongue swirl in the moisture between them.

She watched Catra drink from the canteen while she held them upright, then brought them over to the bed.

The two of them caught their breath, simply resting and kissing while Adora trailed her hands under their shirt and softly stroked their sides.

"Ready?" Adora asked hopefully.

Catra's eyes rolled back with a soft smile. "Ready."

Adora grinned, then grabbed Catra's belt and pulled them across the sheets, forcing them on their back. Their eyes were wide with surprise, hungry, but full of light and laughter.. Adora began to

kneel on the floor and massage Catra's thighs through the rough pants, caressing their knees and calves, reaching under to grab their ass, squeezing everywhere she could. She watched Catra grow more agitated and excited, twitching and twisted around on the mattress with anticipation. Finally, Adora slowed and brought her own head to rest in between Catra's legs, pressing against their crotch with her nose. Catra's eyes shimmered.

"What do you like to call this," she nuzzled Catra's groin, Catra caught their breath.

"My - *ah* - my front hole," they panted sheepishly

"Hmmmmm," Adora said, "good boy."

Catra let their head fall back in an open-mouthed sigh.

"May I?" Adora asked, hands toying with the buckle of Catra's belt. Catra panted out a soft " *Yes please"* .

"Watch me," Adora commanded as she slowly popped the buckle, making heavy eye contact. Catra looked glazed and messy, panting, purring, kneading the mattress, jacket half open, muscles straining against their tight shirt, and chest heaving as Adora pulled the thick leather belt out of it's loops. She slowly unbuttoned the metal snaps on Catra's pants, yanking them down until she was looking at Catra's briefs, which were, predictably soaked.

Adora slowly moved down to Catra's boots, undoing the laces, forcing Catra to wait. She threw the boots, then the socks in the corner, then began to yank down Catra's pants and finally set those on the chair, reveling in the excited sounds Catra was making. Adora pushed her face down into Catra's crotch next, breathing through their briefs, relishing the strong smell of their body, the heavy scent of sweat. She felt dirty and crazed, salacious, like she'd do anything for this magicat. Adora pressed down on Catra's hips with her hands, shoving them into the mattress, then began to work the briefs down.

“You’re fucking soaking,” Adora muttered, “staining my sheets you dirty thing.” Catra moaned and - to Adora’s surprise- panted a soft “ Sorry .”

Adora laughed, “You better be.”

She said in a hushed tone, “I’m gonna punish you for this,” she whispered, “I’m gonna fuck you so hard you’re gonna cry.”

Catra groaned loudly, tail lashing faster.

“You’ll come so hard, you’ll drench the floor, and then I’m gonna make you lick it off.”

Catra moaned again, louder this time. Adora was aware that this sexual storyline made no sense, but she was too in it, it was making Catra wild, so why stop?

Adore pulled Catra’s briefs all the way off and paused to run her hands up and down Catra’s hard thighs, all the way up to their hips. The fur on their belly was thick and rich, exposed from the way that their shirt and jacket had ridden up as Adora tousled them on the bed. The swath of fur trailed down from their belly button, down to another thick patch on the mound in their groin, ending in the opening between their legs. She looked at Catra, who was watching her, mesmerized and vulnerable, brown cheeks hot, hands gripping the mattress like a vice clamp, a bead of sweat running down their temple. Their legs were spread wide, held open by Adora’s film grip. Catra whimpered - sounding a bit nervous – which made sense; a tough, scrappy criminal who had to fight for their life didn’t usually spread wide open like this. This was a vulnerable position in many ways.

“Ahhh” Adora grinned, wanting to keep the anticipation but not scare Catra. “You look so good for me,” Catra moaned and Adora felt them relax. *Good* .

“So handsome, so bad,” she growled, leaning forward, bending down, breathing a hot breath on Catra’s abdomen, trailing a hand up and down their tight stomach, sliding under their shirt to tug at the fur. Catra drooled a bit, trying to suck the spit back into their mouth. “I can’t wait to taste you,” she hissed.

Adora buried her face in the fur on Catra’s stomach, inhaling again, rubbing her face in it, then drew down to the crux between Catra’s legs and growled. “Are you ready?” She asked, looking up at Catra for consent. They nodded vigorously, mouth open, panting with that perfect rasp.

Adora bent in, drew her mouth against Catra’s inner thighs, running her hands over them, caressing, swirling in the fur, and began to kiss her way up towards the center. She grabbed Catra hips firmly and slid their entire body to meet her mouth, flattening her tongue against Catra’s center and licking over their front hole, and slowly, with hard pressure, over their clit. They yelped when Adora completed the stroke, flexing and curling their toes. Adora grinned.

“On your hands and knees boy,” she said, and flipped Catra over, drawing them up on all fours, tail slashing in the air, ass facing Adora.

“What are you –”

Their breath caught as Adora knelt and shoved her face between their legs, licking at the soft folds from behind, sucking gently, pulling their hips to yank all their body weight back against Adora’s mouth.

“Fuuuckk,” Catra hissed.

Adora heard Catra mewl, high pitched cries and yelps as Adora licked away, rubbing the rest of Catra’s exposed body at a faster pace, groping at their thighs and calves. Adora finally pulled away, placed her hands on Catra’s hips and turned them over to look at the ruffled, wet, panting magicat before her, splayed out on the

bed, dazed and dizzy. Adora bent down and kissed them slowly, letting the pace slow down, giving both of them a needed moment to catch their breath. She kissed Catra gently, exploring their mouth, making the movement as soft and smooth as possible. Catra was groaning, giggled a bit, then cursed softly as Adora sucked at their lower lip before grabbing the canteen and putting it to Catra's lips.

"Okay you dirty boy," she murmured, "drink up." Catra did, gulping the water quickly. Adora sipped her own while locking eyes with Catra, who continued to inadvertently lick their lips.

Wordlessly Adora set the canteen down and bent down next to Catra's face. "You need a little more time?" Catra's hair was wet and damp with sweat looking like they had just run in the rain, little curls forming around their head like a halo.

"No," they huffed out, "I'm ready." Adora grinned slowly.

"Good," she bent down, holding eye contact and lathed her tongue over the front of Catra's jacket while reaching a hand down the cup their crotch. Catra gave a great, gutterall 'uhhhh' and clenched the sheets so hard Adora heard them rip. She licked the jack again, firmly, just like she did between Catra's legs, and felt her hand growing wet with slick as she began to move in slow circles.

A few more licks and Catra was blinking wildly. "Adora," they panted, "just…fuck me already."

Adora slowly stood, shaking out her legs. "Okay, you little bastard, you're ready?" Catra growled as if to say ' *yes* , *I told you that'* , and nodded. Adora stood and pulled Catra by an ankle until their ass was on the edge of the bed. Adora towered above them and moved her hand in a gentle circle, spreading Catra's slick through her fingers, listening to them breathe, then softly pushed a finger inside.

“More,” Catra hissed.

Another finger, and then another. “Good,” Catra hissed, and Adora began to move rhythmically in and out, testing and stretching.

“Another hand,” Catra groaned.

Oh shit . She had never done that before.

She reached down with her other hand and began to rub, then push tentatively pushed yet another finger inside. “Faster.” Catra ordered, suddenly bossy and desparate.

Adora obeyed and picked up the pace and fucked them with both hands, cocking her hip to keep Catra legs spread. They cried, mewled, and panted, tail lashing away with their claws sinking further into the bed. Adora lessened the pressure in concern.

“Am I hurting you -”

“Shut the fuck up and fuck me!” Catra bellowed.

“Oh - uh - I mean, okay I’ll -” Adora began to push harder, in and out.

“Deeper! Now!” Catra screeched at her, their whole body jerking with the force of Adora’s hands, *gods* , it was hot, but Adora was nervous - this seemed like a brutal pace! She was on the verge of asking once more – *just to be sure* – when Catra caught her eye and glared.

Ah, perhaps not.

Adora resumed, listening to Catra pant rhythmically, “Talk - to - me-” they said between the thrusts.

Adora stuttered. “ Uh - hello?”

“ *No* --” pant, “ *ah - i-idiot* ,” pant, “ *ah -ah-d-dirty.* ”

Oh, right. Adora got confused and lost track of her storyline.

Huh, where was she again?

Dirty talk….fuck….hmmm.

"Call me a slut!" Catra yelled angrily, "fucking shit! Now!"

"Oh!" Adora said in surprise. Her hands were obscenely wet, and also getting a bit tired at this point, but she squared her shoulders, gave her best sinister frown, and glared down at Catra. Ah, it was coming back to her now.

Catra truly was a mess to behold - dripping, sweating, panting, crying; one hand above their head was pressed flat into the wall to steady themself from knocking their head.

" Fuckfuckfuckfuck ," Catra yelled through clenched teeth. " Oh, shitting gods fuck me." It was Adora's duty to keep her hands at work, so she did.

"You slutty bastard ," she whispered harshly. Catra's eyes flew open and the words and snarled while purring, "Fuck- ah -yeah" they hissed.

Holy shit, this was the hottest thing in the entire fucking galaxy.

"You're just a hole," Adora growled, "you're just a hole and I'm filling you up." Catra threw their head back and moan-cried, hands slipping and knocking their head against the wall. Adora grabbed their ankles and hauled them back, never ceasing her thrusts, and dove back in. "My slut," Adora whispered and Catra's back arched. Hard, harder, deeper she went. Catra was babbling at increasing volume, egging Adora on.

Her arms were burning with the strain and pace. Just as she was about to request a break she felt Catra's entire body tighten and seize up. They released an absolutely vicious, lewd, dirty cry, and suddenly Adora's hands and wrists were awash in liquid, gushing over her.

Sweet gods!

Nothing like this had ever occurred in her whole life! She thought it was a thing of tales, but no! She looked down in wonder at the small pool forming on her floor, continuing to move her hands in and out, forgetting the soreness.

Catra was howling, *howling* , and Adora was positive the house keeper would come barreling in at any moment, so she figured she better make this moment last as long as possible.

“Ah!” Catra was writhing now (still going for goddess sake!), screeching, claws deep in the mattress and scratching at the wooden walls. Their body stayed tight and shuddering for longer than Adora thought was possible - was it one giant orgasm? *Was is five smushed into one?*

Adora kept moving until Catra released an enormous, final groan and let their legs fall. The two of them were silent.

“Should I pull out?” Adora asked softly. Catra groaned in affirmation, and Adora slowly withdrew her hands, listening to Catra’s contented sigh. She put her hands on Catra's thighs and squeezed encouragingly.

Catra looked a bit like a puddle - a furry, muscular puddle - that Adora undressed then tucked into bed after replacing the sheets. She poured more water into Catra’s mouth, rubbing their cheeks, whispering encouragement and sweet things, then fetched a small plate of dried meat she had bought the other day. After stripping down herself, she climbed into bed, pulling a limp Catra on top of her body and proceeded to feed them small bits of food as Adora squeezed their ass and rubbed their thighs.

Catra ate with their eyes closed, purring weakly while Adora chuckled.

“So cute” she muttered playfully and Catra punched her softly, grunting.

“I bet…you'll never forget this….” Catra mumbled before dropping off to sleep.

That was the truth.

“Yeah, I won’t. I hope you won't either.” Adora whispered into the dark.

Gifts kept appearing, even when Catra had to work through the time that they usually shared together. There would be weeks when Adora didn’t see them at all, but Catra managed to leave notes:

Handsome,

Our schedules don’t align. Might not for a few days. Miss you.

C

A,

I’ll be gone for a week or so. Don’t move to a different house. Or city. I will hunt you down. Or just leave a note.

And I better not smell another body on your bedsheets when I get back. I’ll be thinking of you, gorgeous asshole.

C

At times, the gifts rolled in when Catra arrived, or placed on Adora's bed after a long day of work. A thicker pillow. Cheap silk sheets (which were, quite literally, the softest fabric Adora had ever touched). Soft, heavy blankets that finally kept her warm even when Catra wasn't lying next to her (or on top of her). Warm socks. Thick gloves. A set of candles that smelled nice, an alternative to the stinking tallow. Waterproofing oils for her boots and gloves, and a thick salve to heal the crack skin on her face and knuckles.

"It's just because I want to sleep indoors, don't think you're special or anything." Catra said in a huff.

"Ah, you bring all your lovers gifts?"

"Yeah," they sneered sarcastically, "you're just the neediest one."

Adora laughed and tackled Catra into the now-soft, warm bed.

"Where do you get this stuff anyways?" Adora asked. Catra shrugged. "I have my sources. Old ladies, bargains, taking a few items here and there from drug lords. It counts that I haven't paid for boarding in years - being able to sleep in the rafters of wherever I can break into amounts to a lot over time."

"Nice." Adora said, happy to know where Catra had slept all these years at last, glad that it was *not* in the bed of many lovers.

Catra smiled. "And what better a way to spend it?" They muttered softly.

Chapter End Notes

> Okayyyy so a quick note on reality…because I feel obligated: For the sake of getting on with some smut writing I didn't want to get too dialogue heavy - BUT - please, for the love of god, be sure to ask a sexy partner if they want their hair pulled, what names they want to be called(also if someone is comfortable calling someone else something), and where they want to be touched. And like..,what they are comfy with.

Adora should have asked Catra what they meant by "mean/messy/hard" but…somehow she just knew because it's fanfic, and not real life!
But Adora did ask Catra what they likes to call their body parts, so like…yay!

What is Crashpad?
If you don't know it already, 'Crashpad' is a series of queer porn videos from Pink and White Productions, a production company run by queer BIPOC film makers! Crashpad episodes feature all sorts of queer performers, truly across gender/race/ability/body type/ sexual interest and practices. All super consensual and safer sex, the films also show interviews with the performers about how their experiences and anything they want to talk about. It truly is a bunch of films of real queers people having REAL sex…which can be super educational! Sometimes the production quality can be a little lackluster, but it's a great taste of sexual diversity in all the senses - check it out if you want to.

Ahem, anyways, open communication and negotiating a sexy time is very important please take this fic with a grain of salt (lol, if you weren't already!)!

Powder and Brimstone

Chapter Summary

The bois are faced with some shit.

Chapter Notes

I'm back!
this was supposed to be a short simple fic. Lol. There are more chapters and I got all involved in world building and character shit.

*Also I editted the sex scene from last chapter because it was FULL OF TYPOS!!Gahh! SO if you wanna read more sensual leathery scene with all the dirty fucking, go back and check it out.

ALSO SORT OF A SPOILER AND CW WARNING:
if you don't like reading these, feel free to skip - this feels a bit like a spoiler but i must warn.

I'll give CW for:
panic attack, a near death experience, and a big fire (as Californians we feel obligated to CW for fires because...well, shit. They're real)

With that, enjoy!

It had been one of those perfect mornings.

Well sort of. The house keeper had been snooping near Adora’s room a bit earlier after some suspicious…noise complaints.

Catra had stayed the night, which was a delicious treat since they had been a bit absent as of late - the warehouses seemed to be

extra busy, which made Adora nervous but Catra always came by whenever they could. They seemed to shower Adora with gifts these days, which Adora suspected was coming from a growing sense of guilt.

Things had been going well with Catra.

No.

Better than 'well' - they were great, shockingly great, which wasn't a word Adora ever expected to use again after she left home.

Everything about Catra was a sweet surprise.

AFter a long conversation the other night, both of them had confessed that upon leaving the bar the very first time, each expected this to be a one-time fuck, nothing more than sexual adventure. A new thing for Adora, being with a magicat (and, well, being intimate with another person in a few years). Catra revealed that they had been aching for some kind of release - a fight, a fuck - anything, when they laid eyes on Adora. She thought Catra had been glaring at her with hate, but it was actually something called … *cruising* .

Thats when you look for someone to fuck, Catra explained to a blushing Adora. She was shocked that Catra had even picked her out in the crowd and was even sizing her up as a love interest.

That first night alone seemed to have left Catra smitten, much to Adora's shock. "I just liked the way you kissed me," they grumbled shyly, "and then the way you tasted," they said as they touched Adora's lips, losing themself to the memory, "and *then* when I got into your room - *gods* - the way is *smelled.* I was done for." They blushed and rolled their eyes as Adora laughed. " *Really, on the first time?"* Adora was surprised - she thought Catra was always on the verge of leaving, but apparently - "I had my goals set on the first morning," Catra smiled warmly.

“It was so obvious you were a catch, and I don’t usual go for those. I wanted more then just a fuck when I licked your wounds - thats how you can tell with magicats - we don’t just fall asleep next to *anyone* and we definitely don’t go licking any random person’s wounds, even if we inflicted them.”

“So I’m special. You liked me from day one!” Adora said smugly.

Catra turned away and blushed horribly. “I…well. Maybe. Maybe I did.” they turned and smoothed Adora’s hair off her forehead. “Obviously I did,” they whispered, and kissed her, pressing hot lips against hers, “and then I just wanted to give you things - I wanted to spoil you. I didn’t just feel bad about hurting you - I wanted to take care of you and give to you,” the words tumbled out of Catra’s mouth in a whispered rush. Adora was silent - Catra had never opened up like this, spoken so freely and sweetly. It was always actions and gifts, but here were the explanations.

“Being with you has been one of the best things lately, Adora.” Adora’s mouth fell open.

“How ironic it started as a drunken brawl,” Adora giggled.

Catra glared - they were *still* embarrassed and ashamed about it, but Adora just found it funny,

“I mean, seriously, how lucky are we? Get in a fight, come out of it with a lovers?” Adora pressed on, Catra just shrank and pushed into her side and growled softly.

“It just could have been so…bad Adora.”

Adora nodded, trying to suppress laughter. “Anyways, you were saying that I am the best thing in your entire life?”

Catra rolled their eyes “I was saying that you were *one* of the best things in my life -”

"-wait, I *was* or I *am* -"

"Ugh! Adora!" Catra hissed and pinched her, earning a yelp,

"Obviously you *are,"* Catra flushed, which was just so cute when they were angry.

Adora smiled and wrapped her arms around Catra' thick shoulders.

"I just," Catra started and looked off to the side nervously, "I just never expected all this. I just thought it would be a quick - or long - fuck and then I would leave, or maybe you'd even let me sleep over, but instead…" they looked into the distance but ran a strong hand up and down Adora's ribcage, absentmindedly squeezing and caressing there, "instead I got something I've never had before." they looked up, "a friend, and -"

"A friend?!" Adora balked.

" -and," Catra glared, "someone more special than I could have imagined. I've never felt that in my life really."

Adora looked down in awe, that *she* , *Adora* got to be Catra's first.

It was sad really - Adora had grown up safe and warm, while Catra…well, she didn't know. The two of them were adults. That was a long time to wait before you got to feel safe and warm.

She was honored to occupy and provide this for Catra, and also surprised, it felt like Catra had known exactly how to do this the whole time.

Adora hadn't felt grounded and cared for like this since she moved to the city, and it was much different with her family. Catra was a loyal provider, and obviously they fucked (a lot), so Adora felt… connected. Like she had someone who would always look out for her, who cared about her, explained important things about the city, who checked to make sure she was warm and dry and ate

enough food - things that she had trouble taking care of despite the fact that she was competent enough to find and rent a room. It was just the other tasks that were so hard.

Their… relationship (or whatever it was) had been going on surprisingly smoothly. Etheria's fastest moon had been full 3 times since they met at the bar, and Catra was still here. It was consistent, even though their schedules would pull them apart.

Was this…was this *courtship?* Was this like those love poems that bards spoke of? Adora closed her eyes and smiled. It was! Catra was practically courting her. The gifts, the notes - goddess, they even came to her window at night. Which was more out of necessity, but still! Adora was the star in her own love poem, in Brightmoon city no less!

Catra was currently curled up at Adora's side, one hand stroking Adora's belly and kneading softly, the other encircling her, wrapped around her back. Catra was purring at the rain poured down outside. Adora leaned over and pressed a kiss on the top of their head.

She gave a frustrated sigh. "I should start to get up and get ready for work. There's an earlier shift today." The rain looked horrid and freezing and downright ugly. *Fuck,* she was going to go out and work in that.

Catra stiffened immediately, which was much different than their usual grumbling about being left alone in bed.

They grabbed her tightly. "I don't want you to go," they whispered nervously.

What?!

"Wha - why?" Adora was stunned.

“It’s not…it’s not safe. I just don’t want you to.” Catra mumbled.

“Catra…what’s this about?”

“The warehouses…shipments are coming in and they just don’t look right. We opened a crate once and inside it were the regular goods - you know, normal illegal things, alongside explosives.”

Adora shrugged, she didn’t follow. “Weapons are shipped *all the time.* ”

“But these explosives, Adora, they just weren’t packed right!” Catra’s voice rose, “They looked sloppy and everything was too close. Tt could just blow up!” Their eyes went wide in realization, “The fire…” they whispered,

“What fire?

“There was a fire a few days ago.” They whispered.

“What?! Why didn’t you tell me!” Adora panicked at the thought of a raging fire so close to Catra.

“It - it wasn’t like that! It happened outside at night - we all assumed that someone had thrown the butt of their cigar on the crate and it lit up - no one got hurt, it just seemed so normal. But now…I think it came from inside the crate.” Catra shuddered and nuzzled closer.

Adora didn’t really get why this mattered for *her* work.

“Adora! You throw barrels and crates around all night. *Throw them!* That is *bad* for explosives that aren’t packed right!” Catra hissed in exasperation, panicked and flexing their claws in the air. Their pupils were very, *very* small, just tiny slits, and their hair was standing on end.

“Hey, hey,” Adora hushed, “ it’s okay, I’ll be careful -”

“That doesn’t matter,” Catra’s voice cracked, “it doesn’t matter if you’re careful. Someone else won’t be and then you’ll still get blown up!” Catra wailed, now in a full on spiral. “Don’t go! It’s be bad - I can just feel it!”

Adora sighed. Catra was being so dramatic. Adora needed to go to work - she had to pay for this room, eat, and if she stopped going it would interfere with her big plan… It was *almost* ready too, and then she could tell Catra about it at last.

“I can’t.” She said gently. “I need to work -”

“No! You don’t! I’ll pay for your room, I’ll help you! Just, please, don’t go!” Catra said forcefully.

“Catra no!” Adora huffed back in irritation.

“Yes! Just…at least for a few days! Or just, do some other work - I’ll go halfway with you on the room, I don’t care. You’re in harm’s way!”

what in gods name was happening here?!

“No Catra I need the money!” Adora felt defensive, an assault on her independence, “ You don’t understand, I need to make that money so in order to move out -”

She clapped her hand over her mouth. *Shit.*

Catra’s eyes widened in surprise.

The two of them lay frozen in the bed, Adora with her hand over her mouth trying to will the words away, and Catra with their mouth forming and *oh* , tears welling up in their eyes. Betrayal, hurt, terror flashed across their face and a strange growl came from inside.

“I - *ah* - what?” They finally sputtered, shrinking away. “You *what?”* they found their words at last, spitting in disdain. “You’re - you're *moving* and you weren’t going to tell me?!” They snarled, and Adora watched a rush of heat and anger flow through their body, rising up.

“You - I can’t believe you!” their voice cracked as they struggled out of the blankets. “I - this whole time?”

Adora found her brain again, “Catra no, listen.”

“Listen? Listen!? No, Adora, you listen to me! I’m over here trying to keep you safe from idiots who pack explosives, trying to keep you from getting blown up, and you’re here planning to *move away* without telling me? *Keeping it a secret on purpose in fact?!”* Catra huffed and shuddered, a tear dropping from their eye. They were so disoriented that they were stuck in the blankets, trying to get away from Adora while simultaneously drawing near in anger. It looked like they had forgotten how to move.

They must be really upset if that’s what's happening. Catra never lost their balance and here they were now, forgetting how to move their legs.

Shit .

“You - Ador - fuck!” They sputtered, shaking their head and waving their hands. “Just *fuck!”* Their voice cracked again, “What the fuck have I been doing with you this whole time,” they cried, “all this fucking - these fucking presents and - shit!! I’m such an idiot!”

No, that’s not it.

“Catra, you’ve got it wrong!” Adora cried, trying to calm them, reaching out. Catra slapped her hand away, tears flowing freely. “I just gave everything to you Adora, and you’re just gonna” they choked on their words, finally whipping a leg out from the blanket.

“No!” Adora yelled, “Catra stop, listen! It’s not what you think!”

Catra whipped around “What, you just found a magicat to play with?” They yelled, suddenly up and bolting towards their pile of clothes, “thought you’d take home a stray?! Train it to serve you and then just, just,” they angrily yanked on their pants in such distress that they missed the leg hole a few times, “ - just leave it without so much as a thought to say goodbye?!” Catra sobbed as they wrenched on their shirt with lightning speed.

Adora finally disentangled herself from the blankets and rushed at Catra.

“Stop. Catra. You *need to listen to me.* ”

“Or what? What are you gonna say to get out of this one –”

“I need to tell you the whole story.” Adora snapped.

Catra bolted for the window - they were so, *so* fast. For once, Adora’s tendency for stumbling and clumsiness came into perfect use as they staggered backward and toppled onto Catra who sagged under the weight.

“Get off!”

“Wait!” Adora said desperately. Adora’s back was against the window, blocking Catra’s exit. The first mistake. Cats don’t like to be trapped. Adora was vaguely aware of Catra’s deeper stress signal showing through.

Adora reached out to hold their shoulders. The second mistake.

“You have got to listen.” Adora said calmly

“Move!” Catra gestured violently at her, enraged, pupils nearly disappeared

“Listen!” Adora yelled.

Adora reached out blindly, and instinctively Catra blocked with claws extended, leaving a long, clean scratch along Adora’s forearm..

“Fuck,” she hissed.

Catra instantly drew back in horror.

Adora winced, watching a perfect drop of blood pearl and the edge of the wound and slip down onto the flow.

“Sorry” Catra whispered in the smallest voice. Adora looked up to see Catra frozen in fear, hands flying over their mouth, looking at Adora’s arm in terror. “Sorry, I didn’t mean…”

“It’s okay,” Adora hurried - now was her chance to explain.

“I wanted it to be a surprise!” She blurted.

“What?” Catra sounded dazed, forgetting the source of their anger. “Moving! I wanted it to be a surprise.”

Wrath returned. “A surprise!? Who in fuck name wants to be surprised by a lover moving away?!”

“No!” Adora shouted louder than she meant and Catra cowered away. She felt awful - she had done just about everything wrong for Catra’s inherent, biological stress triggers - shocking information, blocking exits, grabbing, now *shouting* -lords, she was probably radiating stress pheromones that were putting Catra’s scent sensitivity on overdrive. *Shit.*

“I’m not trying to move away from you! I want to move *with* you.”

There was a stunned silence and Adora prayed that her words landed.

Catra blinked, dumbfounded and silent - *at last, thank the stars.*

Adora rushed on.

"I was going to tell you *soon* , I just wanted to save enough money up to do it - I wanted to ask you to move in with…" she took a huge steadying breath. This wasn't how she wanted it to go - she had had it all planned out: she was going to buy flowers and fish snacks and sweep Catra right off their feet. But now was absolutely the time. Clearly.

"I was going to ask if you want to move in *with* me. No, to find a new place together." She breathed. "I was going to wait also because, well, I started asking around about what magicats need in homes, and I wanted to find out a few potentials to show you."

She focussed closely on slowing her breathing- that always helped Catra calm down too - and looked at Catra with as much earnesty and affection as she could, banning fear from her expression. Fear often looked like anger to a hypersensitive magicat.

Catra was taking rattling breaths. Oh shit - this had happened once before - *hyperventilating* , it was called. Adora had learned a lot of new words with Catra.

"Catra - it's okay." Adora held her hands out where Catra could see them but made no sudden moves. "I'm not going anywhere without letting you know. And I want to be around you as much as I can, okay? I promise I'm not leaving you."

Adora could see Catra's pulse racing in their neck. They started taking short, sharp breaths, almost sobbing, but their body looked uncharacteristically stiff and uncomfortable, frozen. Adora realized that she was still blocking the window and very slowly edged to the side. She had said what she needed to say. If Catra left now, they would at least know.

"Do you need anything?" Adora said softly and was immediately met with a snarl and hiss, but Catra was stock still. They looked sick and vulnerable, trapped in a state of shock.

The room was full of the sound of soft panting and harsh sobs.

Shitshitshitshit. Stupid Adora.

Stay calm.

Adora willed herself to believe in the best outcome, to choose hope, to think of all the beautiful moments in her life in order to project peace and ease into the room, to emanate the right scent and energy. Magicats were far too perceptive, she had learned the hard way, and she was going to need every tool in the bag to dig them out of this one. Catra was impulsive when they were upset and like any normal magicat, would scramble for an exit when threatened.

"I'm going to sit on the bed now, will you join me? Or would you like to stand? Or you can leave and I won't try to stop you." She said in the most soothing voice she could while backing towards the wall and edging across the room as far away from Catra as possible. "Just know that I'm telling the truth," Catra's eyes flickered in fear as they watched her, brimming with adrenalin and static.

They're frozen in a stress state, Adora realized.

"I can even tell you about some of the places I've looked at." She said soothingly as she sat on the bed.

It wouldn't be any use now, Catra was too far gone but the words would reach them … eventually.

No one said anything. Catra's form was still tense and flexed.

"If you'd like me to leave the room I can," Adora looked at them, then chose to look at the table instead, recalling how eye contact can feel threatening, "Or you can take the bed."

“Promise?” Catra’s voice sounded unnaturally raw and small. Adora’s eyes snapped up at the words.

“What? Of course, you can have the bed -”

“No. The room. The move. With me.” Catra said in the strange, distant monotone. Their eyes were still full of fear and alarm, body frozen solid. It was heartbreaking to see - lithe, flexible, Catra bolted to the floorboards, full of pain and betrayal, instincts restricting their movements.

“ *Yes.”* Adora poured out, “yes, completely. I thought of the idea last full moon, just a spark, then ten days ago I realized that it could happen - instead of you having to climb the building and stay hidden, you could walk freely to the washroom,” Adora smiled at the fantasy, “a larger room, a bigger bed. Hopeful even a few high crawl spaces for you.”

That was also something the old magicat herbalist had told Adora when she asked for magicat specific building design. Little nooks set in the walls at differing heights, places to hide and burrow, tall beams and bars near the ceilings to mimic trees for height instinct needs. She couldn’t wait to see what Catra looked like doing those things. If they said yes, of course. *If* Adora got them out of this mess.

Catra gave her a tight grimace, something loosening in their posture subtly. “You’re not lying?” They whispered harshly.

Adora shook her head and smiled. “Not at all. I bet you’d smell it on me if so.” It was true. Catra absolutely would be able to smell a lie on her. It didn’t matter yet, she could tell that Catra was coming back to themself mentally, but on a physical level, they were far too escalated and rattled. Their breathing was the only sound in the room.

“Here,” Adora patted the bed beside her. Catra flinched.

Hm, perhaps not.

"Catra, I'm going to walk outside and go to the washroom to give you some time alone okay?" Adora said cautiously. Catra stared at her, still frozen, trapped in some instinctual circuit. She could practically hear the cacophony of voices and commands from Catra's thoughts and instincts - *Run! Fight! Leave! Stay! Burrow! Hide!* It was painful to watch someone so stricken with fear.

Adora edged toward the door "Don't leave!" Catra barked. Adora froze. "You want me to stay in here?"

Catra shook their head. *Good,* they were conscious and communicating.

"The building. Don't leave yet." Catra panted.

"I wasn't going to. Here," she pointed to her boots, "I'll leave the boots here where, where you can see them, I'll just wear my socks out in the hall. Catra nodded wordlessly.

Adora left the room quietly and padded down the hall. Catra would hear and smell her if she lingered outside the door and that wasn't *real* alone time. She wandered up the hall and another flight of stairs needing to move her legs to release some stress and review the events.

Shit, that went horribly. She had no idea Catra would be so hurt!

The threat of the warehouse and safety hazards of the shipping really was something she needed to think about, but nothing bad had happened yet. But Catra saw things Adora didn't. They were so terrified! Of course a shock like that - thinking Adora was moving - would be even worse when talking about the very real threat of death. She tried to imagine this situation from Catra's position. She didn't know much about Catra's past, just that…well, Adora was the first thing that sounded like home and hearth.

Imagine if that home and hearth suggested that it was just going to disappear? Adora winced. That's how Catra heard it.

Adora padded down to the washroom on her floor while berating herself, peed, drank water and took a good long look at her stupid reflection. She washed off the cut on her arm - there was a deep spot but mostly it was just long. She had forgotten about it.

She walked quietly to her room, loud enough that Catra could tell that she was approaching and not trying to sneak around. She stood at the door, breathing intentionally loud, then listened for a sound. The room was completely silent.

Which didn't mean much, considering that magicats were silent by default.

She drummed her fingers on the door. "Hello?" she called softly. Nothing.

"May I come in?" No answer. Adora sighed. Still quite possible that Catra was still frozen in place, or silently burrowing in a corner or the bed. Or just as likely they were out the window.

Adora rested her hand on the handle, leaving enough time for Catra to speak up. When she heard nothing, she pushed the door open quietly and peered inside. The window was cracked open. Adora's boots had been moved - they were now under the bed. On top of the mattress was a ball of blankets.

"Hello?" Adora said softly, suspecting that Catra was in the center of the ball. She stepped inside and gently closed the door.

"Catra?" She whispered, padding over to the blanket ball. It wasn't moving

"Catra?" She said again. The blankets hissed.

"Can I get you anything?" No response.

Adora thought back to every scared person, then every cat she's seen. After a stress event like that, most of them needed to rest and soothe.

But what was she supposed to do?

She stood still and gradually the blankets began to move, unfolding to reveal Catra, fully clothed and exhausted, face tear-streaked in complete disarray.

“Hi.” Adora said. Catra growled.

“I’ll sit in the chair unless you want me elsewhere.” She moved to close the window, but Catra hissed.

“Smells good,” they mumbled.

Adora nodded and went to sit on the chair, shivering from the frigid air but happy to keep Catra comfortable. They waited in silence as the rain fell, Adora breathing level and calmly, gaining confidence that Catra would stay and hear her out, maybe even… her plan would work. She smiled. *It would incredible.*

“Stop smiling,” Catra said crossly, and Adora’s gaze snapped up to see Catra watching her.

“Oh! Um, sorry.” Adora smiled inwardly. Catra was coming down. They were watching her now, eyeing her warily. Adora just looked around the room, avoiding eye contact.

Catra scoffed. “Come here.” They muttered quietly.

Adora stopped herself from leaping up and bounding over and opted for a slow, intentional walk and a gingerly sitting on the edge of the bed. Catra swatted at her instinctively. It was a bit playful and a bit protective, but it was contact.

“Hullo.” Catra mumbled.

“Hi,” Adora said.

Silence.

“You scared me.” Catra’s voice cracked and then hid their face.

Adora felt a wave of tears in her eyes. “I know,” she whispered softly, “and I’m so sorry. I wanted it to be fun, but instead, it was …t his.” She put a hand cautiously on the pile of blankets. No response. Then a small finger hooked around her thumb and pulled her hand in the ball of sheets, and her arm disappeared. She could feel Catra touching her hand, exploring it, their breath against her knuckles, then her palm against Catra’s feather-soft cheek, moving. She stroked a finger against Catra’s temple from inside the bundle. No purr yet, but their breath was leveling out.

They stayed like that for many minutes, rebalancing together, Catra invisible beneath the blankets and Adora sitting up with her arm stuffed elbow deep inside.

“Tell me about them?” Catra mumbled.

“About…?” Adora stumbled.

“The houses.” Catra breathed, then popped their head up. “And come down here and cuddle me.” They growled. Adora grinned and quickly pulled her pants off, then lay down and let Catra unfurl at their own pace.

“Well,” she started, “I have this herbalist I go to - she’s a magicat -”

“Is that why you know my favorite plants?”

“Well, they are common magicat plants, so, yeah? Anyways, I've been asking for her advice.”

“Some of the places I saw are across town, then there are a few in this area. One is at the top of a house with lots of windows. The other is mid-floor and larger. Another is on the ground level and has lots of crawl spaces, but not as many windows.”

She watched Cats’ eyes widen and narrow with each detail, absorbing the information, rolling it around in their head.

There was a long pause, then:

“From now on…if you’re serious…let's look together?” Catra whispered out.

“I’m dead serious Catra,” Adora breathed out in relief. She looked up at the ceiling to thank the stars and gently stroked a finger across Catra’s cheek. She could still feel Catras tension- it would take a while for all their joints to unlock, but Adora could feel even breaths, so she rubbed gently along their shoulders.

“I can’t wait to show you the spots, and to see what else you can find.”

Catra smiled wryly, with their messed hair and red eyes. “I bet I can find better spots than you.”

Adora laughed, “that’s a given.”

They lay there silently, just breathing. Catra rolled over and gently tentatively put their head on Adora’s chest. “You’re serious right? You’re not lying?”

“No”.

“I’m not easy to live with Adora. I’m worried. I’m just… tough.”

“I know you are. But don’t you sort of live here?”

Catra would stay for days at a time when they could, arriving before and after Adora’s work. Oftentimes they would spend hours talking or silently passing time with one another. Adora would practice her writing exercises from a school manual she had bought for a discount because she didn’t have much schooling where she was from, while Catra would read, or groom themself, or draw, or nap in peace. It made Adora happy to see them like this, and wondered when the last time Catra slept in a bed regularly and safely.

Catra twitched uncomfortably. " *You* live here - *I'm* your guest."

"Yeah…but I don't want you to just be my guest anymore. We could try having a place together, you know? Why not? You can leave whenever you like. I'll give you space! You can have your own bed too. You won't be tied to me. And hey, if it doesn't work, it doesn't!"

Catra snapped up "Don't talk like that!"

"Hey, even if living together doesn't work, it doesn't mean we would stop - well… *this.* "

Catra glared at her angrily but seemed assured in some strange way that Adora was serious and willing to work it all out. They both stayed curled together in the bed, rebalancing.

Finally.

Adora careened down the narrow staircase, zipping up her jacket and jamming her hat on her head as she took the stairs two at a time. She was running late, but the cuddling seemed very important to Catra. She checked that her gloves were in her pocket as she shot down the front step and onto the cobblestones street.

Damn, she was quite behind, she realized as she caught sight of the decrepit but still-working clock tower in the town square. She bolted across the wide-open space, covering impressive distance even when slowed down by the wet stones and mounting rain.

Stupid Catra.

Stupid, sweet adorable Catra. She smiled warmly as she ran down narrow streets towards the harbor. What a morning! What a day. Gods, that was terrifying - she thought she was about to lose everything they had built to whether -including the plans for a future!

Adora was breathing heavily as she ran - she was mad that Catra made her so late - all the needy hissing and grabbing after the cuddles, going so far as to steal a boot as Adora was trying to leave. *It was childish, really,* she thought as she sprinted down a slight incline, dodging passersby and food stands that crowded the alleyway. Only a few more minutes till the docks - lords, she might lose her spot on the crew and *then* wouldn't that be just perfect - a huge setback to her plan.

Catra's fears weren't unfounded it seemed. Adora shivered as she thought about this, trying to ignore the sick tug in her stomach. What are the odds that it would happen today though? Tomorrow she would really sit down and think about all this, but all she needed to do was push through one last shift. She promised Catra she'd look at other gigs, but what else would pay this well?

Her lungs were burning as she nearly tumbled after tripping on a loose rock, catching herself on a food stall.

"Watch it asshole!" A tiny man screamed from behind a mountain of fruits.

"I- sorry, just trying to get -"

"Shut up!" A little old lady whacked her on the back of the head with a roll of paper. She *thought* this would be a shortcut, but apparently, this alleyway was flooded with grumpy old people and angry merchants.

She did *not* have time for this. She was already late and was on her way to being fired as she and the rest of the crew were entirely replaceable with a horde of other desperate down-and-out workers.

"Truly, sorry -" she extracted herself from a group of people, swearing under her breath, catching sight of a clock bolted to the wall of a building. Damnit! She was so done for!

She sprinted in earnest now, relieved to see the docks a block away but a clear shot down the street. *Yes.*

She skidded to a halt, rounded a corner, and aimed for the rickety wood stairwell that would take her to the top level of the shipping bay. Maybe they wouldn't fire her? Her left boot hit the first step when the air around her crackled in an unnatural way, a little like lightning but…something was off.

And suddenly the world surrounding her filled with a terrifying *whoosh* and a loud, resounding clap of thunder rattled her teeth and sent her flying backward into the mud. Another monumental thunderclap sounded, echoing through the narrow alley behind her, then another. She was dazed, looking at the sky for lighting when she saw the inky black smoke. Her ears were ringing.

Fuck.

Three more explosions sounded and then she heard the screaming. She scrambled up, slipped on a wet stone, and hit the street hard. The air felt hot and contaminated, burning her lungs - *what was* - oh shit.

She saw a lick of fire out of the corner of her eye and ducked as a wall of flames blasted down the stairwell directly towards her face

Heat enveloped her and small pops sounded off next to her ear. Was she on fire? She must be - her lungs were hot and smoke curled around her, suffocating and oppressive.

She cracked an eyelid - no, she wasn't, the flames hadn't reached *her,* but the barrels and stairs by her feet were ablaze.

Shit!

She scrambled up out to the mud, turned on her heel and ran.

Shit!

Her heart was pounding as she slammed up the street, pushing herself forward. More screaming, more explosions behind her. People flooded the space around her and began to run and walk. She cursed, took a side alley, then burst out onto a wider thoroughfare with more room. Confused faces appeared at windows, people stepping out onto the street to look up at the smoke. She didn't look back. She couldn't.

She could hear the oncoming shouts of law enforcers, soldiers in the fire Brigade, and she willed her legs to hurried to a walk, like normal civilians, one who didn't work in the illegal docks and was fleeing a crime scene she knew all too well, one who wouldn't be imprisoned if they caught her. No, not today.

She assumed a concerned expression and looked back in fear, trying to blend in with the crowd, pretending she had no clue as to what could have possibly happened. A flood of people moved around her. A group of tiny children hurried along towards safety. An old lady moved with shocking agility. The old man with the vegetable cart cursed under his breath.

"Here sir, let me help," Adora called, then without waiting for an answer began to push the cart up the street as soldiers shoved forward. She hid her face - *they wouldn't recognize her anyways, but it was still best to keep a low profile.* The man hardly noticed, he was too busy huffing, calling to people to move the fuck out of the way. Adora bowed her head and pushed with all her strength, hiding in plain sight while her heart threatened to leap right out of her chest and her lungs burned.

At last, they reached the town square, which was absolute chaos. People were yelling, screaming, and crying, pointing at the large plumes of smoke that chugged out despite the heavy rain. Adora spared a glance behind her as she set the cart down and nodded to the man, who grunted in appreciation.

Shit, she was totally fucked.

More explosions thundered - oh sea gods, this was a disaster. She prayed that the fire brigade would move swiftly. Thank the stars for the rain, and that they were next to the water.

I almost died. The thought was strangely detached, but the bile in her throat was very real.

She turned and bullied through the crowd, head down, making a wide arch towards her boarding house, wondering if she should pack up her things in case the fire spread or if the patrol would be able to track her down. *Fuck, fuck! This was so fucked —-*

Someone slammed into her chest, nearly knocking her backward onto the stones. "Hey watch -"

Adora felt two rock-hard arms wrap around her painfully and squeeze and the scent of woods and warmth filled her nose. Catra.

Adora could feel Catra's entire body shaking, flexed in tension and latched on to hers, squeezing the breath out of her.

"Catra" Adora wheezed, " loosen up —"

She finally looked down to she the top of Catra's head shoved into her chest. When they finally looked up, Adora had never seen such a sickly, terrified expression written across their features. Which was saying something, considering the state they had been in a mere hour ago. She thought Catra was about to chew her out, but they were mute, grimacing and shuddering; their pupils tiny, terrified slits as they panted through clenched teeth. They weren't wearing boots or a jacket, just a simple shirt that was put

on backward and their thick trousers which were unbuttoned, dishevled like they hadn't even thought about what they would need to leave the house.

Shit.

"Catra it's okay - I'm okay -" Adora whispered in a shaky voice, suddenly realizing that she very much was *not* okay at all. She had almost been blown up, for fucks sake. Catra didn't respond - couldn't respond, absolutely stricken, fur on end.

They both ducked as a patrol ran by, pushing through the crowd.

"Room." Catra hissed through gritted teeth.

Adora began to shoulder them through the sea of bodies, arm looped protectively over Catra's shoulders. She could feel them beginning to crumble. *Shit,* she had put Catra's nervous system through an unbelievable amount of stress in the past hours - the fight, denial, then truly almost getting blown up - Adora felt bile on her tongue at the thought of what would have happened to her if she had been on time - if Catra hadn't stolen her boot if she hadn't run into the vegetable cart if she hadn't taken a crowded street -

She tripped over something only to realize it was the doorway to her house, housekeeper nowhere in sight. She and Catra bolted up the stairs, Catra dragging with each step. "Come on you, come on Catra," Adora whispered.

She could hear Catra's labored, panicked breathing, feel their heaving chest. Shit, more of that hyperventilation business. The loud sounds must be an assault for their sensitive hearing; she could only imagine what it would have been like to hear those explosions and see the smoke coming from the harbor. Poor Catra.

They burst into the room at last. It was freezing, the window wide open and clothes and blanket strewn on the floor. Adora slammed the door with her foot and dragged Catra - still attached to her

torso - across the room to latch the window. The rain had spattered on the desk and the papers were everywhere.

“Left in a hurry” Catra wheezed.

“I’m sure you did,” Adora muttered softly as she closed and locked the window. Finally, the room was still. They looked out of the window over the crowded chaotic square and the plume of dark, thick smoke coming from blocks away, the grey sky above them split open.

“Shit.” Adora breathed, wrapping Catra in her arms and guiding them to the bed. Catra was taking deep, erratic breaths, punctuated with raw gasps.

“Look at me Catra, look,” Adora coaxed and forced their head up to meet her eyes. Catra looked even worse than earlier, utterly spooked and panicked, body trembling. Adora tried to bring Catra’s hands up to her face - she wanted to put their palms against her cheeks, kiss them, smooth them - but Catra wouldn’t loosen their grip.

“Can you please,” Adora gestured to Catra’s arms. They stared at them in confusion and shook their head, “Can’t” they wheezed in horror. “Can’t.” Their eyes were wild and scrambled.

Oh dear. Their muscles were twitching and ripping, sizing up.

“Catra. Look at me.” Catra locked eyes with Adora like it was a lifeline. “I’m here. I’m right here. I’m okay.” Adora looked at them, trying to convince herself.

“I’m safe, I’m here,” someone was saying. Was that her voice? “I’m okay,” Adora felt her throat tighten and waver. “I’m…uh….o.” The words weren’t coming out right, the world around her suddenly blurry.

“I’m …” her voice cracked and her eyes felt hot. Hot. Blazing hot. Catra looked up at her terrified and Adora knew exactly how that

felt. “I’m..fine.” Adora said numbly, then promptly burst into tears.

No, she wasn’t fine. Catra wasn’t fine. None of this was fine at all. She held onto Catra tightly, shoved her face in their curls, and breathed in heavily while she sobbed and sobbed. *Shit,* she was breathing sharply, tears streaming down her face. She was curled around Catra, both of their bodies instinctively tight and tense, fully clothed in rough work garb, full of horror at what nearly happened. Catra’s breath was hot against her chest. Adora began to cough, coughing turned into wretching. She turned her head to the side and held on for dear life.

Dead. She almost died just now. Fuck.

And right after she and Catra finally made it through, finally she had something *big* to look forward to, *finally* , and she almost got her ass killed up because she was too set on her plan. She should have listened to Catra right away. *Idiot.*

After all her darkest moments in the city when she wished she was just dead, now she was terrified of dying. Lords.

Sirens and shouts sounded from below, but the town stayed frozen and locked together in the tight room, fear thick in the air and horrible thoughts surrounding them like wasps.

Hours passed. The sun went down. The flames were still visible from her window, but they weren’t spreading - or so it seemed. Eventually, Catra’s muscles and joints unlocked and Adora maneuvered them both horizontally on the bed. She struggled to untie her boots, missing laces and fumbling with her pants. Her hands were trembling, body shaking just as much as Catra’s. Finally, they lay down together and Adora yanked the blankets on top of them ungracefully, everything twisted together. She

wrapped Catra in her arms while Catra wrapped Adora's head in their arms, and they proceeded to cry until Adora fell asleep.

Adora woke up from a horrible dream, screaming. Catra's face was right there, peering into hers seriously, running a thumb across her temple. "You're okay," they whispered shakily, thoroughly unconvinced. She gasped and sobbed while Catra petted her into calm. "How long was I out?"

"A few hours," Catra whispered back. The flames were still visible in the dark night outside her window.

" *Fuck."* Adora whispered. "I could've -"

Catra clapped a hand over her mouth. "Don't say it." They hissed. Adora could see their eyes flashing in fear. "Just…don't say it yet." They breathed out and released Adora's mouth. Adora nodded.

"Okay." Adora said nervously.

Neither of them went back to sleep that night.

When the sun rose, the smoke was almost out and rain was steadily falling. They watched each other silently. It felt like their hearts had been racing for the past day - well, for Catra that was probably true; Adora felt exhausted and nauseous.

"Water?" She asked weakly and watched Catra nod and grab the canteen, tipping it into Adora's mouth.

She had to go refill it and walked on shaking legs to and from the washroom.

Catra had begun to clean up the room, and both of them moved numbly about, tidying, straightening the sheets, folding clothes, organizing the desk as if this would restore them back into their strong, capable selves. They both returned to the bed, feeling marginally better. They kept the window clear so they would keep an eye on the flames.

No one spoke.

"So," Catra whispered.

Adora's legs were cramped from stress. Her heart rate felt a bit slower, but it was still far too fast for someone who was lying in a bed for hours.

"Yeah." Adora whispered back. She had been crying on and off all morning while Catra petted her with their tail. Catra looked a bit better and had assumed the role of caretaker.

"We should…I dunno." Catra shrugged. "What do you do when something like this happens?"

Adora shook her head. She had no clue.

They mutually decided to stay silent and look at the wall.

Hours later the sun was setting.

"Hungry?" Catra whispered. Adora should be, but she wasn't.

“Maybe we should have some soup?” Catra murmured. They weren’t hungry either. “Or tea.” That was probably smart.

“I don't want to go outside,” Adora whispered like a scared child.

“I don't’ want you to go outside either,” Catra whispered. “I’ll go get us something?”

Adora’s massive hand clapped around Catra’s arm. “I don’t want you to go without me.” She whispered.

Catra nodded. “Me neither.”

Shit.

They stayed inside, dwelling in the darkness. The world felt empty.

Adora woke up suddenly. Etheria’s larger moon was peeking through the clouds. Catra’s soft body was right next to hers, breathing evenly. She looked at Catra’s face. Their eyes were wide open.

“Have you slept at all?” Adora asked.

“Not a wink.” Catra said dully.

“Oh.”

“Yeah, don’t expect me to. I can’t calm down yet.”

Adora nodded, then hobbled up clumsily. They had been in bed for … how long had it been. A day? Longer?

Longer.

“Your work?” Adora started to ask, but Catra just laughed.

“Fuck work. The warehouses are probably dead right now, or swarming with patrols. Either way, I don't give a shit. Bad omen for me to leave now. Fuckin’ idiots.” Catra spat. Adora wobbled back over to the bed after grabbing some sweet herb from her desk drawer, shoving it inelegantly into Catra’s face.

“Thanks, handsome.” Catra winked, “it’ll take more than just this, but it’s nice.”

Adora smiled tightly. It was the gesture that counted, right?

Catra did look a bit more relaxed.

They both returned to bed and lay quietly in the dark.

“Adora.”

“Yeah?”

“Let’s look at some places tomorrow, yeah?” Catra whispered into the dark.

Adora smiled weakly and nodded.

She dropped off to sleep with a faint smile on her lips and fear in her heart. Something, at least, was going to be okay.

High Beams

Chapter Summary

And the bois are back.

I apologize for the abundance of typos I was just desperate to get this out from the massive word document that I have. I got lost in my world building obsession and affinity for fluff.

Soooo…enjoy!

Adora woke up early from a hazy, disturbing sleep. The sky outside was light grey, a soft drizzle. She turned over to see Catra looking at the ceiling with wide eyes.

"No, I didn't sleep," they muttered before Adora could even ask.

Damn. Adora slept, but that didn't keep her thoughts from being murky and strange, a confusing blur of dread and reality.

Both of them agreed they needed to leave the room, although looking for housing seemed to be an unlikely fantasy at this point; Catra walked across the room, each movement weighted down with fatigue. Adora debated putting off their adventure in hopes of Catra resting, but at this point she began to wonder if some fresh air would do the trick and help Catra's system rebalance enough to relax.

The housekeeper was nowhere to be seen, so Adora pulled Catra down the stairs, too nervous to let them scale the wall down the the street in such a state of exhaustion. They snuck out and cautiously stepped into the deserted square, peering around as if they would be attacked at any moment. The only residents out at this hour were shop owners, merchants, and market goers ambling through the heavy fog to their destinations. The air

smelled of charred wood and stunk of...whatever had burned inside of all the crates.

Where to?

The thought of eating something fried was nauseating, and Catra looked sick but had rejected food this morning.

Adora lead them to the one place that she could think of: the magicat herbalist's shop.

After what felt like an agonizingly long walk down a few city blocks, they stood outside a little shop front that was, blessedly, open for business. Upon walking in the door they were enveloped in warm, steamy air and a cloud complex scents that Adora would never be able to identify even if she studied for years. She watched Catra take a huge breath in, and their shoulders loosen immediately. Thank fuck.

"Hello." Croaked an old, raspy voice from behind the counter. The shop was tiny, crowded with shelves packed with jars of all sizes, and bags of plants, powders, and bottles of strange liquids. The countertop was the only clear space in the tightly packed room, and behind it sat a small, wrinkled magicat with silver white fur, barely visible amidst the clutter. It reminded Adora a bit of the pub she met Catra in - so full of character, the floorboards worn down from what could have been centuries of foot steps. But the ambiance was cozy, a bit dusty, warm, and just … old.

"Ah, it's you again." The old magicat said cooly. It wasn't unfriendly, but more of an observation. She didn't seem happy to see them, but she didn't seem upset. Neutral and ambivalent, completely calm. It brought Adora a sense of peace, to have something so steady and unexciting.

The ancient hybrid furrowed her brows slightly. "Ah, and you've brought your …" she glanced at Catra up and down, bright green eyes flitting over them, nose twitching, tail swaying ever so slightly. Catra had frozen under her stare with tense shoulders

whil Adora tried to read the energy of the room. She was good at assessing Catra's stress signals now, or the tells of excitement and happiness - and trust, Catra had been *complete* stress and zero happiness in the past few days (which would have been apparent to *anyone)* but Adora had never seen this type of response to another creature before. Catra didn't seem angry or reactive - they just looked wary and defensive and … *something else* . Adora decided this must be some complicated magicat exchange, which unexpectedly stung - she had never seen Catra interact with another magicat before.

The old magicat broke her stare, her expression returning to neutral as if she had confirmed some theory.

"I see you've brought your *mate* this time."

Catra scoffed while Adora gasped. *Mate?* They hadn't even talked about any of that - it was way too soon in the, the… courtship? Catra had crossed their arms and grumbled, tail flicking in agitation.

"We - we're not — we're, um," Adora stuttered.

"We're *not* mates." Catra spat out.

Adora felt her insides clench, even though *she* had been trying to correct the magicat as well.

The old woman gave absolutely no recognition of this statement, simply slowly blinking her eyes, addressing the two of them with an expression that landed somewhere between bemused irritation and disinterest. There was a very long stretch of silence in which the old woman allowed the blatant lie to settle around all of them like heavy dust.

" *Indeed* ." She said in a tone that communicated that she thought the two of them were both full of shit.

Adora winced and she could sense Catra's fur standing on end.

The old woman blinked serenely from the counter then addressed Adora "Your order came in. You were supposed to pick it up yesterday." She stated it as a fact, not a hint of blame.

Shit. The order.

The order of the flowers she was planning on giving to Catra, as a sweet gift and one to possibly accompany her announcement of moving in together if she had been ready.

"Order?!" Catra hissed, irritated at being left out of this matter. Catra was seemingly irritated at everything right now, which made sense since they hadn't slept a wink for the past few days. Adora could see the exhaustion in their sunken eyes, the sweat that was beading at their hairline like a constant fever, the way their hands trembled.

"Oh, just something I wanted to, um…" Adora trailed off, feeling embarrassed.

The old magicat cleared her throat and did the job of laying Adora's secret completely bare. "Just an ordered bouquet of magicat specific herbs and flowers she's been pestering me for these past weeks. Something I'm *sure* that doesn't concern you *at all* , as her official *not-mate* who so clearly shares a bed with her." She finished with a detached sigh and rolled her eyes.

Catra growled, blushed and flicked their tail angrily, caught somewhere between fury and elation.

"Honestly," drawled the old woman, "what on earth would you expect from scent marking her for the past 5 moon rotations. Anyone could smell it from a town away." The old magicat lazily inspected her claws, flicking an ear.

Adora and Catra stared at her like dumbfounded idiots.

"Anyways," the old woman sighed drearily, "what *actually* brought you in today? The two of you look like you've been living with demons over your heads from the past few years and it got

particularly nasty in the past few days," the woman looked at them with a piercing gaze, the muttered, "and you smell like you haven't washed the soot of the fire and the sweat of the night terrors."

Catra bristled and hissed at the woman, who blinked owlishly, unfazed. Adora put a calming hand on Catra's shoulder. They flinched and maintained their defensive posture.

"The past few days have been…taxing," Adora tried. She could feel her voice wavering, and suddenly felt the dizzy hunger and nausea that had been building in her for the duration of their short walk over. She and Catra had locked themselves in her room after all, and hardly drank water, let alone food.

The old woman squinted and watched the two of them with a cool, calculating gaze, then nodded her head as she made some internal decision. "Very well, come this way." She snapped, then to Adora's amazement, ushered them behind the counter and through a small doorway in the back. Catra was too surprised to resist, the fight drained from them with the rush of emotion earlier. Adora noticed that the old magicat was wearing a ridiculous flowered nightgown that she might as well slept in, which seemed to the the universal uniform for old herbalists of any species these days.

They passed through a tiny corridor that Adora ducked through, then into a small storage room that was filled with more plants, powders and herbs and a few ancient fuzzy couches. "Sit." She commanded.

Adora and Catra sank into a large chair, side by side as the woman poured them water and a dark tea from separate containers, then sat across from them in an equally soft, worn chair.

"Stressed." She said knowingly.

Catra buried their face in their hands and sighed while Adora leaned back against the cushions and nodded. All her muscles ached. As much as she wanted to be next to Catra, they both had been on the verge of picking a fight all morning. Catra's lack of sleep made them prickly and wild, and Adora felt like a fussy child herself. The shared trauma between them was crackling like a lightning storm, ready to strike and set a forest of emotions ablaze.

"Drink the tea." The old lady ordered. Adora reached for a cup, "The *other* one" The old woman said as she sipped her own. "That one is best for magicats - I poured it for your *not-mate* over here."

Catra hissed weakly and mumbled "it's Catra."

The old woman smirked and nodded. "That one is for you, Catra. It's a special blend for felines. You could drink your *not-mate* Adora's tea but it wouldn't do much for you." The woman said with a hint of sarcasm.

Catra glared at her and grabbed the tea.

The old woman chuckled a bit tauntingly but looked satisfied. Adora didn't like being made fun of, but she grabbed her tea and took a sip and —

Oh moon's of love, that was a *good* cup of tea.

She exhaled in pleasure and felt tears prick her eyes in relief. Catra grumbled and sipped theirs and looked mildly pleased - which was a complete turn around from the past days of horror.

Adora open her mouth to say something, anything really. "Don't talk. Just drink," the old magicat said absently. "I don't want to hear a word that comes out of your mouth until you calm down."

Catra's tail thrashed. "You better watch how you're talking to her," they spat, breath growing erratic and full of protective, wild energy.

The old woman snapped to attention and gave Catra a severe look, which, to Adora's surprise, silenced them completely as they drew back into the massive couch.

"You." The woman spat, and drew herself up to her full height, which was a good head shorter than Catra, "need to cool your claws off, little kit." She hobbled over to Catra who cowered and hissed at the same time, truly looking like an *actual* kit.

"Don't you - um -" Catra was sputtering. The old woman raised her arm and aggressively pointed to a pile of cushions in the corner. "You! Go. *Now."*

Catra hissed again, shrinking away, "I *won't be put on time out!"* They cried angrily like a child resisting the rules of an evil guardian. Adora watched slack jawed at the exchange.

The old woman scoffed and rolled her eyes, "You should be *thanking me* you ridiculous kit. That's a *good* place you fool." And with one fell swoop the old magicat's hand was on the back of Catra's neck, pulling at their scruff. Caught by surprise and instantly pliable from the sensation, Catra rose on weak knees and scrambled to keep up with the old woman who dragged them a few steps to the nest of cushions. She dumped them unceremoniously down into the fluff and dusty pillows. Catra immediately growled in a show of defiance, but was unable to hide the very obvious physical comfort they were experiencing. The old woman addressed Catra with a seething glare, then grabbed a loosely woven fabric sack filled with dry herbs and dropped in on Catra's head. Catra hissed and swatted at the humiliating treatment but Adora didn't miss the way their body instantly relaxed and the motion of their tail had calmed into a gentle sweep.

"Put that on your nose and breathe it in," the magicat ordered, watching Catra's body closely. They glowered at her as they stuffed their nose into the fabric and inhaled, sinking deeper into the cushions. The trembling in their hands lessened by the second and Adora could see their movements returning to that smooth,

liquid-like grace, rather than the jerky and cramped twitching of the past days.

“There we go.” The old woman said in a surprisingly warm, satisfied tone, “have you had those before?” Catra shook their head angrily, still glaring at the woman like a moody adolescent.

“Hmmmm.” The woman grunted, “it’s something we use to calm stressed kits down,” Catra hissed at being compared to a baby magicat yet again, and the old woman grumbled, “adults use it too, smooth your tail. It’s just that no one likes to admit it.” She rolled her eyes and puttered back to her seat. “And take off those boots!” She said sharply, “they’re terrible for foot paws - don’t sleep in them,” Catra scrambled to untie their boots and kick them off.

Adora looked at Catra in awe. They were kneading at a pillow contentedly, half of their face covered by the giant tea-bag of dried herbs. The beginnings of a weak purr hummed in their chest.

Simply watching Catra helped Adora calm. She sipped her tea and felt her legs loosen, realizing how numb her body had been.

“Lie down,” the woman said crossly. Adora obeyed, sipping her tea, unlacing her boots. The woman angrily threw one of the softest blankets on the planet at her head, and Adora wondered how anyone could be so nurturing while maintaining the attitude of a complete asshole.

“You two, stay here. I need to help a customer.” And with that, the old magicat did her best to stomp out of the room on her old, soft feet.

Adora looked at Catra, who was watching her sleepily. “Hey, Adora.” They yawned from across the room. Adora smiled back. “Hey handsome.”

A purr rolled through the air. Adora watched Catra’s eyes flutter closed and they slipped into a light sleep.

Thank stars. Adora drank her tea and felt a few hot tears fun down her cheeks while she looked around the room and tried to absorb the safety and comfort. She wanted to pack it up in her heart and keep it there forever. Such a stark contrast to her cold, unwelcoming boarding house.

Eventually the old magicat grumbled back in.

"I take it you are still looking for a new place to live." She mumbled.

Adora nodded, watching Catra who was still fast asleep.

"Yeah…although I'll need to find some new work first. Catra probably too."

The old woman nodded. "The docks and the warehouses," she tutted her tongue and shook her head, although didn't show a scrap of judgement, "best for you to look elsewhere, that's for sure."

"I almost was—" Adora blurted but couldn't find the strength to finish.

The woman nodded solemnly, "I could smell it on you. All of it. Including that special scent of terror."

Adora nodded, then whispered, "it was right after I told Catra too - about the moving in together. And I narrowly missed fucking that all the way up," she shook her head in relief, "but stars," she took a shuddering breath, "if I had been on time to the docks," her voice caught in her throat.

The woman grunted knowing. "Very lucky. Been there a few times myself," she sighed, "count your blessings and adjust course, little one." She released a puff of air.

Adora groaned, "that's the *only* thing I'm doing now."

They sat in silence for a while more.

“Well,” the woman started, “a few people have come to *me* hoping to rent a place, but…only time will tell if that will work for you.” She looked from Adora to Catra.

Adora nodded. They needed to assess their financial situation first. And also discuss if Catra still *actually* wanted to make this move.

“You say you aren’t mates,” the woman interrupted her thoughts, “but…” she sighed in annoyance, as if she despised the fact that *she* had to be the one to say this, “call yourselves what you want, but don’t hold back from telling eachother your truth.” She shook her head as if Adora had been pestering for her advice, "Trust, *that* is something you will regret if you loose the chance.”

Adora felt panic rise in her chest at the implication. She had been having the darkest thoughts for the past two days of suddenly loosing eachother all over again, even on a simple trip to the washroom.

“Oh calm down,” the woman spat, “I’m just trying to help you. It’s too obvious.” She glared at Catra, who was happily kneading in their sleep, “they’re going to move in with you dear, clear as day.”

Oh, hm.

“Do you know if they were raised by magicats,” the woman asked curiously, departing from the topic of conversation abruptly.

No, Adora didn’t. She didn’t know anything about Catra’s past. She shook her head and the old magicat cocked her eyebrow in critique.

“Well, you better figure out how to talk about your pasts before you move in together.” She said judgmentally. “ I ask because most magicats would recognize those herbs and those particular cushions as signs of comfort, play and safety,” she observed Catra sleeping peacefully, “this one didn’t.”

Adora had no idea some cushions were different than others, especially for hybrids.

“What an odd little kit,” the woman murmured, a smile playing across her lips in thought.

It filled Adora with warmth to see someone - an older magicat at that - looking at Catra so sweetly and carefully, someone who knew things of which Adora had no clue. Apparently Catra didn’t know either.

“Yeah,” Adora mumbled, suddenly sleepy.

“You should rest,” Adora heard a muffled voice say softly, but her lids were already closing like metal weights over her eyes.

Adors was in a peaceful dream.

She was in a lirrle green room, soft light streaming in from a little window, lighting a beam of golden dust particles that swirled in the air. Tall shelves of herbs surrounded her. She was lying on a plush sofa wrapped in a blanket, something warm pressed down on top of her. She groggily realized this wasn’t a dream, in fact she was in a back room storage unit of an herb shop, run by and ancient little magicat. She looked down to see Catra sprawled on her chest, hands clutching the sack of herbs to their face and breathing through it in their sleep.

Adora smiled and pet through their hair, earning a sleepy grunt. Gorgeous.

She carefully moved Catra next to her, then wobbled up to a standing position to find a washroom. After relieving herself she tiptoed to the counter.

“Thank you so much,” Adora whispered to the old magicat. She wondered how the woman looked disinterested and managed to

seem invested in their collective health at the same time. Adora glanced towards the back room where she could still see Catra sprawled out in a deep slumber.

"I don't know how to thank you enough –"

"I do." the woman said flatly. Her eyes sparked wickedly and Adora's stomach dropped for some unnamable reason.

Great.

They had spent most of the day with the herbalist. Catra slept for hours, twisting around on the cushions in their sleep, kneading excessively, sleepily drinking tea and then falling back into peaceful slumber. It was delightful to watch.

Adora rested, napped, learned about a few more herbs for magicats, picked up her order.

The herbalist sent them home with a snarl, a jar of soup, and the little bag of herbs that Catra repeatedly denied but was secretly in love with. The old magicat's attitude confused Adora to no end, but didn't seem to phase Catra at all.

Adora finally felt the spark of an appetite as they trudged up the stairs of the boarding house after confirming the housekeeper was out of sight, then sleepily ate their soup in silence.

At last, after a long day of sleep, Adora happily slipped in bed with Catra by her side to engage in, well, more sleep.

They lay comfortably until Catra broke the silence.

“So, where’d you get yours?” Catra was pointing at the well-used dragonhide jackets that had brought them together.

“And why Brightmoon?” They added on.

Adora let out a *hhhmmmph* and scoffed.

“Ouch! You don’t need to - sorry.” Catra looked offended.

Adora closed her eyes and sighed. “Well. I’ll tell you…it just. Hurts.”

She knew this moment would come. She hated thinking about it, and she had never even talked about it. Well, sober, that is. Or to someone who cared.

It was time to go back to those memories.

“Remember when you made a joke about me coming from the high hills?”

Catra winced “Yeah, and I’m sorry - again. It was cruel and —”

“Yeah, well, I am. But we aren’t stupid. It’s just…simpler there, so different then the city. Also ignored by the larger trade routes, although we - I mean *my* homeland does produce most of the food for the surrounding kingdoms.”

Adora sighed. These memories always made her so tired. Visions of the green rolling hills that rose into mountains, the thick woodlands that expanded from the edge of the fields, the way the sun hit the world during dawn and dusk, soft and ethereal, thick pink and blue mists that enveloped everything as the sun rose and set. Waterfalls and creeks where she used to play and bathe in the pure water, laughter ringing off the canyon walls and mossy boulders.

Her heart began to ache in that special way.

“Beautiful there. Astoundingly. Magic, even.” She whispered harshly. She felt Catra’s warm palm touch her shoulder and rub in the way she often found soothing. It wasn’t working now - even the strongest balm couldn’t sooth this wound.

“There would be yearly competitions, you know, harvest time, spring games, a place to gather and revel. People trained all year.”

She had too that year, in between farm duties and taking care of the great, shaggy cows that the town raised.

“ I was always so big - even as a kid - so strong, everyone had bet on me winning that year,” she scoffed, “used to being bet on I guess. Well, that year the city militaries had come to watch the games - it was recruiting, really, but none of us knew, we just thought they were finally taking notice of us. We felt so special. So I entered the biggest competition and…I won.” She gave a small laugh. That victory had been one of her proudest moments, she could still hear the cheers, feel the flush on her skin, the girl that pulled her down for a kiss behind a barn, the tall and beautiful knight that tipped his helmet towards her in praise and recognition.

“Of *course* you won.” Catra crooned in their soft, scratchy voice. Adora was about to tell them that this was not a time to poke fun at her, that these memories hurt, when she realized Catra was earnest and proud of her. Adora laughed despite herself. Turns out she still had at least one fan.

“Yeah, I did. I was at the top. *‘Champion of Humans’* was the title”

Catra snorted in laughter, “I’m sorry but *Champion of Humans!?* Only humans would come up with such a ridiculous name!” Adora recoiled, feeling insulted. Also she had been vaguely aware that that was an absurd title, really.

“I didn’t make the title up!” She said defensively. Catra just chuckled and patted her arm affectionately. “ I know, I know. I’m

not laughing at you, I'm laughing at whoever made it up. I'm proud of you."

Adora sighed, irritated. "Anyways, I won. My town was thrilled. For the first time we thought we were going to be on the map. The knights and soldiers gave me such praise and invited me to serve - I accepted immediately and couldn't wait. I had dreamt of fame and recognition, dreams of splendor- all that shit, you know? And now it was my chance. I just knew that I was going to be like that knight one day soon. The town loaded me with support - coins, food. People even gave me -" her voice caught. This was the worst memory of all, " they gave me old things- family charms and heirlooms for me to use to start my future. *'Do it for us, Adora, we know you can. '* I was honored but I was not humble, and I was not smart either. I took everything with pride and promised my allegiance to my town and to the knights." she shuddered at the memory, the hubris and excitement of having so much power, of looking at the glittering content of her satchel, of the abundant praise people heaped on her.

"One of our elders was an old witch, always one step ahead of the rest of us. The night before I left she called me into her hut. She warned me of the perils of the city, she warned me of the shifting nature of the world and human intention, and she blessed me so that I would carry the love and the protection of my home where ever I went. Before I left her house, she gave me one of *her* items. We went to the back room into a cave, winding through a deep corridor and into the cavern where she slept. From the back wall she opened a small closet, a special one, and she gave me this jacket and blessed it and me with safety and smarts. I was a little thrown off - it seemed so *average* and dusty, at the time but I put it on anyway and it felt right. A few hours later I left in the early morning with the army and the whole town waved me goodbye. I was so proud." She scoffed at her idiot self from a few short years ago.

"And in my bags I held all the wealth they gave me, the precious treasures of their family, and the hopes and dreams for a better future for the town. I walked away with my head held high, and

down the road I went with the foot soldiers. Four days later I was in Brightmoon, a three more days and the knights kicked me out of the army." Adora heard Catra take in a sharp breath. "I," Adora's voice cracked, " I had been too proud. The night before I had been so stupid. I had no idea of safety or suspicion - it just didn't exist in the hills. Everyone knew each other - if you betrayed someone, they would track you down and have a duel or something!"

"Anyways, I was playing cards with some of the other foot soldiers and locals. I was so loud, so pompus."

Adora remembered her bravado, and the looks she saw a few soldiers exchanging with her words. It was sickening.

"I was drinking - we all were, but I wasn't paying attention and the drink was so much stronger then what you could find in the hills. I made a fool of myself. I was behind in the game - al lthe cards were blurring together - too many rules, such a complicated game. My last waking memory was placing a bet…I had run out of coins, but hey, the Champion of Humans couldn't loose, right? Instead of folding, I placed something on the table - something from a family… an heirloom. A pendant made of metal and stones." She took in a shuddering breath, nausea rising in her belly, the memory yanking at her heart. "I don't know if it was valuable… but it was precious to someone…" Adora gave a tight laugh that turned into a sob

" And that was it. I'll never know what happened the rest of the night - I drank too much, and I blacked out, and when I came to all I had were my clothes. Everything else, the history of my town, the hopes and dreams, the family heirlooms, *all* gone." She snapped her mouth shut as a wave of nausea overtook her. Catra rubbed her shoulder wordlessly. "Maybe I gambled them away, or maybe someone knocked me out and stole them. When I woke up the hangover was horrid and I stupidly went to tell my officer what happened - all my woes - I thought he was my mentor! But he wasn't and I was nothing to him." She said bitterly.

"I had missed role call. I was a liability- no control, couldn't handle my drink. I didn't know that they would discard *me* , the Champion of Humans, so easily. It turns out that there were many champions. He scolded me for carelessness and didn't bat an eye at my losses. I realized then, that country kids did this all the time… *god* ."

If only they gave her a second chance, dammit!

"I was out. I didn't know how to find work. I didn't know *how* to work, I barely knew how to read, and no one wanted to hire an innocent country bumpkin. I worked at vegetable stands and as a bar boy, and then was picked up by the harbor crew because they offered better wages and they could recognize a desperate human from a galaxy away. Been there ever since. I slept on the streets, in a few warehouses," - *in the beds of a few ladies,* but she didn't want to say that to Catra, " - then finally saved up to rent a bed, then a room here. My jacket was the only thing left from home that I have, so…..so, yeah. That's how I got to Brightmoon. And that's how I got this jacket."

She let the silence fall, let the aching in her chest overcome her. Broken promises and withered dreams, all of it wreaking of betrayal and her insatiable pride from the past. Disgusting.

She felt something wet on her shoulder and watched Catra quickly wipe a tear out of their eye.

"Adora, you didn't—"

"Don't, Catra. I can't. I just…don't."

Adora pleaded. She knew what Catra was going to say - *it wasn't your fault, you're not a bad person, you didn't know any better.* Lies. Lies to make her feel better. All if it was still her doing, her responsibility.

Catra shrank away and nodded. Adora hated snapping at them but it was too much. This was the first time she told the full story and it felt like her heart was being ripped to shreds. The wound, the horror, the disappointment was as fresh as the day it happened.

"I - okay, Adora. Let me know when."

They lay in silence while Adora breathed, grinding her teeth.

"What about you?" Adora said, hoping to be distracted.

"Huh?" Catra had been lost in thought.

"The jacket."

"Oh," Catra paused, coming back to the present. "One day I woke up with it.

"What?!? You just woke up? Who gave it to you? Where were you?" Adora hissed.

"I- I don't know! I was asleep on a street! Okay, I was a kid!!" They cried defensively.

Catra said it as if it were the simplest thing. Adora felt ill. Kids shouldn't sleep on cold streets.

"Oh."

"Yeah." Catra cleared their throat haughtily, "So, as I was saying. I fell asleep one night and then I woke up and this great thing was over me!" They smiled at the fond memory, as if that was a complete retelling of the story.

There was…so much Adora didn't know how to ask. So many pieces that Catra wasn't telling her. "Could you maybe…back up

and start at the beginning?”

Catra looked irritated. “That was what happened! Plain and simple!”

“I mean the streets part. Where are you? Where was your family?”

“Ohhhhh,” Catra nodded, “right, country bumpkin over here.”

Ugh.

Catra cleared their throat. “There's a lot of stray magikits in the big cities east of Brightmoon- I was one of them. Something about hybrid migrations and then being stuck in slums by the city officials, diseases, blights, you know, that shit. There’s a lot less trade in that area, so a lot of folks are down and out. Humans, orcs, hybrids - everyone. I don’t know who my family was, I was just like all the other kits around, sorta raised each other and lived in streets and little shelters, using the different social services who gave free food and free school. Half- feral you know?”

No, Adora did *not* know.

“Old magicats would teach us things. But we had to watch out too- there were people who did bad things to magikits so you always had to be weary. Something about ears and tails make some people think we’re *actual* cats and things get bad… humiliating.”

Adora felt another wave of nausea at the thought of her Catra as a kit, being chased around, taunted, hurt -

“Anyways,” Catra waved dramatically, “I hung around a few alleys and there was always this old guy in a window who would watch us play and fight. I didn’t like him, I thought he was one of those nasty guys who didn’t like magicats or captured the kits and was mean to them.” Catra huffed and looked at their audience of one, preening with the attention, “ Well, one night I got in a fight and had to hide out. The sun was setting - it's best to find a place to

hide and sleep instead of roam the streets when you're a kid, *especially* a kit," They glared at the wall, " So I holed up in the alley, and then I saw him watching me. He smiled and it was creepy. I hissed and hid, waited till he was gone, then hid again. Not too well, apparently. I woke up a few hours later, nice and warm but I couldn't see - everything was dark and I thought I'd been captured. I scratched and fought until I realized I was under a jacket. When I poked my head out, I was still in the alleyway but this was over me." They pointed at the jacket, happily. "There were even a few fish snacks in the pocket!" Their tail swished happily.

Adora watched in awe.

"I knew it must've been the man! No one else knew I was in the alley. Who else could it have been!? The sun was about to rise so I scrambled to his window but couldn't see. I went out on the street and there was a little crowd around a dead body. The man, he had died that night, while walking up the stairway in the early morning. He had been outside - there was mud on his shoe and his footprints lead back to the alleyway I had hid in." Catra smiled warmly.

Adora gasped, a tear dropping from her eye.

"It -" Adora's voice was scratchy in her throat. "It was him, right. And then he died?" *The tragedy. Gods. Catra didn't even get to meet him* .

"Don't cry, Adora, he was ready to go. I overheard a neighbor saying that he had predicted his time was coming soon, that he had been slowly giving away his possessions." Catra said dreamily.

Adora was stunned. "Wow."

"Right?" Catra looked like a happy kit. "A guardian angel."

Adora just blinked, trying to will the tears away. She would have to cry about it later when Catra wasn't around. Between her story

and this one, she felt raw and tender.

“You know how special these jackets are?” Catra broke the silence.

“How?” Adora rasped.

“Very, they’re ancient.” Catra said reverently, their eyes glinting. “Killing dragons and making garments has been outlawed for over *four* centuries. These have lasted all this time.”

Adora’s mouth dropped. “You’re shitting me.”

No way. “ These had to be made more recently - probably illegally! “

“Nope, we can go to the library to see.” Catra said proudly. “Authentic ones have an insignia. Both of ours have them. I checked yours the first night I slept here, don’t worry.” They winked flirtatiously.

“Library?” Adora didn’t even know there was a library in Brightmoon.

“Yeah,” cried Catra, “There are hundreds!!”

“Can I go in?”

“Yeah silly! They’re public. We should go sometime.”

“Oh! Okay!” Adora was excited. A *library.* She didn’t know she was allowed inside those places, but apparently, she was.

They lay in happy silence for a few moments.

“Adora…” Catra started hesitantly in a cautious tone.

Ah shit.

“Yes?” She ground out.

“Out of curiosity, what game were you playing when you, you know…”

“Lost all my town’s heirlooms? Yeah, I don’t want to talk about it.”

“Please! Seriously, I just need to know.”

“Why?!” Adora spat. “What does it matter?”

“It matters because,” Catra shifted uneasily, “it might not have been so much your fault as you think.”

Bullshit.

“Bard’s Barhand. And why the fuck would that make a difference.”

Catra’s eyes flared in recognition and sharp anger. Actually, they looked enraged. Adora shrank, suddenly terrified - what had she done this time?

“I knew it!” Catra hissed, seething. “Adora, you were duped. You didn’t stand a damn chance.” *What? Where was this coming from?*

“You know why hill folk are known as the dumbest - *which they aren’t* - it’s because they fall victim to the most scams. It’s unfair. People prey on them and petty thieves and strangers take advantage.”

Adora felt her own anger flair, “Do you?” She asked accusingly.

Catra scoffed in exasperation, clearly offended. “Oh please, me?! I’m the ethical theif, remember?” They looked at her crossly, “I don’t do that shit to people - only the high and powerful. Innocent hillfolk don’t have much to begin with. It's just wrong.”

“Oh, sorry.” Adora shrank.

“Yeah, *anyways* . Bard’s Barhand is a complex strategy game, Adora -”

“ - Yeah, I know -”

“- and no one should have let you play, or bet so heavily. It’s a game which, *weirdly* , players get a bit honorable about, even if their high criminals. To dupe a hill kid into gambling their life away just… terrible form. Besides!” Catra gestured wildly, “they probably drugged you! And!” They got even angrier, “Adora, if you hadn’t had your shit stolen that night, it just as easily could’ve happened the next! It could have been confiscated by the knights, for fuck’s sake. Everyone knew what you had in your bag - you were a target from day one!”

Adora wanted to argue, but…something rang true.

“I still should’ve -”

“Yeah? You still should’ve done what, Adora? Face it…this was all sort of a set-up. Your town ment the best, but sending a kid off with family heirlooms and gold to a huge city isn’t exactly great judgement. And you didn’t *know* about the heavy alcohol, or how to play a complicated game. And everyone *knew* you had a good catch in your bag.” Catra sighed. “You gotta stop blaming yourself so much. It was all a fucked up set up. I’ve seen smart city thieves get tricked like that - being drunk and talked into a complicated gamble. It’s not fair.” Catra shook their head in disgust.

“I can never go back to my town.”

“You haven’t been back?” Catra shot up in surprise, “why not?”

“The disappointment.” Adora groaned into her hands.

“Adora…I’m sure that seeing you again would make their days. They might think you’re dead. So what if you never made it to the

army? It’s probably best - you’d likely be dead! Or a complete asshole. They knew what might happen if you left with valuables, so they were probably prepared to lose them.”

Adora shook her head.

She didn't believe everything Catra just said, but the burden felt lighter now.

“C’mon, just.. think about it.” Catra said softly.

Adora nodded, thinking quietly.

“Lets go to sleep.” She said abruptly.

“Oh - uh, okay.” Catra said nervously. “Are you - mad?”

“Don’t wanna talk about it.”

Catra shrank away. Adora reached out and stroked their ear reassuringly and pulled them to her chest.

“Adora,” Catra spoke in the dark, “I need you to promise me something,”

Adora grunted.

“If I ever give you something valuable,” Catra started, “and you lose it, or it gets stolen, I want you to come back to me, okay? Really. That's what matters.”

Adora felt the breath hitch and catch, tears falling. She pretended they weren’t there. Catra’s words hung in the air.

“Okay,” she croaked.

“Good,” Catra whispered and kissed the back of her hand, graciously pretending the tears weren’t there either.

Adora held Catra tight, more for her own sake, and felt their body ease into sleep, the sack of soothing herbs was tucked beneath a

pillow.

Adora watched the moon from the window, the same moon that shone down on her that horrible, fateful night of loss and gambling, the same moon that shone down on her now, on the night of what was, perhaps, the beginning of her own forgiveness.

Adora looked down in resignation at the old washroom.

It was her third today, in addition to scrubbing the first two floors of the ancient structure. There were three more floors to go.

The hold herbalist lived in an impossibly narrow and tall house smushed between other - albeit much shorter - houses a few long blocks away from her shop.

Payback indeed.

Adora had smiled widely as she and Catra arrived that morning, well rested and ready to work, but one look at the old magicat's blank face and Adora groaned inside. She *knew* this day was going to be bad. She had tried so hard to smile and be overly thankful and sweet, but the woman took none of her friendly advances and instead shoved a few buckets and sponges in their hands.

Catra hadn't been much help in the moment, avoiding eye contact with their tail between their legs, clearly still embarrassed from their childish behavior at the shop yesterday, and their new obsession with herbs used to calm kits.

The old magicat had given them harsh directions for cleaning and smiled wryly when she said " *perhaps you'll find hidden treasure."* Which was stupid because you don't find *'hidden treasure'* in

someone else's house - that means you just found something they left around, and if you take it that's called *stealing.*

She rolled her eyes at the toilet and sank to her knees. Magicats were thankfully cleaner than humans, but still. This house had clearly seen many a magicat grow up based on the deep scratches on the floors, the walls, the ceiling - practically everything spoke of tiny claws learning to scratch and climb.

Maybe this was love , she thought as she set to work, because Catra had completely shirked their duties and became fascinated with just about every aspect of the house.

Adora loved the house too of course - it was both of their first times inside a building that had been designed by and for magicats and there were noticeable differences. There were the classic high beams that criss-crossed just below the ceilings, an enormous tree trunk that ran through five floors, large holes cut out to accommodate it's girth and provide a way to magicats to move about the house at lightning speed.

There were inset nooks and crannies at all heights on all the floors, where a magicat of any size might crawl into for burrowing of quiet time, and large windows for sunbeams and observation. There was plenty of view of the street, which Adora learned was helpful for a sense of security. Large, replaceable scratch posts made of wood were everywhere and cushions were abundant.

The house smelled dense and old too, which Adora suspected was really a complex blend of magicats that resided here, and herbs that were perfect for magicat health. As Catra entered the building, Adora watched their entire body perk up, nose immediately twitch uncontrollably, eyes wide and pupils blown in interest, tail swishing in excitement. It was fantastic, and Adora realized with a pang of sadness that she would never be able to experience the world like Catra did, never be able to pick apart the individual scents in the air and respond to the texture of the walls in the same way.

Ah well, at least she could live vicariously through Catra and get off on happy they were.

The one drawback was that Adora was the only one cleaning. For *hours.* She could hear Catra scurrying around the house, jumping across beams and running up and down the tree.

When they first entered Catra had kicked off their boots and dropped onto all fours, running furuiosly towards the large tree, then completely vertically. They did it about ten times in a row out of sheer excitement once the old magicat waved her permission. Adora watched Catra panting and yelping with joy, their strong hands flexing and claws sinking into the wood while body gracefully moved through space.

She had never seen Catra so happy and carefree, and Adora really wondered what exactly their past had been like. Surely they had scrambled around in rafters and scaled walls - Adora knew that. But maybe it was something about being in a home, all the smells and tastes, the thrill of exploration in a safe place. No danger at all, just room to be themself.

Yeah, that must be it.

The old magicat looked on with a tired expression, but Adora didn't miss how her ears twitched and tail flicked happily as she watched Catra bolt around.

Adora scrubbed away while Catra continued their thorough, multi-sensory exploration of the house. She could hear Catra's claws on the floor above her currenty, then a soft thump- they probably just leapt up in a little loft to poke around. That was another thing - they had been down on all fours for almost the duration of their time here, which was something Adora had *no clue* was possible. Apparently, it was natural for magicats to move like that. Again, a wave of sadness washed over her as she realized this was another thing Catra had never let her see.

Adora sighed. As annoying as it was to do this by herself, she was happy that Catra was exploring, she just wished she could do it alongside them and learn.

"You missed a spot." Came a flat voice came from behind her.

Gods, did this woman have any other tone?

"Erm, yes," Adora bit back her irritation, "I was actually starting here and going to move there next."

"Hmmph" grunted the woman. She stood there watching Adora for what felt like an invasive amount of time.

Adora finally spoke, turning to ask a question that had been bothering her ever since they entered.

"Do you think…that maybe…Catra hasn't been their full self with me?" She asked delicately, " I mean - in a magicat sense. Like, being with a human, they might not let themself behave in all the ways they need to?"

Adora looked at the woman, silently, for a long time.

She looked at Adora dully and opened her mouth. "Obviously." She said with detached judgment.

Damn, tell me how you really feel.

"Oh. why?"

The woman scoffed. "Adora, really. How dense are you?"

Ouch. Mean!

She continued "Of course Catra's been hiding from you! The whole city is run by humans with human sensibilities - architecture, noise levels, street design, laws, industry - gods, it's a miracle any magicats live here at all!" She gestured angrily.

"And I'm sure Catra doesn't want to scare you off with any *weird* , *strange* things a magicat might do. They didn't get proper modeling from older magicats, so I doubt they even understand what all their impulses and instincts mean - lots of self judgment." She blinked in annoyance, then turned towards Adora to point accusingly. " And then there's you! Looking strong and golden and perfect, clearly with very little knowledge of magicats, never bothering to read a book or learn much or how to *communicate* with us,-" Adora felt a flash of anger" – and then Catra wanting to give you everything so you'll keep them around," she gestured at the air, clearly growing more agitated.

Adora felt a flush and rage and a pit in her stomach. *How dare this woman..*

The woman continued on her angry rant "...not to mention that Catra was *clearly* schooled by humans who indoctrinated them on how to *move* and *act* and *be* in the world." She snapped her gaze to Adora.

"Magicats are *very loyal.* " She hissed with a fire in her eyes, "much more than *humans.* So, have you got what it takes? Or are you just going to let them shower you with gifts, and then back out whenever you please." She looked at Adora threateningly.

Bullshit.

If this wasn't an ancient old magicat in a stupid flowery nighgown she would be standing up and swinging fists. Adora felt hot tears in her eyes, she didn't know what the fuck she had done to deserve this demeaning lecture, but it was humiliating and enraging to be treated like this.

"I believe," she growled through clenched teeth, " you might have missed the fact that I am trying to *restructure my entire life* around a magicat that I have welcomed into my home gladly," she felt her voice rising, anger and sadness bubbling over, "and the fact that I am willingly scrubbing twenty years worth of grime

from your house *by myself* because I want my *mate* to have the time to explore whatever they want!"

There was a loud crash above them and Adora heard Catra cursing, trying to reassemble something that had broken. She winced, no doubt Catra' impeccable hearing had picked up Adora's slip, calling them *mates* . They hadn't even talked about it, but there it was out in the open. *Shit.*

"And," Adora hissed, "I'll have you know that I came from an isolated hill town, barely know how to read, and only learned that *I* could go inside a library *for free* yesterday. So yeah, I haven't read a book on magicats because I didn't *fucking know they existed, or where to find them!* But you can be sure that I will be collecting everything I can from now on!" She choked on the last few words, biting back tears.

A tear streaked down her cheek as she clenched the scrub brush.

Fuck! She didn't want to cry, but the level of blame and judgment the old magicat was throwing at her was outrageous! She didn't know there were books on these things! How magicats liked to live, to move, to act, or what they liked in their dwellings and homes! Catra was the only magicat she knew, and Catra didn't even know those things about their own kind!

The old magicat looked a bit taken aback. "I see," she said, but her tone was noticeably kinder, almost embarrassed.

"Well," she muttered, "that clears that up."

"*What!? Does that clear up?!"* Adora said sharply.

The woman blinked at her cooly, composing herself. "I couldn't help but have some reservations, some humans don't have the best … *intentions* with magicats."

Adora grimaced, thinking of Catra's story last night.

“Yes,” Adora croaked, realizing the old woman was only trying to protect Catra, “I heard about that. I can assure that’s not me.” She grumbled, pride still hurt.

The woman nodded in silence. “I’ll go get you a snack,” she muttered, a peace offering. Adora nodded and faced the wall, trying to calm down.

There were a few moments of silence as Adora began to scrub again, soap suds mixing with tears, when she heard a shuffle behind her and turned to see Catra in the doorway, tail between their legs, broad muscular shoulders slouching, looking guilty and nervous.

“Adora - I - um,” they rubbed the back of their neck and looked away like a small child, “I didn’t mean to make you angry - I um, I just got so excited -” their voice was cracking, tears threatening to spill.

Adora was mystified - *what was happening?*

“I didn’t mean to leave you to do all the work - I just -,” they had crept over and picked up a sponge, nudging into a corner. “I just, got excited, that’s all. I didn't mean to leave you. That was selfish, I’m sorry.” They muttered quietly, sniffing. Their hair was plastered down with sweat from all the jumping and playing, but now they just looked sad, twinkle in their eyes long gone.

Catra could be so annoying sometimes.

“Nope!” Adora said, putting on a firm smile. “No, no, no Catra, I’m not mad at *you,”* she said assuringly, “I was mad at the old lady for doubting me so much. I *want you* to run around the house -”

“-no Adora, it’s work we should both be doing -”

“No! Catra. You have your exploration. Go, I want you to have some fun. After the past few days you deserve it.” Adora pushed a

bit more.

She continued. “C’mon, it’s like you’re doing…research! Yeah, I mean, how else are we going to know what’s best for you - *for us* - if you don’t do research, you know? Leave the scrubbing to me. I wasn’t upset with you, it was her, okay?”

Catra looked guilty still, kneading a sponge anxiously, “Yeah, but…” they said in a small voice. It was strange to see them like this, muscle bound and fit, scruffy and handsome, but trying to collapse in on themself with shame and discomfort.

“No buts, get out of here.” Adora chided.

Catra ducked their head, “Really, I don’t think I should get to -”

“Catra,” Adora said in a warning tone. Because it was actually getting annoying. “Leave. *Now* .”

Catra’s tail switched nervously. “Go on, I need you to report back on everything you liked and didn’t like, c’mon, I’m serious.”

Catra was scared, unsure of what to do. Adora imagined them suddenly as a kit in the free education programs - caught between the demands of their natural born instincts and the strict instructions of human teachers.

Adora tried the only thing she could think of and… hissed.

Catra broke into squeaky laughter, light returning to their eyes. They backed out of the room and dropped on all fours. Adora threw them a wink and watched Catra blush.

“Let me see how fast you can climb up to the top floor and back here,” she wiggled her eyebrows flirtatiously. “C’mon, show me what you got.”

Catra smirked then took off faster than Adora had seen in her life.

It sent butterflies all through her body.

They returned moments later, panting, grinning from ear to ear, proud as could be.

Adora leapt up and shook off her gloves and laughed, then lunged at Catra who easily dodged the attack. They cackled happily.

“Show me what you’ve found?” Adora said encouragingly. Catra looked bashful, embarrassed and excited, as if they found a secret they were supposed to keep but were dying to spill. It was almost bittersweet, to watch this tough creature revert to what Adora suspected was their shy kit self. A child self that never got to play like this, in a home that smelled of magicat generations and safety, where the walls, ceilings and floors welcomed their primal instincts and body.

“Well, really - um, I haven’t found much -” they were blushing and looking away doleful. Adora rolled her eyes.

“Well, I guess I’ll have to explore on my own.” Adora sighed, then made a brave attempt at jumping and grabbing a thick beam above her head. Catra yelped - a truly adorable reaction - elated to see Adora hanging from the beam, and leapt gracefully up on top to look down at her with enormous, excited eyes. “I bet you can’t climb up here,” they whispered tauntingly.

“I bet - I - ah! I bet I can!” Adora huffed and struggled, finally hoisting herself up to the beam, enjoying the sight of Catra licking their lips as they watched her body flex and pull.

Adora clambered on top of the beam, them clutched at it with her whole body for dear life. Holy shit. She was terrified.

But she grinned at Catra. “Okay, show me the way.”

Catra snickered, “there is *no way* you’re gonna keep up with me.”

Adora rolled her eyes. That much was obvious, but she sure as shit going to try - it was her turn to experience Catra’s world, to put their methods first, to move in ways she didn’t understand and follow a magicat’s instinct rather than human’s; after all, hadn’t Catra been molding their behavior into what was acceptable to humankind for years, sacrificing their needs along the way?

Yeah .

How else was Adora going to learn how to be the best mate - ah, *roommate* - if she didn’t follow Catra’s lead like this.

Adora spent the next few hours on a guided tour of everything that Catra loved about the building. They were more talkative than Adora had ever imagined they could be, animating their speech with gestures, laughing emphatically, childish and excited to run around rooms on all fours. Adora tried to do everything they did - climbing on the beams, scaling the tree trunk, wedging herself into small crawl spaces and the cubby-like nest nooks that were built into the walls. There were so many of them - she insisted on trying them all, but stopped after nearly getting stuck in one.

She watched Catra as they yammered on, growing more emotional and excited, pausing to stop and sniff different areas, to point out small discoveries they had made. Adora interrupted with questions - *what smells do you like* - *what are the best textures in the room* - and discovered that Catra had been testing all the large scratch posts and found a favorite, and had taken it upon themselves to knead every pillow in sight, many of which were made from a special blend of rip-proof fabric.

They dragged their claws along the walls idly, pointing out interesting things that only a magicat would find; a place where some type of plant was packed into the stucco, an different

building material, the arched doorways, colors, angles, and the symmetry and layout of the room - all sorts of details that had been designed to mimic traditional building styles and provide gentle stimulation for magicat brains. Catra didn't know *why* they liked certain things, but they did; Adora assumed it was some inherent need that was at last being met.

Catra spent a long time making disparaging, judgmental remarks about a large box of magikit toys they had found, which was an automatic signal that Catra had absolutely indulged in ' *researching'* the toys and desperately wanted to continue. Adora made a mental note to try to track some down and purchase them under the guise of admiring the design.

They wandered from floor to floor, circling back naturally to places Catra gravitated towards as Adora listened politely, making every effort to memorize each detail. She wanted to absorb as much of this as she could in order to carry it with her to be the absolute best that she could be.

At last, they arrived back at the room where Adora's scrub brush awaited her. Catra looked like an exhausted kit (something Adora would *not* be verbalizing), worn out from a day of exploration and learning. Which was about right - Catra *was* experiencing the right environment for the first time, unlocking old impulses, and their senses must've been on pure overload. *Much like a human toddler learning about the world.* Adora pondered this, then scolded herself for thinking about rugged, sturdy Catra like a baby.

Catra gave an enormous yawn, slumping a bit and leaning heavily into Adora.

"How many times did you run up that tree do you think?" Adora wondered out loud.

Catra simply shrugged and yawned again, slouching more. Adora could *feel* the energy leaving them.

She looked around, then dragged a large pile of pillows out from the other room and pushed Catra down. They protested weakly. "No, I'll help you!"

"No, you'll sit down and rest."

Catra struggled up. Adora sighed, then threw herself down on the pillows (so soft!) and Catra happily joined her, curling up next to her and giving another squeaky yawn, then slipped off to sleep promising it was just a short nap. Adora pretended to sleep for a few minutes, then silently snuck off to continue cleaning. After all, Catra had stayed up for the past four days and nights to instinctively protect Adora, their senses so rattled they couldn't relax, and they needed to rest.

And Adora had a debt to repay and a relationship to build with this old angry magicat, who was clearly a new, grumbling blessing in her life.

Together

Chapter Summary

Good times. Hard times, Fluffy times. Smutty times.

goodboi4goodboi

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"A good day, right?"

Adora yawned as she got into bed while Catra hung their jackets up. Her room felt even smaller, colder, the drafty window leaking frigid air and the mood of the building felt gloomy after a day in the warm, cozy, sun kissed house that was perfect for Catra. For them *both* .

Catra nodded silently, peering out the window that looked directly to sea without a building between to break the wind, then around the room as if they too were experiencing the same, deep chill from the surrounding walls.

"Yeah…it was good." They said quietly, ears low.

Adora cocked an eyebrow, "you alright over there?"

Catra ducked their head. "Yeah, I - well, I still left you to do all the cleaning, so…" they sighed again, "sorry." Their tail switched around in embarrassment.

"Ppshhh!" Adora shrugged, "stop it! That was fantastic. I needed you to explore the house, remember? We'll never find a good place if you don't figure out what we need. Besides…I like seeing you having fun."

Catra blushed as their ears perked up hopefully, then sank a bit. “Yeah, but Adora…what about you? What do you want?”

“Me?!” Adora laughed, “Catra, I want to live with *you* .”

Catra glowed, “yeah, but what do you actually want. Besides living with me?”

“Well,” Adora sighed, “if you must know - I have low standards. *Really* low standards. All I want,” She looked off dreamily into the darkness beyond her window, “all I want is a room with a big bed - one that I don’t fall off regularly - and then a small kitchen or fireplace to cook with.” She could feel tears gathering in her eyes. It had been *so long* since she had a way to simply heat water for tea, let alone cook a meal. She ached to feel the warmth of a room like her childhood, toasty and sweet, full of familiar smells, and she had been pining for the stews that she ate growing up. With a fire and a pot, she could easily make it.

“Adora?” Catra said softly, reaching out to hold her big hand.

“Oh! Yeah?” She shook her head to clear the memories.

“I’d love to find a place where we can give you a big bed and a fire.” Catra said gently.

Adora nodded silently.

They sat quietly for a moment, then Catra pulled off their shirt - *giving Adora a fantastic view of that damn body*-then stripped down to their briefs and slipped into bed with Adora to sprawl on her chest.

“Adora,” Catra started hesitantly.

“Hmm?”

“Today you said…something,” Catra glanced at the wall to avoid eye contact as they gripped her arm - a new habit that told Adora

that they were nervous. Adora felt a knot in her own stomach in response.

“I said a lot of things. Which one?”

“Well, I guess a few of them. But,” Catra took a deep breath, “it was when you were yelling at the old lady.”

Adora flushed in shame. It was not her finest moment at all. “What about it?”

She asked, then immediately realized what this was about. *Mates.*

She had called Catra her mate. They needed to talk about it, even though she didn’t want to at all. Because talking about it meant asking, and asking meant it would be *real.* She’d never had a mate - as hybrids would say- and she’d never had a partner - as humans would say; and she, Adora, the ex-champion of the humans, was completely terrified.

This would mean … definition.

Why was she even scared though? They were going to move in together already.

“Oh, um,” Catra’s tail thumped nervously, “you don’t remember?”

There was a hint of sadness in their voice.

“Oh, yes. I remember. I mean, gods, I said so much. Most of it was me and my big mouth getting carried away. Just…emotions, you know.” She laughed nervously.

“Oh. Yeah.” Catra said in a tiny voice. Adora held her breath.

“I guess…” Catra started, “well, no, never mind. Let's just go to sleep.” They muttered. She couldn’t see Catra’s face but their tone sounded dejected, and she could feel the, were withdrawing and closing up.

Ah shit.

Why was she like this?

What did it matter? A label was just a label. They were committed. Catra was loyal and so was Adora. So again, why did it even matter?

As if on cue, an horrible vision of the near future invaded her thoughts: one of their shared room, Adora sitting in their shared room, waiting at home for Catra to return from work. The vision flashed to Catra…Catra was in some alleyway, fucking a handsome stranger that did things to them that Adora couldn't. In the vision Catra purred and whimpered with pleasure as they had shattering orgasms, dripping on the cobblestone in the arms of a stranger that was so much better than Adora ever could be. They finished fucking, Catra kissed the stranger goodbye, then sauntered back to their new home.

" *Well, you and I aren't mates!,"* They reasoned with Adora as she broke down in tears, " *we're roommates who fuck. I'm still loyal to you, I just didn't know it would hurt you."* Vision-Catra said nonchalantly.

And it was true. Because Adora didn't have the guts to speak the truth that one time in bed.

Real Adora snapped back to reality in the dark boarding room with Catra tucked under her arm.

"MATES!" She blurted.

"What!?" Catra jolted in surprise.

" I said a lot of things today," Adora felt Catra's eyes on her, "I accidentally called us mates."

She felt Catra tense up, waiting. “Yeah?” They said in a cracked whisper, as if speaking too loud might shatter the moment.

“Yeah,” Adora cleared her throat. “It just slipped out. I’ve never had a mate, I don’t know what it means. But I know that I like you - *a lot* - and I want to be around you as much as I can, and I don’t want to be with anyone else. Romantically. Or, like, um. Fucking” The closed her mouth, heart racing.

Catra held their breath. Adora could feel their tail twitching.

No one spoke.

Catra finally cleared their throat. “I’ve never had a mate either.” They whispered. Adora was flooded with relief. Catra continued. “I think it means whatever we want it to mean.” They said hoarsely, “but, well. I don’t want to be with anyone else in that way. And, um, it makes me happy that you don’t want to either.” They finished tensely.

Adora released a breath. The vision of the handsome stranger dissipated imediately, and she smiled into the dark. She couldn’t see Catra’s expression, but knew that Catra could see her’s. “Okay,” she whispered cautiously. Catra giggled in relief.

“So…” they started, “mates?”

Adora started to giggled too, then laughed softly, then harder. Catra joined in, and soon they were both howling. Tears began streaming down her cheeks and Catra squeaked, bubbling over with joy.“Yeah,” Adora panted between sobs, “mates!”

A massive *crack* made them both shriek as a muffled voice bellowed from the other side of the wall, “ *Can you shut the fuck up over there?!?”*

The two of them shoved their faces into the pillows and roared with laughter.

They faced each other in the dark at last having simmered down to soft giggles.

“Okay then,” Adora said softly.

“Yeah,” Catra replied. “Mates.”

Adora grinned back. “Mates it is.”

Catra smiled into the dark, then paused. “Don’t humans call it partners? Do you want to call us partners instead?”

Adora shook her head, remembered what the old magical said, “No, let’s call us mates.” She said definitively, and felt Catra’s shoulders relax.

“Okay,” sighed Catra. “Thanks Adora.”

Adora rolled her eyes. “Don’t thank me. I should be thanking you. You chose me.”

Catra shrugged. “Yeah, well, you chose me too.”

“No, it’s you,” she argued. Catra hissed.

They spent a few minutes arguing.

“Catra, one more thing,” Adora suddenly broke off.

“Hm?” Catra said sleepily. Adora remembered their big day of rolling around the house, exploring and playing. “The old lady, she said you were probably hiding things from me”

“Hiding things?! I’m not hiding anything!” They snapped defensively.

“No, I mean, not doing things - magicat things around me. Is - is that true?” She could feel Catra’s broad shoulders cave in. “Maybe.” They said quietly.

“Why?” Adora asked.

" I…" Catra started meekly, "well, I heard what she said, and I guess that's true. I was just doing it automatically. I didn't want to scare you? I dunno, it just happens around humans."

Adora nodded. Dammit. *Conditioning,* that's what is was called, right? Stupid fucking humans.

"Okay, well…" Adora started. "I want you to be yourself around me."

Catra scoffed, "easier said than done."

Adora nodded. "We'll work on it. I know I can be better about it too."

She knew she could she just wasn't sure how exactly, but she'd find a way.

"Why?" Catra asked suddenly.

"I want you to be happy." Adora tried her best to say what she was trying to say, "And I don't think someone can be happy if they can't do what they need to do. If we are going to live together, you need to be able to be your full self."

Catra didn't say anything.

"And I want to learn from you too."

"What?!"

"Yeah, magicat stuff is really cool," she felt ungraceful, but it needed to be said, " you know, it's neat how you can climb and smell things that I can't. It's a skill. I like watching you do it." She smiled. It was true.

"Y - you do?" Catra said softly. Adora's stomach dropped at the hesitancy in Catra's voice. How had she never said this before?

“Yeah! I love it. I have from the start. I’m sorry I never told you - I just thought you knew. Or like…it was just obvious.”

She felt like a fucking moron as she said the words, remembered flashbacks of Catra’s hesitancy, moments when they seemed to freeze their movements and the redirect in a mysterious way, then the strange insults she heard over her years in the city - things that involved the words *fur* and *fleas, stinking scales* and *animals.* She shuddered at her ignorance and obliviousness.

“I’m sorry,” she muttered in embarrassment.

“What?” Catra said in wonder. Their face was hot against her shoulder.

“I just…I’m sorry I never said anything sooner,” *and assumed that we were on equal footing this whole time.*

“Oh,” Catra’s voice cracked with warmth, “that’s okay.” She could hear the smile on their voice, oblivious to Adora’s realization. “You really think it’s cool?” They said shyly.

“Yeah.” Adora said firmly, because it was true. “I think it’s really, really cool. And I’m jealous in a way.”

Catra bristled with warmth.

“Catra, I know - *well, now I know* - people have given you a lot of shit for magicat stuff. I’m sorry I didn’t know before. But I want you to know that I think it’s really cool - and fucking hot - that you can do all this stuff.” Adora said with a blush.

Catra’s tail thudded against the wall happily and a soft purr rolled through their chest. “Yeah?”

“Yeah.”

“Thanks,” they said shyly.

“I’m sorry I didn’t sooner —“

“Hey, stop apologizing, okay?” Catra patted her shoulder encouragingly, “you didn’t know. You get a pass,” they said wickedly, “because you’re oblivious *and* from the high hills,” giving Adora’s should a firm pinch.

“Ouch!” Adora huffed. She didn’t feel like she should get a pass, but some of it was true…she didn't know - she knew she could be incredibly oblivious, often the last to pick up on things, and coming from the high hills felt like a huge gap in cultural city knowledge that most people took for granted. “Okay…well,” she sighed, “I’ll try to be better.”

“Alright,” Catra said happily, “but I don’t think you did anything wrong. I can’t blame you for not knowing. The more time I spend with you, the more I see how you’re still learning the city. It’s a big adjustment from the hills.”

Adora rolled her eyes. Yeah, it was, and at this point she should be adjusted by now. But… she wasn’t.

“Hey,” Catra poked her cheek, “cheer up. You’re doing good.”

Adora shrugged, suddenly feeling her own exhaustion from the day’s work.

Catra yawned too.

“Adora,” they said shyly, “thanks for today. I had…a lot of fun.”

Adora beamed. Fucking perfect.

“Good,” she said softly, “good, you deserve it all.”

Catra pushed closer. “Thanks,” they whispered, “never done that… before.” They yawned again. Adora pulled them tight. She could feel Catra slipping into unconsciousness.

“Here.” Adora said suddenly, rummaging under the pillow and pulling out the small pouch of herbs. Catra smiled lazily and

grunted. “Don’t need 'em. ” They mumbled, already falling asleep.

“Okay,” Adora muttered, listening for Catra’s snore. When she heard it, she promptly put the pouch on top of Catra’s face.

“There you go,” She whispered into the top of Catra’s head, then closed her eyes and sank into deep, heavy sleep.

The next morning was grey and drizzly, much like every other morning, except for the fact that Adora felt calm and rested, happy to be free of the burden of the docks. She lay in bed full of cheer despite the weather, relishing the fact that tonight she would not have to work in the freezing rain - she would *never* have to work in the rain at the shiping yards! This thought was followed with the bitter realization that without working in the rain, she would be making no money, and no money meant no … everything.

Shits, she had a new job, which was finding…a new job.

Catra awoke sleepily.

“What’s on your mind Adora? I can feel your thoughts.”

“Um, well,” she said nervously.

“You’re worried about work and money.” Catra mumbled through a yawn.

“How’d you know!?” Adora said in disbelief. Catra shrugged. “I could feel your thoughts.”

Adora sighed in aggravation.

The day began as they both walked into the square - Adora from the doorway of the house and Catra down scaled wall.

It was time to put the plan in action.

The following days were an adjustment.

Adora looked for work, quickly and anxiously. She helped at vegetable stands and restaurants day by day in an attempt to weevil her way into an official position. The labor was hard and she worked even longer days, often coming home at after sunset to face-plant on bed – but Adora counted the many blessings - free food, the smells of a fresh harvest, *not* working in perilous storms, no threat of drowning or being blown up, going to work in the morning and ending in the evening rather than a graveyard shift, and… *no* orcs.

Yes, a meager but very promising start to a new life.

Catra observed the warehouses from the crumbling building tops of the eastern city; as predicted the centers were overrun with patrols and soldiers, illegal strongholds busted and exposed. A definite no.

They found a few more days of paid work doing final wraps with the circuit and cleaned incriminating evidence where they could, but removed themselves quickly, sensing even greater problems approaching on the horizon. *Bail while you can,* advised the old herbalist.

But with years of connections in Brightmoon, Catra found work quickly; their first position was at a *legal* warehouse and shipping center. Magicat agility had many advantages: ability to scale walls, identify scents, and catalogue items quickly that a human could not. It didn’t pay nearly as well, but it was a sacrifice both were

willing to make. As long at the boarding house was in their grasp, they would make it work.

Life felt simultaneously harder and better all at once. The world was still cold and cruel: The rain was freezing, orcs still shoved Adora in puddles while walking home, humans taunted Catra, and saving money was even harder to pull off - the source of unexpected fights between the two of them.

And yet… they had each other. Every night now. Fighting meant making up and growing closer. Adora was blessed with the touch of the softest fur the color of rosewood in bed, cuddles and fucking, fresh fruits and vegetables each day after market, and an endlessly grumpy old magicat herbalist who was fiercely protective. A trade off that she was ready to make.

And then, the luckiest moon shone down on them one horribly rainy day. Catra had to take shelter in the library on their way back home, took the opportunity to do some browsing, and ran smack into a frantic librarian whose ladder had broken and couldn't access the high stacks. Catra fetched the books easily, charmed the librarian with their extensive knowledge of the library (which was really a thinly masked genuine obsession), and was immediately referred to an open position as a clerk and guard. As a magicat applicant, Catra's abilities carried significant weight - agile, impeccable eyesight and strong reading skills, able to reach high places, excellent hearing, mouse hunting (a secret hobby that Catra kept tucked away as to not be equated with an *actual* housecat), and extremely quiet when necessary. With a wink, the librarian told them that he would be putting in a good word for Catra.

That night Catra bounded in from the rain, brimming with excitement, dropped to all fours for a few stunningly fast zoomie sessions around the tiny room. Adora was beyond thrilled - a steady income and a happy Catra, all in one day! She had learned that magicats required a fair amount of peaceful solitude, which was perhaps why Catra had been living in a near constant state of agitation for the past decade as they worked in noisy shipping

centers and bustling industrial spaces. Adora thought happily about the fact that Catra would be able to read on the job, work shoeless due to safer work conditions, and the indoors were guaranteed to be warm and dry during storms. They would be required to work some night guard shifts at the library, and daytime assistance to gather materials from the high stacks.

As Catra retold the story for the fifth time that night, Adora watched a spark of that same kit-like joy she witness at the magicat house glittering in Catra’s eyes, yammering away like a child.

But funds were still stretched thin.

Over a very teary conversion they decided, if needed, they could sell a few of the more expensive gifts Catra had given Adora if money was too hard to come by.

Their housing search schedule was thrown off, but they took the time to read up on helpful designs and explore the sprawling city, looking for quieter neighborhoods and smaller streets closer to the library. Catra sniffed around to locate any magicat enclaves in the region - or anywhere with more hybrids- per Adora's request. She didn't want Catra to feel like the only one any more. The boarding house had human tentents only, and Adora was done with it.

It was a fortnight from their visit with the old magicat and they had finally narrowed their search down to two affordable places that would meet their needs.

Both formerly magicat homes and rented specifically to hybrids. One had tall ceilings with beams, but was smaller on the floor space. The other was a wider room, no beams, big windows. Both had plenty of space for a bed and a stove.

Trying out her role of supportive mate, Adora encouraged Catra to follow their heart and intuition, let their instincts guide the way. Catra had never had a home of their own, wasn't this the moment to let them step into their dreams, their independence, to put their needs before Adora's?

Yes. It was perfect.

Unfortunately, this sent Catra down into a multi-day spiral of panic, self doubt, and indecision.

Conversations were circular and frustrating before Adora figured out the source of the problem.

Catra paced around the room quickly, tail lashing, eyes flicking, looking every bit like an anxious kit.

"What if I make the wrong choice?

"You won't!" Adora said warmly, "They're both great!"

"What if one is better than the other?" Catra squeaked.

"They're both the same, but different." Adora said (for the millionth time).

Catra whipped towards her with a spark in their eye, as if they found the answer. "Which do you want?"

"I'm happy with either. Which do you like more?" Adora pinched the bridge of her nose.

"I don't know!" Catra waved their hands frantically, "Which one do you think *I* like more?"

Oh gods, this again. "I dunno Catra, that's up to you."

"What if we hate the one I pick?"

“Well, then we could move into a different place later?” Adora said meekly, patience drawing thin.

“What if we can’t!?”

“Then we make do?”

Round and round the conversation went. Adora was irritated and concerned at how agitated Catra would get.

Why were they like this? It was just a simple decision at this point - *both* places would be fine and met everyone’s basic needs and even some of the more advanced ones, and they had done multiple thorough assessments each night.

And then it hit Adora - Catra didn't know *how.*

They never had an indoor space that was all their own before; sure, they had made enough money to afford one in the past, but they hadn’t because…well, it just didn’t seem to occur to them. They had lived a transient life and settling down seemed oddly confusing to them, a dance they had never learned, a lesson that was never taught in school. And so…they just didn’t.

They made due with sleeping in rafters, or crafting little nests and nooks in warehouses, or the library after hours, or barns, or the shipping center - never establishing a place of their own because they didn’t really know what that entailed or how to begin.

Adora saw the error in her ways; in an attempt to give Catra a say in the process, to guide their own fate, to shape their own life, Adora left Catra at sea without a compass. Or a map. Or any sense of direction really!

Just like Adora felt when she landed in the city. She had to put together a roadmap by making mistakes and being screwed over. Catra had finally filled in the blanks for her in a few short moon cycles and kept her safe in ways she didn’t know she needed.

When it came to hearth and home, Adora had the road map - she knew what to do.

The night of her realization, Adora broke the code. “I think we should go with beam place.” She said definitively.

Catra’s shoulders sagged in relief.

“Oh thank gods!” They jumped up and wrapped their arms around her like she had pulled Catra out of the sea.

“You’re so dramatic.” Adora laugh.

“Well, I’m pretty far out of my element here.” Catra spat.

“Yeah, yeah. I’m sorry.” Adora said affectionately. “Didn’t realize that at first. How do you feel about that decision then?”

Catra looked up with wide, confused eyes.“What do you mean?”

“I mean, do you think you’ll be happy there? In the beam place?”

Catra shrugged. “I think so, I mean, when I try to imagine it my mind just sort of goes blank and I get sleepy. Or scared.”

Ah.

“Okay, well, let's give it a shot.” she said confidently, then added, “I chose it because I think that it’ll be fun to have higher ceilings, beams, and a few of those nook things. I know the windows aren’t as good as the other one, but I think it would be good to see what it’s like to live in a place where you can climb, you know?”

Catra just chewed their lip and nodded silently, broad shoulders still sagging with the release of tension. “Okay.” they said.

“I’m scared I’ll mess it up,” they blurted.

“What?” Adora drew back to look at them better.

“I’m scared I’ll mess it up.” The words tumbled out of their mouth. “I’ll blow up at you in an angry fight, or I’ll scratch all the walls up and break everything important,” they were breathing quickly, a rock-hard grip around Adora’s waist , “OR I’ll sleep in the nooks instead of the bed with you and then you’ll hate me and then we’ll break up and, and, -” before Adora knew it, they were crying into her shirt. She looked down at them dumbly.

Stars, this was a very stressed magicat.

“Um, okay.” She scratched the back of her neck, trying to figure out the right answers. “Well, first of all…I don’t think you’ll mess up. Second, if we get in a big fight one of us should just go take a walk and calm down.” She released a big breath and massaged Catra’s back, “ Third, we’re going to get you scratch posts so you can scratch to your heart's content,” Catra’s breath hitched and their tail twitched happily which was … incredibly endearing.

“Fourth, you are free to sleep in the nooks all you want because it’s only natural and I won’t be mad - it’s normal. But I think you’ll also like to sleep in our bed.”

Catra’s breathing had calmed, but they were still clamped around Adora like a lifeline.

“Okay,” they warbled. “You promise?”

Adora nodded, not exactly sure what she was promising, but feeling confident that she could. “Yeah, I promise. And we can work out whatever problems we have, okay? We already have! I’m not leaving you Catra.” She petted their hair softly.

“You’re sure? Even if I get angry at you?”

Adora chuckled. “Of course. Are you thinking of leaving me?”

Catra whipped backwards, aghast. “No! How could you say that!?” They spat.

Adora shrugged, “Well, you keep asking me, so I thought I’d make sure about you.”

Catra grumbled, slapped her in the chest lightly, then shoved her down on the bed. Adora shrieked with laughter.

“Shut up!” Catra grinned down at her as they leapt on her, muscular thighs wrapping around her hips.

“Make me,” Adora whispered in her most ridiculous, sultry tone.

Catra pinned Adora’s hands down against the mattress and lowered themself down to press into Adora’s mouth with a slow, warm kiss.

And five days later, they were out.

It didn’t take long to move out of the boarding house. Adora had more possessions then she started with, but that wasn’t much. Catra brought her a giant bag, packed everything up, then jumped out the window to meet Adora downstairs. They had rented a push cart from one of Adora’s bosses at a vegetable stand, and trundled all her possessions up hills and neighborhoods until they reached the old, tipping house of their new home.

It wasn’t much. But it was everything.

Another narrow building designed by and for magicats.

This one was even skinnier than the herbalist’s; each floor was it's ow room which had been outfitted with a tiny cooking area. A huge tree ran through the center of the structure with the passage hole to the next floors sealed off. It smelled of magicats and previous tenants, an unpleasant medley for Catra, but they

decided they could adjust as long as they took over the scent of their floor.

The walls were high and the room held an impressive amount of thick beams that formed a lattice work above their heads. Some radiated from the center tree like a wheel, while others stretched from wall to wall. Adora watched in as Catra shot up into the air and leapt around on the beams excitedly, muscles rippling and with a gleeful smile plastered across their face.

The two of them hauled Adora's belongings to the third floor while Catra brought things they collected from previous hideaways. It was late in the evening, after they had thoroughly chased each other around the room, met a few neighbors, and tried to find a system for Adora to access the beams (a ladder was in her future) that they realized they had no furniture.

After a night of poor sleep, Catra was off to the library and yet again, Adora found herself at the door step of her new favorite herbalist.

She painted a smile on her face, feeling a mild dread in her stomach and raised her hand.

The door slammed open before she could knock.

"Ah, hello,-"

" *What."* The old magicat spat.

Charming as always.

"Well, ah, thank you so much for letting us explore —"

"Get to the point," she said bitterly.

“Catra and I moved in and I need to find furniture they like and I was hoping you could tell me where you got yours because –”

“Hush.” She held up a commanding hand and Adora’s mouth snapped shut.

“Don’t worry,” she said sternly, “I have just the thing.”

Adora had envisioned buying new furniture for their home, for Catra. Or at least lightly used furniture.

Not years worth of well-used bookshelves, scarred armchairs, a bed frame, a rickety table and heavy bureau. Or the magicat's old scratch posts, which could be sanded, cut, then fused together to form a new one.

And no, Adora did not envision spending her day hauling a decades worth of furniture down five flights of stairs and into a cart, then pushing said cart up two massive hills to her new apartment. Nor did she envision herself having to haul *that* cart of furniture up three more flights of stairs to her new home.

No, she didn't envision repeating the process three times in a row either.

By the end of the day she lay exhausted on the wooden floor of the apartment, waiting for Catra to come home. Her muscles ached like no other. She could barely move

When Catra did arrive, they bounded through the door, took one look at Adora, then around the room, kicked of their boots and shot up into the beams and leapt about while laughing. They landed on the bureau, hopped on the table, then stopped on a beam only to look directly down at Adora, who remained a puddle on the floor. Catra’s eyes were full of electric excitement that glinting in the fading light.

“Hello handsome,” they said warmly.

“Muugghhg,” Adora groaned.

Catra snickered, “you decorated.”

“I furnished,” Adora said weakly. “No mattress.”

“No mattress indeed.” Catra purred.

“Pillows though,” Adora moaned.

“Pillows?!?! Where?!” Catra belted, so loud that Adora winced. They composed themself instantly, then quietly spoke “I mean. Pillows? Where are they?”

Adora grinned. “Bureau.”

Catra bolted over and ripped open the doors, squeaking as a few massive, sturdy kneading pillows tumbled out. Adora watched their tail flicking happily and smiled.

Soon Adora was dragged over to a pile of pillows covered with the soft animal hide and a few blankets, then dropped in after Catra changed her into comfortable clothes.

“You’re excited.” She mumbled into Catra's fur.

“Yeah!” they said loudly, kneading at Adora’s shoulder, “I am! The library was so…” they smiled dreamily, lost in thought. “Nice. Peaceful.” Adora saw a tear in their eye, “ and then I got to come home to… this!” they gestured at the room happily, and then were suddenly on their feet, then down on all fours running circles around the room, then up and down the tree trunk and across the beams.

Adora laughed again, but was far too exhausted to watch. She closed her eyes, just for a rest.

She woke up to Catra pushing a plate of food in her face. The room was dark except for a lantern that burned on the table and the eerie blue glow of a natural lighting crystal that Catra had ‘found’ while covertly cleaning up the remains of the warehouse.

“Is it bad to eat with your eyes closed? “ Adora mumbled.

Catra snickered. “Just don’t forget to chew…” was the last thing Adora heard.

The next time she woke up, everything was dark.

No moon, a soft rain outside, Catra pressed against her side with an arm wrapped protectively around her head. Adora gulped down water from the canteen Catra had thoughtfully tucked between a few cushions.

Once the last drop of water disappeared Adora knocked out into a heavy slumber.

“Yeah, that’s it.” Catra panted heavily in Adora’s ear.

After a few more days of working, funishing, and purchasing goods, they were in their new (big) bed.

“Make that sound for me Adora,” Adora shuddered and moaned while Catra continued the fast, hard, circular motion of their hand, thick furry arm flexing and flickering.

“What do you say to that, good boy? Hmm?” they whispered in a rasp, eyes glinting like the sexy fucking devil that they were. Adora felt another rush of liquid heat coursing through her body, swirling in her abdomen, spiking between her legs, nipples hard and sensitive as Catra pressed her up against the wall. Their chest fur was so soft, curling with sweat and heat. Catra laughed wickedly, hand clamped over Adora’s mouth firmly, thumb rubbing her chin, and pushing their face next to her's. Catra whispered again “You like that baby?”

Catra’s other hand was between Adora’s legs, palm pressing hard against her clit and making rough circles in that way that drove Adora crazy while she bucked against them.

“Hmmph!” Adora let out a strangled, muffled moan. *Holy shit* , this moment would break her, burned into her mind forever, would likely tip her over the edge of sanity and into lust filled oblivion forever more.

Fuck me. Was all she could think, *gods, please fuck me till I cry.*

It had all started about a half hour ago. Catra had gotten up to fo the washroom and when they came back, the air in the room had seemed to heat up ten fold. Adora had been innocently lying on her stomach and suddenly Catra was on top of her, caressing her back and stripping her down. Calloused fingers explored, massaging her ass, strocking up and down her legs while Catra’s breathing grew labored. Adora felt kisses on her feet and suddenly, chills were shooting through her spine, wet hot energy and desire pulsing around her. Catra had been so hungry and powerful, spreading Adora’s legs apart carefully, softly stroking the wet slick between her legs and purring deeply in appreciation. Adora’s body was on fire and she could *feel* Catra’s hand trembling with excitement, breath hitching, the tell-tale sound of their tail thumping against the mattress.

Fuck, all she could manage to do was fist the sheets and bury her scream in the mattress because she was going to be *loud* .

Catra's voice was gravily and deep, cracking with desire, "So wet," they muttered, "shit, you're soaking Adora, fuck," they were panting. Adora moaned and spread her legs wide, pushed her ass in the air. "Fuck, your ass is just - just -" she could hear Catra stutter, voice breaking with emotion and awe.

It wouldn't be the first time Catra cried like *that* while fucking. It had taken a long *, long* time to coax Catra into topping - they had relegated themself to (very happy, enthusiastic) bottoming all these years, terrified of clawing any partner they had been with. So when Adora eventually convinced them to just *try* (after begging like a groveling, desperate horny fool) Catra agreed. They were a bit of a shy mess when they started; so emotional and overwhelmed with the new role, suddenly having free reign, allowing themself to indulge in all the touches they had denied over the years. When Catra cried while topping, it usually meant that Adora was about to get the most mindblowing fuck she never dreamed of. Last time Adora was sitting in Catra's lap, riding and grinding against their hand and Catra nearly broke down in tears with pent up energy, then threw Adora around on the bed, pinning her down and licked her until she was a shuddering mess, wrecked by double-digit orgasms.

But that was then, and this was now.

Present day Catra pulled it together though with a heavy breath, "your ass is just, *fuck* , it's just *delicious, fucking enchanting"* they squeezed firmly, grasping her ass and twisting the flesh there, pinching and groping. Adora moaned and she felt catra's hand moving around, giving hungry squeezes and kneading her, hands ghosting up her spine and softly raking nails down the length of her back.

"Fuck," Catra was panting in awe, "so damn wet down here," both their hands were between Adora's legs now, fondling, pressing between her thighs, spreading her further apart; Adora felt hot breath on her lower thigh and flexed as Catra licked a stripe up the inside of her leg, then around the back to bite her ass cheek. *fuck!* Adora cried into the mattress, lifting her backside in the air

to show Catra were she wanted it, displaying her self, begging with her body. *Oh gods, please just fucking* -

Suddenly she felt Catra press their entire face between her legs, nose shoved deep into Adora's crotch, warm tongue pressed against her clit and folds like they were trying to consume her, hands roaming up and down her legs with an invasive hunger.

"Guuhhhhh," Adora shuddered into the pillow, listening to the slurping sounds Catra made while they pressed against her from below and ran their hands running up her torso.

"You're so handsome its fucked up," she heard Catra hiss, then they *spat* on her ass and dove back in. Adora was howling and came up for air.

"Catra, c'mon, c'mere." she panted, not knowing entirely *what* she wanted. Catra was suddenly right behind her head, baring down on her aggressively in that way that sent a shock down Adora's spine, "what do you want," Catra's voice was raspy and dripping with desire and disdain, "what do you want you dirty little prince?"

Adora gargled. She was going to die, this was so hot. The stuff of her fantasies in real life. Shit. She was blessed.

"Dirty," she panted. "My hair," she huffed. She could feel her arms burning from how hard she was griping the sheets, felt Catra slowly run their hands from Adora's massive shoulders down to her wrists, caressing along the way.

"Okay handsome," they said tauntingly, with a solid undertone of tenderness, "but I want you put your hands here." They guided her hands to the bed frame, "to brace yourself" they whispered into her ear, raising the hairs on her neck. She felt Catra's palms slide back up her arms like liquid, one hand lacing into Adora's short hair and twisting carefully until she moaned, the other sliding over her shoulder and then down the hot skin on her chest

to circle a rockhard nipple. “To brace yourself while a fuck you 'till you can’t think.” They growled harshly.

Fuck yes.

And then Catra was on her like a lightening whirlwind of red hot sex; hands everywhere, groping feverishly at her chest, running up and down her stomach, her back, pressing into her soft ass. Adora jammed her face into the matress and gripping the bed frame as she felt Catra’s mouth moving up and down her body like a flood, nosing between her legs forcefully licking, slapping at her ass.

“Handsome bastard,” they growled, flipping her over on her back, straddling her abdomen and squeezing her thick shoulders. Adora stared up and awe as Catra bore down on her, grinding their hips, eyes wide and glittering with lust, tail flying furiously through the air. They looked every bit the hunter and predator that a magicat could be; Adora the eager, willful prey. She soaking the sheet, grasping at Catra’s hips and whimpering softly.

And then Catra was just a breath away from her face, staring her down as sweat dripped down their forehead. Catra glared at her lips. "Open." Adora slowly opened her mouth, making a show of the submission. Catra silently observed her, then slowly spat into her open mouth and pushed two fingers inside. “Suck those for me,” they whispered harshly, “like a good boy.”

Adora thought her head might explode. Her heart was hammering in her chest, pulsing throughout her body.

Silence hung in the air as she closed her mouth and sucked the slowest, softest she could while holding Catra’s smoldering glare and watched their eyes widen, as if they were surprised at the turn of events. This shit always drove them wild, Adora knew. "*Hmmmm,"* she hummed for good measure, to ensure that Catra would be sufficiently worked up.

“Good boy.” Catra’s voice sounded dry. “Open up.” Adora obeyed.

Catra's hand covered her mouth, the other snaking down between her legs, and then there Adora was, pressed between the cold wall and heat of Catra’s body, moaning into Catra's hand and grinding heavily against their palm as they showered her with filthy compliments.

“Such a dirty thing,” they muttered, “shit you’re so gorgeous like this,” Catra growled, “I could fuck you forever, you know,” Catra’s eyes gleamed while Adora howled and jerked her hips faster and twisted. “Handsome fucker,” Catra spat while Adora grabbed their head and *pulled* Catra's face towards her chest. Catra’s eyes flew wide, “Shit! You are bad,” they hissed. Heat cracked between them as wet, squelching sounds filled her ears. Adora reached out again to grasp Catra's shoulders for support, clamping down to steady herself against Catra’s bulkly form. *Oh gods, oh fucking shit, oh fuck –*

The orgasm came from deep within, starting as a rumble and rolling through her in waves, a shock that coursed through her nerves as she fucked Catra’s hand, tears running down her cheeks and stifled yells. Catra’s tail was lashing furiously and their legs rubbed together, muscles rippling, “yeah, that’s it Adora, *come* . Like the good boy that you are,” voice gravily and wet in her ear, surrounding her, smothering her senses, “yes baby, just like that, yeah.” Catra muttered, “so handsome, so good to me,” they had switched gears from dirty degrading top into affirming angel top on a dime, while Adora continued to come, orgasms blending together into one long, vibrant intense moment that lasted for minutes.

Adora was shaking as Catra removed their hand from her mouth, then slowly pulled her in for a soft, wet, kiss, wiping a few tears from Adora’s cheeks.

“So hot,” they let out a soft laugh, sounding completely enamored, wrapping a strong arm around Adora’s hulking form. Adora curled into them as Catra’s hand gradually traveled from her groin to her ass, pulling her flush against them.

“Gods, Adora you’re just so…” Catra sighed like a ridiculous love-struck fool, a sharp contrast to the sexy, degrading tone from moments before. “So incredible. What do you need baby?” They were already opening the canteen at the ready, stroking Adora’s shoulders, kneading her arms, rubbing her cheeks like she always liked.

Adora looked on dumbly, soaking in the warmth around her, admiring Catra's damp, lush fur on their chest and inhaling the familiar scent. Images of their first meeting flashed through her mind, as she drank the water and opened her mouth to eat a piece of fruit Catra was shoving in her face.

After a short nap in Catra's arms, Adora mumbled " Will you take me on one of those things? You know…that you told me about?"

"Hmmm?" Catra said sleepily, petting Adora's bare back.

Adora wracked her memory, "Starts with a D? It's supposed to be fun?"

"Ah," Catra squeaked and chuckled " a date? You wanna go on a date?

“Yeah,” Adora said shyly, “I do. Sounds fun.”

Catra smiled, “Oh handsome, you have no idea what you're in for.”

“Hey,” Catra said softly, hours later, voice sparking with an idea. They had eaten the rest of a stew Adora had cooked the other day and immediately crawled back into bed to read.

“Hm?”

“I have a question.”

"Hmm?" Adora felt an anxious pull in her stomach, sensing something significant.

Catra's tail thumped in excitement. "Do you want to go on a trip? Like an adventure?"

Adora looked over curiously "With you?"

"Yeah," Catra said cautiously, "maybe."

Adora narrowed her eyes, suddenly suspicious. "What?"

Catra sighed, shifting their broad shoulders to face her. "Look, Adora," They picked up one of her hands and held it close, "I think it's a trip that you need to make - And I'd love to come. But it's a trip to a place you've already been."

This was so confusing, what the fuck was Catra even talking about, Adora hadn't been anywhere else in Etheria except… - it suddenly dawned on her. Adora glared.

"You know what I'm talking about, right?" Catra said nervously, their wide set jaw clenching. Adora nodded, wanting to pull away. Catra continued with sparkling eyes. "The hills, your home. Adora..." Catra sighed, "I think it will be good for you - for everyone. I see how it haunts you Adora, but I don't think you know how much they love you back there, how much better it would be to let them know you're alive, with or without the riches."

Adora did *not* like this one bit. But Catra's instincts were usually on the mark.

"Besides," they said slyly " I've never been to a forest, you know. Maybe you could show me around?"

Adora rolled her eyes. She never should have told Catra how their fur looked like rosewood and reminded her of the forest. It gave way to thoughts of Catra frolicking in fields, chasing butterflies and birds like a happy kitten, bounding up and down trees while screaming with delight. Catra meeting her hometown, the awkwardness, children wanting to let Catra's tail, feeding them delicious food - taking Catra to her favorite secret places, the

creeks, the caves - climbing trees, looking at flowers, waking up before sunrise -arg, dammit! It was too sweet.

Adora sighed, glaring over at her mate, gorgeous, scruffy Catra, sitting there with a head full of messy curls, shirtless, muscles and fur glowing in the soft light.

"Fine. I'll think about it. I'm going to bed." Adora said abruptly and turned away from Catra, towards the wall. She listened to Catra quietly extinguish the lanterns and draw the curtian, then slip under the covers and pull her tight, pressing a gentle kiss to the back of her head. "Think about it, baby." They whispered in a rasp.

Adora grunted back, then slipped into dreams of rolling hills, morning mist, walking through forests of rosewood with Catra by her side, hand in hand.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading everyone!
I hope you enjoyed this little AU as much as I did. It was a great soothing fic to write during these times. Feel free to drop me a line in the comments.

Sending much love to all of you - take care of yourselves.

End Notes

Did you enjoy? Please leave a comment! Seriously, it helps me know someone is reading out there!

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